



KENNY WRIGHT

BULL'S EYE 4

Consequences of the Hotwife Fantasy



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Kenny Wright



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Preface

This is the fourth book of a five-part series called Bull's Eye. If you haven't read the previous stories, I would highly recommend stopping here and going back. This book will be a lot more impactful if you do.

Also, to set some expectations, this book is all about Heather Kingsley-Fletcher and what her life has been like up to the pivotal moment at the end of book 3. In fact, the working title for this book was, for the longest time, "Manhattan."

This is the moment in the arc where we take a moment to pause, to catch our breath, and reflect, so I'll do some of my own here in this preface.

This series has been a labor of love for years. It began a long time ago, before I even conceived of previously published books like *Rose Blooms* and *Annie's Affair*. I can't believe that we're here, near the end, and I just want to thank you, the reader, for coming along with me on this journey. It's not your typical "hotwife" book. In fact, I'm not even sure I'd call it a hotwife book at all. But it's erotica, and it's a story of human frailty and temptation, and I hope that it scratches some of those itches for you.

I do have more straight-forward hotwife novels in the hopper after this series is done. My hiatus won't be as long as it was before I began to publish these.

If you want to show support beyond purchasing, leaving a review wherever you purchased your book is the best, most impactful thing you could do. I don't pay for advertising and rely on word-of-mouth, reviews, and the algorithms of the book marketplaces to be discovered.

Thanks again. We're almost there. Just two more books to go. Enjoy!

■

Paul

Saying goodbye to Manhattan

“Go back to sleep,” she whispers. In the darkness of my bedroom, she’s no more than a shadow. I can still feel her lips on mine. Still feel her body in my arms, slight yet strong, smooth and as warm as a breeze on a summer day.

“Stay.” But I know that she won’t. She can’t.

“I need to go.”

She does. She has a whole other life, and a husband waiting for her back there—a husband with a jealous streak who’s still figuring out what it means to be a hotwife husband.

“You going to be okay?”

“Yeah.” She’s not sure. I hear the forced optimism. “It’s fine.”

Or maybe it’s not forced optimism at all. Maybe it’s just the way things are. This was a casual thing between two consenting adults. Nothing less, nothing more.

“I’m sorry, I just didn’t mean to fall asleep.”

I nod, drape my arm behind my head and watch her get dressed in the dark, gathering her things. All I want to do is take her back into bed and relive what we shared. But that’s not our fate. Instead, I say, “We had a lot to drink there.”

“I’ll see you in Las Vegas, Paul.”

“Yeah. See you then, Manhattan.”

“Bye, Jameson.”

I’m an idiot for thinking that this could be more, or that what we shared tonight was something special. I’m just the bull. I’m just a man here to give her a good, hard fuck. There will be others after me, and there will always be her husband, there to take her back when her blood cools and she’s once again Heather Kingsley-Fletcher.

As the door shuts gently behind her, so does my dream of domesticity, of a life with Manhattan. This is how this works. It’s the only way this works. Call it the curse of the bull, but my role is not the one that ends with the girl.

I turn over and try to catch some sleep, the warmth of her body already cooling in the sheets beside me.

■

A Shoulder to Cry On

I park my car outside Eleanor Heller's home. It's late. Four in the morning, and out here, deep in the suburbs, it feels even later. Getting out, I wish I grabbed more sensible shoes before leaving.

Leaving? That's not what I'm really doing, right? Not after seven good years of marriage with Joshua. We just had a fight. We've had fights before when it came to this game. I just need some space.

The knot in my stomach tightens. I pull my raincoat around me and squeeze the phone in its pocket as I do my best not to think of the reason for that fight, and how good it felt to fall asleep in his arms.

The door opens before I'm halfway up the drive. Eleanor is standing there, clutching a bathrobe to her chest. I want to cry when I see her. My friend. The only friend I can turn to. She meets me in the rain, clutching me to her. I don't think about the woman with the wild stories. Right now, in this moment, she's in mom mode. I welcome the nurturing.

"Come on, Heather, let's get you inside."

I sniffle. "I'm sorry to bother you." Then I remember the photo I saw, briefly, on Paul's phone last night. Before anything happened. God, that felt so long ago. "Is... he still here?"

He. Mason Coles, the only African American on the board of directors, who was fucking this sweet woman in front of me in that photo I saw. Maybe this was a mistake. If he's still here—

"Please, none of that now."

I lean into her British accent, like she's Mary Poppins or something. That thought makes me laugh. I let her lead me into her home.

She's already got a kettle on the stove. "I'm making some tea. Do you want some?"

I could use something a whole lot stronger, but tea is a better idea. I nod. She hasn't even asked me what's wrong, why I'm here, why I texted her in the middle of the night. That will come soon. The whole story. All of it. First, tea.

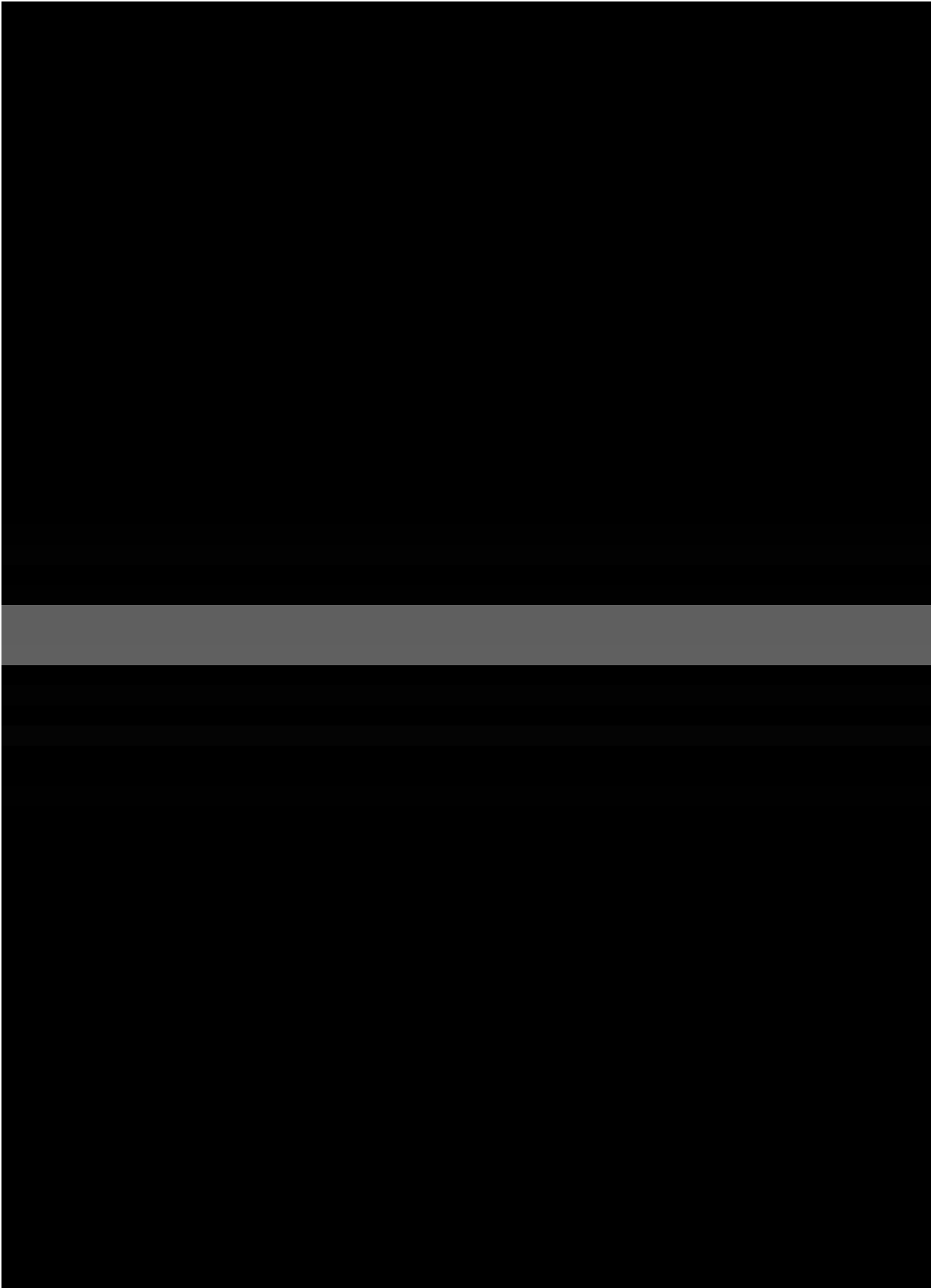
"You're a little taller than me, but I put a set of pajamas in the guest bedroom. Why don't you go get dressed. I'll be here, tea ready."

I hug Eleanor again. This is too much. I've asked too much. I leave her, find the guest bedroom on the ground floor of their spacious home. The pajamas she's set out are long and plaid red, like they're from a Christmas set. I can imagine the entire Heller family wearing matching pajamas and opening presents. The Rockwellian image makes me want to laugh and cry all at once.

I take the PJ set into the bathroom, daring myself to look at my reflection. My blond hair's a tangled mess, dry now from the shower that feels like another person's life. My makeup is gone and my eyes are puffy. Back when I put on this dress, it looked classy on me. Now, it looks as cheap as I feel.

I strip out of it, turning my back from my naked form as I pull on the flannel material. It's a nightgown, long and warm and amorphous. Right now, it couldn't be more perfect.

I splash water on my face and take a deep breath. You can do this. You have to do this. "First day of the rest of my life, right?"



Eleanor has set out the tea in the front room, along with a plate of shortbread cookies. A gas fire burns in their fireplace, bathing the room in warm, welcoming light. Eleanor yawns, but brightens when she sees me.

“Go to bed,” I tell her. “We can talk in the morning.”

She waves the idea away. “Sit. Relax. Talk.”

Where to begin? So much has happened tonight—an entire life’s worth of ups and downs.

I try and gather my thoughts. I fucked Paul. It was amazing and transcendent and tragic. I was transported, and yet in the end, I was used.

I don’t know where to begin. Eleanor helps.

“You slept with Paul.”

I flush. Nod.

“And you told your husband.”

I nod again, smaller, barely moving.

“And Joshua flipped out.”

“Not exactly.” If it only was so simple. I think of Paul, and what we did—of the fantasy of us for one brief and glowing moment before it all came back to earth.

“Joshua didn’t quite flip out. I think... I think that he set it all up.”

Eleanor cocks her head, not following.

I sigh. “You know how I was flirting with a few guys on DeBauch, right? Not just Paul?”

“Sure. That’s kind of how that app goes.”

“There was one guy in particular that I was hitting it off with. Thomas. Despite how hard he took it when he thought I hooked up with ‘Jameson’ after the club,

Joshua still encouraged me to go and meet up with this guy for drinks.”

“Not at all surprising,” Eleanor says. She knows how this goes. Her husband, Ronald, is even more into this fantasy than Joshua. “Men have short memories when their cocks do the thinking.”

“Maybe I have a cock then, because apparently I have a short memory, too. I went for it. Not to hook up with this guy or anything, but... you know how it is.”

“The potential is so exciting,” she helps.

“Yes, exactly. And doing it with Joshua. That’s just it. The best times were when he was there.” Or Paul, I initially don’t say. “But this time, he suddenly couldn’t make it. Some meeting pops up and he needs to be down in Richmond that night. I decided to postpone, right, but he insists that I go anyway.”

“Okay.”

I pinch the bridge of my nose. “I think he knew that I’d ask Paul to come along. I’m almost certain that he’s been spying on my texts and emails, so he knew that Paul was Jameson from the beginning.”

Eleanor puts the rest together. “The date with the guy ended in disaster, but then Paul swept in.”

“Yeah.”

“And you think your husband set that up?”

“I don’t know.” I cover my face with my hands. “I don’t know anything right now. All I know is that he wasn’t surprised when I came home and told him that I was with Paul, and that he did all of this without talking to me. He took matters into his own hands.”

“Because he thought you’d resist.”

“At least we could have had a conversation about it,” I snap at her. Then remember my surroundings. The family sleeping upstairs. “Sorry.”

“Don’t worry. They can’t hear.” She regards me motherly. “And I’m not taking

his side. If Ronald did something like that to me..." She trails off, shaking her head.

"But he wouldn't have, because you and Ronald are in this together. This is your adventure, together. With Joshua, it's like he looks at this whole fantasy as a problem that he can solve—or manipulate into solving. He's always made this thing about him."

"He never stopped to find out what you think."

"Right. And maybe, if he had, he would have discovered that I was into it all just as much." It's something I've never actually said out loud, but feels good to finally admit. "But he's always been like that. For a man with such confidence, he has a hard time being straight forward."

It's what I like so much about Paul—a thought that I immediately bury.

"Tell me how it started," Eleanor prompts.

"Oh, it's a long story."

"I can make as much tea as we need."

I look at her, at her smooth cheeks and welcoming smile. She's also in pajamas, a warm shirt and pants in pink, striped flannel. I cast my memory back to that first time, to the moment when Joshua came to me with his fantasy. I've never spoken about it before. Never thought I had to. But as I begin to speak, I realize how much I want to tell it.

■

David

Before there was Paul, before I even knew what a “hotwife” was, there was David. He was trouble.

David worked for Joshua at the law firm. Junior associate. He was like a younger version of my husband—26-years-old, Stanford educated, drove a BMW, cockier than what he was good for. He was exactly the kind of man I hated, so naturally I was attracted to him.

We were at this gala for one of the partners at Joshua’s law firm. This partner threw a huge ball for his birthday every year. Black tie, evening gowns, catering, three string band. Totally over the top. Joshua was pushing for partner at the time, so we always went.

I still remember the dress I wore that evening—a halter dress, long and black with a slit up the front that parted each time I took a step. It was backless, so I couldn’t wear a bra with it, and I remember being so self-conscious about that. My boobs were practically falling out of the sides, too. I wore it hoping to get a rise out of Joshua, but he barely noticed.

That was happening a lot those days. We’d been together for nearly five years, married for three of them. We were both focused on our careers—he was pushing to make partner at his law firm and I was dealing with the steep learning curve of running my own PR agency. I was 28, Joshua was 38, and what once felt like a fun generational gap began to feel more like a gulf.

When we got to the party, Joshua left me alone so he could smoke cigars and drink Scotch with the rest of the good old boys. This was the typical M.O. of these events. I used to hang around him, but didn’t like feeling like a trophy wife, and the conversation never veered into territory that I could contribute to.

So I started hanging out with David, who was more than happy to keep me company. That night was no different.

“Alone again?” With his broad shoulders and dark hair, David looked like he was born to wear a tux. “If I had a wife like you, there’s no chance I’d leave you alone. Not in this crowd.”

I raised an eyebrow. “Oh? This crowd can’t be trusted?”

David had a nice, boyish grin. We were standing at the top of the stairs that led down into the back of the estate where the party was being held. Party-goers stood in groups around a long reflecting pool that glowed with floating lanterns. The crowd was flirty and fun, dressed for the summer evening affair.

“No, definitely not,” David said. “So many guys here just looking to get laid.”

“Just the guys, huh?” See, this is the type of relationship that we have. David brought out a side of me that I just couldn’t help—much like Paul would years later. “And that’s not you, David? You’re not just looking to get laid tonight?”

“Depends on a lot of things.” He didn’t quite give me a once over, but I knew what he was thinking. I’d been dealing with men like this since puberty, and while it was fun to flirt, I was married.

For whatever reason, though, that night, I didn’t resist as strongly as I should have. I was feeling lonely and neglected, and this good looking, charming guy was harmlessly hitting on me. Fine. It felt nice. A reminder that I still had it.

I looked out over the back lawn below, pretending to watch the crowd while giving David time to look at me. I even shifted, holding my glass and pretending to wave at someone so he’d know, without a doubt, that I wasn’t wearing a bra.

“So David, no date tonight?”

“Nope. Tonight, I’m a single man.”

“Sorry to hear that. What happened to... that Asian model you were dating.”

“Lei. Didn’t work out.”

“I’m sorry.”

“Don’t be. We had fun. Just ran its course.”

Without meaning to, David touched a nerve. Joshua and I—had our relationship just run its course? I wasn’t his first wife, but until recently, I never thought this marriage we had was finite. I met him at a point in my life when I needed a man like that—worldly, mature, yet confident enough in himself that he didn’t fall all over the place to talk to me.

But now, maybe what I saw as confidence was just self-conceit. He never apologized for leaving me alone at these things. He never seemed to express remorse. I was pretty sure that he was still attracted to me, though. We always had a great night following these parties, and he always complimented me on my dresses—moments before tearing them off me. Still...

“You miss those days?” David asked, mis-reading my thoughtfulness for nostalgia.

“Hm?” I turned, and he was right there, standing close. His eyes were not on me, but the back patio and reflecting pool. Still, I knew that from his vantage, it was easy for him to look down my dress.

“Having fun. Do you miss it?”

I laughed. Spoken like a true bachelor. A man who couldn’t see beyond his own world view. I put a hand on David’s face. It was smooth, clean shaven. I liked that. Made me wonder what else was nicely groomed. The illicit thought was there and gone in a flash. “I don’t expect you to understand, but we still have fun. It’s just different now.”

We may not hit the clubs together, but we take trips to Napa and Sonoma. He has a family home on Martha’s Vineyard we visit during the summer. We talk about politics and philosophy, where to ski next winter, what new restaurants are opening. Things I just can’t imagine talking about with David. Things I don’t think I could live without anymore.

David didn’t get it. He shook his head. “Now, he leaves you by yourself in a smoking hot dress like that.”

I leaned closer, letting him smell my perfume. Letting him want me even more. I whispered, “And at the end of the night, he’ll take me home, peel it off, and discover that I’m wearing nothing underneath.” I laughed at the way his jaw went slack, then started down the stairs. “Come along, David. Let’s go mingle some.”

We mingled. We drank. Mostly, we stuck together. David was a fun guy, like I said, and he also seemed to have the inside track on the gossip. He knew which secretaries were fucking their bosses and which trophy wives were sleeping around.

“See the brunette over there, talking to the guy in the white tuxedo?” he said to me. I did. The man in the white tuxedo was, in fact, a black guy I recognized from other events. Some big client of the firm’s. “They’re fucking.”

“No way. How do you know?”

“Just look at them. Tell me I’m wrong.”

I watched as the brunette put a hand on the guy’s arm as she laughed at whatever he said. I knew the signs, too, and if they weren’t lovers now, they’d be soon. It was so wrong, yet it set a spark off between my thighs. They were so casual about it, and David was so casual in the telling.

“She’s the wife of one of the senior associates, and I know for a fact that she’s not the most faithful.”

I turned to him. “You know for a fact, huh?”

“For a fact.” He smiled at me, looking proud. “She’s got a little tattoo on the inside of her rib cage of three birds in flight, and she likes being choked. Allegedly.”

My pussy was definitely feeling something warm. My heart sped up. I searched for a comeback, something playful and witty and smart. Before I could think of anything, the sky lit up with a bang so loud that I almost ducked.

Fireworks blossomed above, whistling and exploding across the man-made pond that backed up to the estate. The show had begun. David, however, was still looking at me as if he didn’t hear them, didn’t see them. I blushed beneath that

gaze.

“Come on, let’s get a closer look,” I said, taking his arm. We moved with the crowd as they headed into the gardens where the best view of the night sky’s pyrotechnics were. I looked for Joshua, but didn’t see him. He was probably still in the house, still having his guy time.

I frowned at that, grabbing a drink from a passing caterer. I don’t remember how many I had, but was at that point in the night where I stopped caring. More was better. More helped dull that feeling of neglect and the spike of irritation that came with it. If he didn’t want to spend time with me, David would do.

When David put his arm around me, I didn’t take it off. We were bunched in with everyone else, craning our heads as the sky exploded above us. No one was paying attention, and it felt nice. I thought of the brunette and the black man. Thought of his powerful body rutting over her, his dark skin shimmering in the pale light of the moon, his large hand wrapped around her neck as she screamed out an orgasm.

The fireworks show went on. I snuggled closer to David. He had nice, large hands, too. Powerful hands. Hands that I imagined he knew how to use.

The show ended, the crowd dispersed, heading back up to the house. David and I stayed behind, walking toward the pond, where a trail wound through the gardens. The air still smelled like sulfur and excitement. I felt alive, the way I used to feel after a night of partying, but before the real fun began. The way I told myself I didn’t need to feel anymore.

“Look at this fucking place,” David said as we disappeared behind a copse of trees. The pond was shared by several other families with oversized homes. At the edge of this estate sat a boat house with a dock. A pontoon boat was moored there. “Someday, we’ll be celebrating my birthday at a place like this.”

I squeezed his arm, feeling his thick biceps there. “You planning on marrying an heiress?”

“I don’t know. Does she have a winning personality?”

I laughed. It felt good. We’d stopped walking. When had we stopped walking? He turned to face me, and suddenly it became hard to breathe. I knew what came

next—something very, very wrong. “David...” I warned.

“Sorry, just...” His eyes moved past me, seeing something. I turned to look, but he already had my hand in his, pulling me along.

“Where are we—”

He put a finger to his lips and guided me swiftly to the boat house. I nearly laughed as we went. It was hard to run in those heels, but I loved the challenge. Again, I was younger, freer, crazier. He pulled me close to him when we huddled under the eaves of the boat house. “Remember that brunette and the black guy? I’m pretty sure they just went in there.”

My heart leapt. “No.”

“Come on.” He crept to the door.

I grabbed at his arm. “We can’t.”

But he’d already started opening it. Mercifully, it swung inward on silent hinges. He slipped inside, and I followed. Beneath the loud throb of my pulse in my ears, all I could hear was the creak of each floor board beneath our feet and the sound of insects chirping outside. Did they hear us enter?

The boathouse wasn’t huge, but it was big enough that there were a couple rooms, and a couple of entrances. We’d come in from the back, but another led out onto the pier. Ropes and anchors and machinery clogged the workbenches in this first room. I barely saw any of it, my eyes fixed on the door that led to the second. Where they had to be.

David crept along, looking back at me, his face lit up. The door was open a crack. Still I could hear nothing beyond. I strained my ears, trying to step on my toes alone—something incredibly difficult when wearing four-inch heels.

He got to the door, peered through, then looked back at me.

“What?” I mouthed.

David stood, swinging the door open. It clattered against the wall, and I nearly screamed. I turned to run. To not get caught. David grabbed my arm before I

could flee. “Guess I was wrong,” he said. “They’re not here.”

I looked anyway. The front room, a sitting room that looked out over the pond, was empty. I knew I’d been played, but my adrenaline was up, my blood thick and racing. David pressed up against me, his body hard and warm.

I turned. Looked up at him. Backed up against the door frame, I could have run. I could have put my hand on his chest and told him no. But I didn’t.

We stared at one another, the light of the moon filtering into the shadowy interior of the boathouse. I could hear the water lapping, the rhythmic bump of the pontoon boat against the wooden pier, my own shallow breath.

He leaned down and kissed me, and I didn’t turn away. Didn’t stop him. His lips felt like fire on mine, and when he pressed his tongue against my mouth, I welcomed him. I kissed him back, feeding my hands around the nape of his neck as his own gripped my waist.

He felt so different from my husband. Where Joshua was lean and tall, David was about my height in heels. He was more solid, however, his chest broader, his neck thicker. Getting kissed like that, his body pressing me into the doorframe, felt so sinfully unfamiliar.

“I have wanted you for so long,” he whispered.

My head spun. Things felt woozy, heavy. He kissed my neck and I let him, tilting my head away, baring it. My fingers ran up the back of his head, mussing his slicked, dark hair. When he dropped his head lower, pulling the halter top of my dress aside, again I didn’t stop him. I wanted to feel his mouth on my tits, feel what his tongue could do to my nipples.

Tit bared, he didn’t kiss it. He cupped it, instead, his mouth returning to my lips for another passion-laced kiss. Any disappointment disappeared at his touch. He didn’t squeeze and grope like an unpracticed boy. He caressed. He tweaked. He twisted just enough to get me moaning against him, pushing my chest out harder.

I hadn’t been touched like that in years. Joshua was an amazing lover, don’t get me wrong, and he did some amazing things to me in the bedroom. But he never touched my breasts like that, never took the time to learn them the way David seemed to instinctively, and the thing about my nipples is that they are sensitive.

I've had orgasms just from breast play alone.

Not that I was thinking any of that at the time. Joshua didn't come into this. Only David and the things he was making my body feel.

"You're really not wearing anything under this dress?" he asked.

You'll never know. I had the quip ready to go, right there on the tip of my tongue. But I couldn't release it, and when I felt David's over hand slide into the place where the dress parted around my legs, I lost all thought of stopping it. Instead, I parted my thighs a little more, giving him access.

"Fucking hell, you really aren't," he groaned.

I smiled at his amazement.

"And I knew you'd be shaved."

"Did you now?"

He pushed two fingers into me. I gasped, remembering we're in a semi-public place. I bit back my moan, but his thumb on my clit was almost too much. Again, I marveled at his hands, the way he played me.

"I had a feeling," he said, kissing down the column of my neck again. "You look like a woman..." Down along my collarbone. "...who's got a very naughty side."

When his mouth finally touched down on my nipple, I nearly came right there. I drew him into me, opening my legs wider. The wet slosh of his fingers plunging into my pussy filled the boathouse. I couldn't stay quiet forever, but tried. Tried so hard.

David must have felt my imminent orgasm. Just as I reached my peak, he reached up and covered my mouth with his hand. Even that felt exciting and new.

"You wore this dress to be seen," David hissed. "You didn't put on panties because a part of you wanted me to find out. Admit it." He fingered me faster. I was close. "Say it, slut."

My body wanted it. Craved it. Hungered for it. But my conscience finally broke free. Finally realized what I was doing, who I was betraying. I put on this dress for my husband. I left my panties at home and shaved my pussy smooth for Joshua.

This? This wasn't me. This was not me anymore.

I turned my head away. "No," I said. Shutting my thighs, I squeezed a hand between us and pushed him off of me. "I can't."

"Of course you can," he insisted.

Fear descended on me in that moment. He wasn't going to take no for an answer, and here I was, all alone with him. Powerless. I hated that feeling. Hated feeling trapped, heart beating like a frightened animal.

"David, stop."

He pressed harder against me. What an idiot I was. What a stupid bimbo. Even when I was at my craziest, I never put myself into a situation like this.

"Get off her." Not my voice, but familiar. It was hard, laced with threat.

David was lifted away from me, his weight suddenly gone. Standing there, shoulders heaving, murder in his eyes, was my husband.

-

The First Reclamation

David and I cried at once. “Joshua!” David stiffened, backing away from me.

“Leave,” Joshua said to David. “Now.”

“Josh—” he began.

“Can’t even follow that simple instruction. You’re fired. Clean your office out by Monday. Anything left will be thrown out.”

David looked ready to argue, then looked at me. He was done. He knew it. He’d just tried to fuck his boss’s wife. “Fuck,” he muttered, turned, and left.

Fear, worse than anything I’d ever felt, descended on me now that I was alone with my husband. Fear and guilt and remorse.

“Joshua, I’m sorry—”

Before I could get further, he was there, filling the space that David just left, his mouth pressed to mine.

Confused, emotionally charged, heart trying to beat itself out of my chest, I went with it and gave into the kiss. I was still horny, could still feel David’s illicit touch. It was good to feel Joshua this way, a reminder of something familiar and sexy and right.

I could feel his erection against me, as tempting as it was confusing. I reached down. Through the thin material of his tuxedo trousers, I could almost feel it throb. He was so hard. I needed to feel more, needed to touch it, to feel it inside me.

I pulled the side zipper of the trousers down and shoved the cumerbund to the side. Thrusting my hand into his black briefs, he snarled as I grasped his cock. Our kiss broke. He stared down at me, huffing and dark. Even in the moon-cast shadows, I could see the need in him, the pained desire.

He pinned me harder to the door jam, grabbed a thigh, and hiked it up against him. I gasped. Rarely did Joshua manhandle me like this. It was exciting.

David was gone, a temporary insanity washed away by the lust I had for my husband. Later, I'd learn that this wasn't the case for Joshua. That he was still thinking about David and me and how he'd caught us making out in the quiet of the boathouse. At the time, all I wanted to do was feel my husband's cock and be reminded that I was his.

I pulled his briefs down enough to free his cock. Pulled him close to me as I raised my leg higher. I placed him against my pussy and he thrust forward, burying himself to the balls in one motion.

"You're so wet," he groaned.

Embarrassment and shame warmed me. I was. I couldn't deny it, and had half hoped that he wouldn't notice. But his erection didn't flag, didn't soften. If anything, it swelled inside of me as he began to take me against the door jam.

We'd never had sex in public before. We'd never done anything like this before. I figured this kind of sexual adventure was behind me, and honestly I was fine with that. What we had was so much more than quickies and crazy sex. But this was, without a doubt, one of the hottest nights we'd ever had. Joshua was an animal.

"Uh, fuck me, baby," I moaned. I didn't curse with him. Not often. That night, though, it just felt right, and it seemed to spur him on. He held my leg up, pressing it against the wall as we rotated into the sitting room of the boathouse.

I stood on just one foot, in heels, and the ball of my foot screamed at me. I didn't care. I welcomed the discomfort, the pain that crawled up my leg. I focused on Joshua's cock instead, how he drove into me, how it felt huge and long and so, so good.

"You kissed him," he said through his grunts.

I froze, my body starting to tense up. Joshua didn't let me. He grabbed my hands and pinned them above my head. His face loomed over me, still dark, still angry, still alive with passion. "You kissed him," he repeated.

"I'm sorry—"

He kissed me, silencing my apology. He shoved his tongue into my mouth, like he was out to prove that he was a better kisser, that he was the bigger man.

"Was that the first time? Or have you done that before?" he asked.

"The first. I swear."

His eyes lost focus, and for a second, I thought he'd lose it—either to his climax or his anger. He shut his eyes, sucking air in through his teeth. His squeezed my pinned hand harder. I gasped.

"You two haven't been fucking behind my back?"

The accusation struck me like a blow across the face. How could he think that? How could he—

"You wore this dress for him tonight, didn't you?"

"No—"

"You went right to him. You were with him the whole night."

"Joshua, I—"

"You couldn't wait to get your hands on him."

No, no, this was all wrong. I didn't. I wouldn't. The protests caught in my brain, getting all gummed up. Joshua kept fucking me. His face turned red, bright against his salt-and-pepper hair. He was going to come. Whatever he thought of me and David, he was going to come!

"Admit it. A part of you wanted to fuck him."

Before I could protest, tell him no, no, no, Joshua thrust home one last time, hard enough to lift me off my heels. He pinned me to the wall, holding my hands

above my head and my knee up against my ribcage. He exploded inside of me, and with that, I lost it, too.

I didn't want to fuck David. I didn't. Yet as Joshua's shaft pulsated inside of me and his heat filled my pussy, I did think of David, I did think about his strange cock and how it would have felt inside of me. I did think of the old days, when I was free to fuck, when every party, every outing, was an adventure ready to happen.

My body sizzled. The tension never died, but added to the strange highs we were both feeling. I groaned, tight and frozen against the door jam and my husband shuddered against me. We held each other, melted into one another. My lips sought his. This time our kiss was softer, gentler, more loving.

Joshua opened his eyes, seeing me as if for the first time. The jealousy and pain was still there, and my heart fell seeing that. But he didn't push me away or call me a whore. He didn't send me packing like he did David.

"Let's go home," he said instead.

I nodded. Home. There was still a home for me. For us. And at that moment, I vowed never to jeopardize that again.

■

Confessions

We didn't make our customary goodbyes. There were no air kisses and back-patting hugs. We just left, abrupt and quiet and quickly. Things between us were tense again. Guilt settled on me like a low-grade fever. Questions swirled in the quiet between us.

In the car, I finally built up the nerve to call him on it. "Joshua, say something."

The engine of the Mercedes purred to life. We pulled out, the gravel drive crunching beneath the wheels. He didn't say anything until we'd pulled onto the road.

"How long has it been going on?" He was calm, but I could see his jaw working, clenching and grinding.

"It hasn't. There's nothing going on—"

"Sure looked like something tonight," he snapped.

That shut me up. He was right. As much as I wanted to play it off, he was right. "Nothing happened—until tonight I mean. Joshua, I swear."

"But?" He heard it.

"But I guess David's been flirting with me since the Christmas party. I never took it seriously. Guys are just like that."

"You flirt with other guys?"

"No," I said defensively. "Just..." I didn't know how to talk about this without sounding completely conceited. I put my hand on Joshua's thigh, squeezing it

gently. “I love you, baby. And only you. Guys hit on me, but I never reciprocate.”

“If what I saw tonight wasn’t reciprocating, I’m scared of what is—”

“I’m sorry, okay?” My voice rose. It wasn’t fair of me, but he wasn’t listening. “I fucked up. I was drunk, and feeling neglected, and was a dumb, silly slut. Is that what you want to hear?”

He drove in silence, shutting down. I hated when he did this. We didn’t fight often, but whenever things got really heated, Joshua had the annoying habit of disengaging.

I watched him, and he knew it, making a point to look everywhere but in my direction—even when turning right.

I groaned loudly. “Don’t do that. Please, honey.”

He took a deep breath. I readied myself for the fire, the fury. Instead, I got an apology. “I’m sorry.”

It threw me.

“I’m sorry you felt neglected.”

It’s telling how surprised I was that he’d actually heard that. It’s been that way for a while now. “What’s happening to us, Joshua? How did we get here?”

He was quiet, and at first I thought that the wall was back up. Watching him, willing him to speak, I didn’t see the simmering anger that usually came with those bottled up silences. He looked nervous.

Again, I put a hand on his leg. I wanted to close this gulf. I wanted to reconnect, but he had to let me. “Joshua, talk. Please. What’s on your mind.”

He took a breath, as though ready to speak. Still, it took him a full minute before the words came. “I...suspected something might happen. With David.”

“What?”

“I’ve seen you two together. I watched how he looks at you.”

I blinked at him. I didn’t understand.

“I knew that it was only a matter of time before something would happen.” It’s only now, years later, that a statement like that would really sink in. Back then, I was just confused.

“You...knew? You knew and you kept ignoring me?”

“I wasn’t ignoring you.”

Anger flared. “That’s bullshit, and you know it. I feel like we’ve barely seen each other lately. Tonight, you just...disappeared. Again. You always disappear. If that’s not ignoring me—”

“I was watching you,” he barked. I stopped. Looked at him. He looked angry at his own words, glaring at me beneath a pinched brow. “I was watching you all night.”

I just shook my head, not getting it, which was frustrating. I usually got things like this. “I don’t understand.”

We pulled into our driveway. We were home, but neither of us made a move to get out of the car. Joshua turned to me, and he looked more in control again.

“I have a fantasy that I’ve never told you before.”

“Oh...kay.”

“It turns me on to think of you with other men.”

I shook my head, still not comprehending. It was like he was speaking a different language, despite all the individual words coming out in English. “You want to try swinging?”

“Not exactly. It’s more like...just you.”

“And another man.” I tried not to sound quite so flat, but I was feeling numb.

“Yeah.” He squeezed my hand. “Come on, let’s get inside. I’ll explain more.”

I followed. I didn't know what else to do, but all of a sudden it felt like I was living with a stranger. Joshua was a jealous man. It was kind of a problem when we first started dating. I had to watch myself when other guys were around, pay special attention to him and make sure everyone knew I was taken. When we got engaged, it became easier. I just needed to flash my ring... with most guys, anyway.

But this fantasy? Him wanting to watch me with other guys? It didn't make sense.

I got out of the car and followed him in, more shaky on my heels now than I was at my most tipsy earlier tonight.

Joshua headed upstairs, to the bedroom. I needed a glass of water first. I took a detour into our kitchen—a beautiful, open concept one we'd renovated together. Seemed like a different lifetime.

I poured two glasses and followed him upstairs. I paused just inside the doorway to watch as he pulled off his tuxedo jacket. I saw him like the kitchen, something familiar that looked new once again. He wasn't built like David. Wasn't dark and dashing like some men I've been with, or beautiful like others. But Joshua had a magnetism that drew me to him. He commanded a room, not with charm or a sharp sense of humor, but with something harder to quantify.

It didn't hurt that he was pretty easy on the eyes, handsome in a way that young men cannot be—the kind that looked good holding a glass of whiskey and wearing a suit. Or a tuxedo shirt. Even the gray that was creeping more and more into his temples suited him.

Beneath the crisp, white tuxedo shirt, he wore a tank top that accentuated his trim shoulders and long, sinewy arms.

“You coming in? Or just going to stare?”

Joshua did what so few men could before—he made me tremble, made me feel like I needed to work for him, not the other way around. It took me years to realize that this isn't necessarily a healthy thing. I guess I'm still coming to grips with that.

I offered him a glass of water.

“No thanks.” He picked a glass of Scotch. “I’m good.”

I nodded, going to my side of the bed and setting the glasses on the nightstand. For the first time in years, I wished I had a cigarette.

Joshua joined me, carrying his drink over to sit by my side. When he offered me a sip, I took it, even though I’m not a huge fan of peaty whiskey. He watched me drink, thinking through how to start this conversation.

I helped him out, tired of this being so drawn out. “So you were saying something about me with other men?”

Joshua chuckled. “It’s a thing, yeah. Called being a ‘hotwife.’ I get excited at the thought of you and other guys.”

I started to speak, decided to finish his Scotch off in one go, and tried again. “Is this a test? Are you testing me?”

“I mean, I watched you make out with another guy, and we’re still talking.”

It was absurd. So absurd that I started laughing. Joshua laughed along, but his heart wasn’t in it, and I was just feeling hysterical.

“I’ve actually been watching you since the Christmas party. When you wore that red sequin dress, he couldn’t take his eyes off you.”

“No one could,” I said with a shy smile. I usually wear my self-confidence like a tailored coat. With Joshua, it always turns to self-consciousness. “Although I didn’t think you noticed the dress.”

“Oh, I noticed.” He turned to me. “So sexy with those criss-crossing straps along the back. You couldn’t wear a bra with it.” He leaned down and kissed my shoulder. “Like this one.”

“You do remember.”

He slipped a hand beneath the haltered front, cupping my bare breast. “I do.” He ran kisses along my neck, up to my ear, where a pair of chandelier earrings dangled. “I think I like this dress more though. It has some nice...features.”

With a hand on my knee, he caressed up the inside of my thigh, following the center slit.

“Makes me pretty accessible.”

I sighed as he found the slit of the dress. “If memory serves, you wore a tiny, red thong that night.”

“That you tore off when we got home.”

“Because I got jealous of the way you were talking to David that night “

His hand crawled higher. My body tensed as I fought to keep focus on this conversation. “See, that’s where I lose you. You say that you want it, yet you also get so jealous.”

“Because I am jealous. It’s actually a big part of it.” His fingers found my pussy. I gasped. “The more jealous I feel, the more turned on I get.”

He kissed my neck, zeroing in on my most erogenous spots. It was like he had a direct line to my libido—that spot just behind the corner of my jaw, how to rub his fingers along my g-spot, how to work my clit with the soft padding of his thumb.

“I watched you tonight. Flirting with David. Watching the fireworks as he watched you.” His voice was calm, a whisper against my ear. His fingers slowly worked in and out of me, drawing out the story. “When you disappeared down that path with him and didn’t come right back, I was so jealous.”

He found the clasp of the dress behind my back, flicking it open. It fell away, baring my tits. He drank them in, and they hardened even more beneath the attention.

“I thought I was going to have a heart attack as I followed.” He leaned down, wrapping his lips around a nipple. Unlike David, Joshua had discovered just how sensitive they were. He worked me until I dug my fingers into his hair, gasping and shockingly close to climax.

When I was on the edge, he pulled away—lips from my breasts, fingers from my pussy. “No,” I cried, trying to keep him close, keep him there. He was too

strong. He shoved me onto my back, grabbing at my crumpled dress. With a yank, it was past my hips and I was naked and splayed out for Joshua.

“When I walked into the boathouse and heard you two...” He shivered, then pulled his tank top off. “I felt torn in two.”

Beneath his pants and boxers, he was fully erect. This couldn’t be a test. At least part of him was turned on. His cock was much like the rest of him, long and slender and hard.

He put a knee on the bed, between my legs. “That wet, smacking sound of kissing...” He crawled closer. “Clothes rustling.” Crawling over me, his cock against my pussy. He rubbed my clit with it. Resting his head on mine, our eyes locked. “My wife moaning.”

I gasped as he pressed that hard cock against my opening. I was so close. So on edge. But it was more than that. His words, the idea of doing something so illicit, so naughty—it insinuated through me. Infused me.

He sank into me as his fantasy worked into my mind, into my lust. He was so into it, which made it a string that I wanted to pluck.

“Tell me tonight wasn’t the first time. I won’t be mad.”

“Joshua, I...” I gasped. I couldn’t. I hadn’t.

“Tell me you and David have met before. That you saw him at the annual banquet. Snuck away with him for a quick fuck in the coat closet.”

“Joshua...” I had seen David then, and it had been much like tonight. Joshua had disappeared, and I was bored. But nothing had happened.

“I saw you then, too. Saw you dance with him. Saw you two whispering. Where did you go that night?”

I shook my head. The veranda. David wanted to smoke. I kept him company.

Joshua’s thrusts started coming faster, harder. He dug his elbows into the pillow on either side of my head. He watched me. Watched as my climax built beneath him.

“You shaved your pussy tonight. Why? For David, right? You left your panties at home for him. Say it.”

“Yes,” I lied. That must have been what it felt like when a jockey whipped a horse. Joshua went wild, driving his hips down, burying that long cock deep inside of me. “Yes, David likes me shaved.” It wasn’t even a lie, but a fact about the younger man shouldn’t have known.

I ran my hands down his back to squeeze his ass. He had such a nice, cute little butt. I could feel it clench with each, powerful drive. “He likes feeling nothing but smooth, wet skin when we fuck.”

“Ah!” Joshua groaned.

I braced for his climax. Somehow, he held off. My turn to groan. I wanted it. I needed it. All of a sudden, I started thinking about David plowing me, his thick, muscled frame slamming into me.

Joshua pulled out, flipping me over before re-entering from behind.

“Think about him.” Joshua grabbed my hips. “Think about David’s cock.”

I did. I squeezed my eyes shut and imagined David there, taking me hard. I reached between my legs, found my clit. I moaned as David took me harder. We were back in the boathouse. I was bent over a piece of furniture, dress hiked up as the younger man fucked me from behind.

“Fuck babe, that’s it.” David was there, but not. “Play with yourself just like that. Play with yourself as you think about another man inside of you.”

I danced my fingers against my clit in rapid little slaps. Just the way I liked it—a little rough, a little demanding. Just the way Joshua knew how to fuck me. The way I imagined David fucking me now.

“Fuck me...” I gasped. Then, mostly because I knew it would excite him, I added, “...David.”

Joshua snarled, his thrusts slapping against me, his cock feeling huge with each ram. “Ah, Heather!” he gasped.

“Come. I need your come. Come, baby.”

He was there. Thrusting one last time. Thrusting so deep it hurt. My breath caught. My brain turned to fuzz as his cock went off, my own orgasm cascading with his.

I flopped forward, spent. He crawled into the space beside me, rolling onto his back. His skin was hot where he pressed close. I could feel his heart racing.

“That was...” He paused to catch his breath. “Wow.”

In the afterglow of our mutual orgasm, some of the things we’d said started to filter back. Some of the things I’d said.

“Joshua, David and I...”

“I know.” He propped himself onto an elbow. I turned to look at him, folding my hands beneath my head like a pillow.

“We’ve never—”

“You never until tonight.”

Shame roared through me like a blast of heat. “I am so, so sorry.”

“It’s fine, Heather. It’s fine.” It wasn’t fine. It shouldn’t be fine. I started to say as much. Joshua spoke first. “I know nothing happened. I was there, remember. I saw you tell him no.”

“I should have told him earlier.”

“And I think it’s hot that you didn’t.” He ran his hand down my back, tracing the tattoo etched low on my tailbone—a small princess tiara. “I think it’s hot that you were tempted.”

His eyes drifted to the tattoo, too. He liked it as much as it embarrassed me. When I’d offered to get it lasered off, he told me not to. Told me it was a sexy reminder of the vixen I could be.

“I will never cheat on you, Joshua. Never. I swear. I’m not... I’m not that

woman anymore.”

He stroked my back a moment longer before smiling and letting it go. “Of course not.”

He didn’t believe me. Or, possibly more accurately, he didn’t want to believe me. It didn’t matter. Not tonight. I knew better than to argue with him when he got like this, and he was in a good mood.

“Good night, dear.”

He smiled, kissed me warmly, and we climbed beneath the sheets. “Night, love. Thanks for tonight.”

-

Melody

The next morning, I dragged myself out of bed. A reminder of last night's drinks hammered the inside of my skull. Joshua lay face down and passed out, snoring peacefully. The wreckage of the night before was strewn about the bed—my dress, Joshua's tuxedo, the empty glass of Scotch.

Bleary eyed, I barely saw it on my way to the bathroom, to the shower. I needed to feel hot water on my body, to wash away the fog I was fighting through. To wash away the troubling revelations that had come out.

I'd almost cheated. I'd come so fucking close. I'd let a man, who I'd been flirting with for months, lead me away from the party, to a place where no one would see us, where we could be alone. Then I hadn't pushed him away when he'd kissed me. When he'd slipped his hand up under my dress.

The shower couldn't wash that memory away. Worse, I started to respond to the fantasy like some kind of whore. Like a woman I swore I'd never be again.

I soaped myself, like I could scrub her away, rubbing my skin with the luffa until I was pink and raw. Passing my hand across my pussy, even that betrayed me. "You shaved your pussy tonight. Why?" Joshua had demanded. "For David, right?"

I hadn't. Had I? Doubt crept in. I'd let things go over the last few months. Joshua and I had been so wrapped up in our jobs, in other things. We'd neglected our sex life.

"You left your panties at home for him," Joshua had insinuated.

But I hadn't. I'd left them off for Joshua. A sexy secret for him to discover. Not David. Right?

David had discovered it first. I closed my eyes, thinking of David's strong, unfamiliar touch climbing up the inside of my thighs. His fingers were thicker than Joshua's, yet somehow less demanding.

"And I knew you'd be shaved," he'd said. "You look like a woman who's got a very naughty side."

I was. I was that woman. Once. Still? Had I shaved with David in mind? Had a part of me, small and sneaky and so very naughty, thought of the fit, cocky junior lawyer as I'd scraped the stubble off my mound? Or imagined the younger man's eyes on me as I modeled my dress in the dressing room mirror?

Guilt welled up inside of me, and for a second, I felt like I might throw up. Hand splayed on the shower wall, I looked straight up into the spray as I turned the temperature down, down, down. The cold water shocked me out of my nausea. The guilt lingered.

Once, I'd been the kind of woman who had no problem with lingering eyes. I loved to flirt with young, arrogant men, before taking them back to my place and fucking them. It was thrilling to feel the power shift, to look into their faces as they realized that while they thought they were in control, I was.

The excitement was in the power I had over them. Flash a little leg, a playful smile, and they were mine. Did I miss that thrill? Did a part of me want to feel it again?

I shut the water off without answers. My shame was still with me. My remorse stubbornly clinging to me. At least the throbbing in my head had dulled. Some coffee and water would finish it off.

Joshua was still sleeping when I emerged from the bathroom. He'd shifted, laying on his back, facing away from me, his breathing slow. Was he still asleep? Or just pretending?

"I think it's hot that you were tempted," he'd said last night. I fled the room, the memory of his confession chasing me.

Once upon a time, I was pretty wild. I sowed my wild oats. In college. Just after. I've been a part of many fantasies, and fulfilled most of my own. This one was new to me.

A “hotwife”, he’d called it. So many questions swirled, and as I Googled the term and this whole other world opened to me, the questions compounded. How long had he had this fantasy? How had he kept it hidden? Why hadn’t he shared?

When he finally joined me, looking rough, I went ahead and asked. “Why didn’t you tell me about this fantasy of yours?”

He blinked, looking haggard. His hair was awry, all over the place. He had dark bags behind his rimless glasses. I thought I felt bad, but he looked so much worse.

“Coffee,” he croaked. I nodded. He’d thrown on an undershirt, pajama pants, and a robe. It made him look older, more vulnerable. “How do you look so good?” he asked.

“I look good?” I laughed to myself, flipping my hair. “You like my glamorous ponytail?”

He poured himself a mug of coffee. “I do. And those glasses.”

I wore plastic framed nerd girl glasses when my eyes couldn’t handle contacts, and that morning, they definitely couldn’t handle contacts.

“And my sweats?”

“You’d look good in a trash bag.” He leaned on the counter, looking at me thoughtfully.

“You’re thinking about how much leg a trash bag would show, aren’t you?”

He smiled quietly. “Maybe.”

He was in a good mood. Good. I took a deep breath. Joshua knew what I was going to ask before the words were out. His smile faded, replaced once again with wary discomfort. He crossed his arms, his coffee mug tucked under an elbow.

“Why didn’t you tell me about your fantasy before?” I repeated.

“Well, it’s not exactly the kind of thing that comes up in casual conversation.”

His answer came so easily now that he had time to think about it. I could see his litigator brain working.

“But...it’s real? You really...you really fantasize about me being with other men?”

He shrugged, like I was making it a bigger deal than it was. But it was a big deal. Especially from Joshua.

“You were always so jealous.” I remembered those days. Joshua’s jealousy didn’t manifest in paranoia or insecurity. He got possessive. I should have hated it, but at the time, it was what I needed. “And didn’t Melody cheat on you?”

Melody, Joshua’s ex-wife.

“Well, yes.” He sipped his coffee, letting his gaze drift toward the window.

I helped him out. “But there was more to the story.”

He nodded.

I’d seen pictures of Melody. She was blonde, like me, but with a more delicate beauty than I could ever hope for. She would have been at home at an event like the one last night, floating along on Joshua’s arm. I both envied women like that and never wanted to be one. I made it clear, early on, that I wasn’t going to be his trophy wife.

We’d never talked about her, though. I knew things had ended badly, that they only talked now through lawyers and that he always went into a mood when her name came up. But beyond that and some pictures, I didn’t know much.

Now, he watched me carefully as he revealed more. “Melody and I would sometimes play.”

I shouldn’t have been shocked. He’d just admitted that he got off on the idea of me with other men. This was hardly a surprise. But it still was.

“I...see.” I collected myself. “Play as in she was a...hotwife?” Strange and awkward, the word stumbled off my tongue.

“No. Well, not exactly. We would play with other couples.”

“You were swingers.”

“Don’t sound so scandalized.” He started to close himself off again. “We both know you were pretty wild when you were younger. Don’t pretend you’re some shrinking violet.”

“I never said that I was.” I tried not to sound as defensive as I was feeling. He was right, and there was nothing “pretty” about my past. But I still associated that with the immaturity of my youth. What Joshua was talking about was something different. Still, I buried my judgment before he shut this conversation down completely. “Just trying to understand.”

He saw the effort I was putting in. Closing his eyes, he took a deep breath, letting go of something. “Calling us ‘swingers’ makes it sound like we did it more than we did. We didn’t go to parties. We weren’t members of clubs. We only did it a few times, and only ever with a few other couples.”

He was in a zone. I left him there, giving him space to think. To relive. “The first time it happened, it was completely unplanned. We were out with this other couple—Kathryn and Garrett—at one of Melody’s openings.”

“She was an artist?”

“Gallery manager. Garrett actually got her the job—they were old friends. It was after one of the openings, we’d all consumed a lot. One thing led to another and we were back at their place, naked in bed. I knew they played, and I’d always suspected that they’d done it with Melody, but she swears she didn’t. That night, though...”

The look on Joshua’s face was a curious one. I’ll never forget it. He was torn. The memory was a good one, but one that eventually unraveled everything.

“At first, Garrett and I just watched as Melody and Kathryn fooled around. That was sexy. It couldn’t have been the first time between those two—never did ask, though.” He rubbed the skin just beneath his mouth.

He was lost in the retelling, and I was lost right along with him. Like I said, Melody was pretty, and the thought of her neatly coiffed blond hair bouncing

between another woman's thighs had me squeezing my own thighs together.

"Things got more intense when they beckoned us to join them. I went to Melody, Garrett went to Kathryn. But we were all in the same bed, twisting and fucking. The women kept kissing each other. Then Garrett kissed Melody..." He shut his eyes, shuddering. "I'll never forget that feeling. Like having an orgasm at the same time you're being struck by a bolt of lightning. I wanted to tear her off of him, but I was so turned on."

He opened his eyes and seemed surprised to see me sitting there.

"But that was nothing compared to what it was like watching them fuck. Still brings butterflies. Even now."

He refilled his coffee and joined me at the table, where the morning sun was giving way to a brighter day. "After, we laughed it off. It was a good time, we both agreed, but neither of us needed it, you know? Six months later, I come back from a business trip and catch her fucking Garrett in the guest bedroom."

I knew it was coming and still feel the churn of betrayal for my husband. I took his hand in mine, lacing our fingers. I rubbed his wedding band.

"I'm so sorry, Joshua."

"The thing that killed me was that she hid it. I would have been fine with it if she'd just asked, but she hid it."

I wasn't so sure about that part. Like if he said it enough, it would be true. But he was conflicted. He wanted it, but he hated it.

He squeezed my hand and smiled weakly. The memories were gone. The hangover was back. "So you see why it's hard to admit that I still have that fantasy?"

"I get it." I kissed him softly. "But I'm not Melody. I'd never do that to you."

It wasn't what he wanted to hear. I saw the disappointment fall like a shadow across his face. Frustration bubbled up through me, but I held it in check. What did he want me to say? Yes, one day I'll cheat on you and you'll love it before you burn me down?

“You’re definitely not Melody.” He kissed me back, reaching down to squeeze my chest. “You’ve got bigger tits.”

I rolled my eyes, but laughed. “And a nicer butt. Don’t forget about that.”

“It’s not something I’ll ever forget.”

We held each other, looking deeply into each other's eyes. “I’m sorry about last night. And David. I still can’t believe I let that happen.”

“I let that happen, Heather. I put you in that situation. It was our mistake, together.”

I liked that. Together. “Let’s stop making stupid mistakes,” I said. “And let's start talking about our fantasies.”

■

Sleep

Elie tries to hide her yawn, but does a poor job. Through the gauzy curtains, the sky has started to warm, hinting at dawn. It's five-thirty in the morning. Retelling my story has distorted my sense of time. I'd just walked out on my husband a couple hours ago. I'd just had sex with Paul less than five.

"Let's go to bed," I say. "Sorry to keep you up."

"Oh, no, no. Don't apologize," Eleanor says in polite, British fashion.

"Thanks for having me for the night."

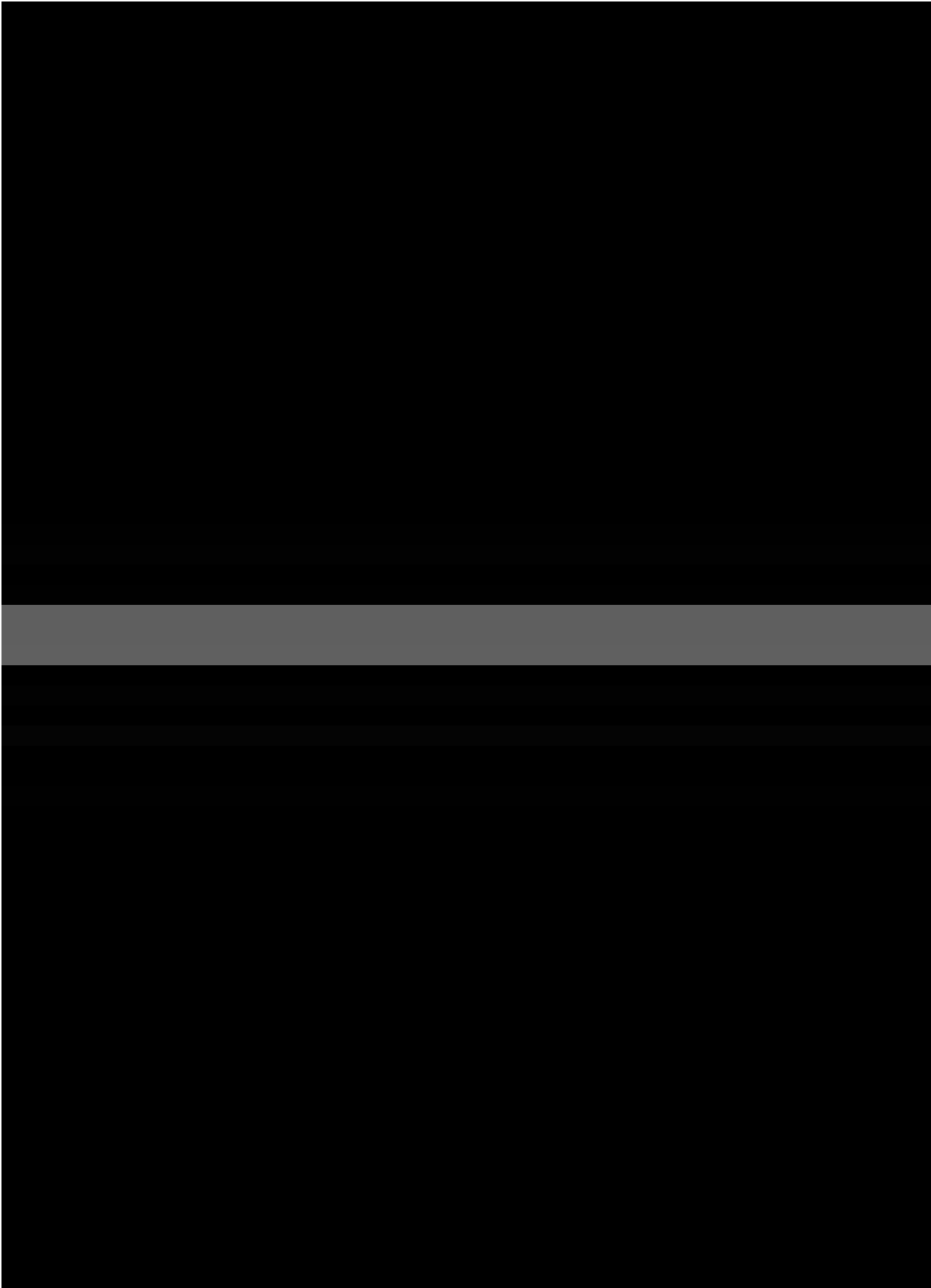
"Stay as long as you'd like. We can set you up in the guest house tomorrow. It's yours for as long as you need." She pats the tops of her thighs, then stands.

"Towels are in the bathroom. There's an extra toothbrush in the top cabinet. Night, Heather. We'll continue this tomorrow."

"Sounds perfect."

In bed, it's hard to sleep. I'm back in time, back to that moment when my life turned on its axis. If I'd only stayed away from David... If I'd only stuck by Joshua's side like a good little Stepford wife... If I'd only found my own female friends at those events... If, if, if.

But I hadn't. Worse, I'd been tempted. Joshua's confession to me, about his fantasy, about his past marriage, awoke something in me back then. A part of me that I'd hoped was buried. If it hadn't, then maybe Joshua would have let his go. Maybe we'd still be normal—just two professionals in love and enjoying one another.



I wake to the sound of Eleanor's kids chatting excitedly to one another just outside my door. "I think there's someone in there," one of them whispered.

"Are you sure, Donny?" the other whispers. "No one was in there last night?"

"Maybe it's the Tooth Fairy."

Despite the lack of sleep and the vague throb of a hangover, I can't help but smile as I listen. A soft laugh slips out.

"Someone is in there, Donny!" comes the excited voice of Eleanor's youngest.

"Shh, Lucas, you'll wake her." If anything, he's louder than his brother. "And we don't want to make the Tooth Fairy angry with us."

I pull myself out of bed and find my bearings. It's disorienting to wake in a strange bed in someone else's house. I'm used to hotel rooms, not lived in spaces like this.

Eleanor's left out a robe and some warm slippers. It warms my heart. I'm half surprised she's not left out a plate of biscuits and a hot cup of tea.

More whispering comes in through the door, but I can't make out what's said beyond their earnestness. It's so freaking cute.

Joshua never wanted to have children. I knew that when we got married, and at the time, I was fine with it. Work was pretty much all I could think about. Now, though, I hear those kids on the other side of the door and feel the tug. Not that I could ever imagine Joshua taking care of a child—or putting anyone beyond himself, for that matter.

Stepping into the slippers and pulling on the warm robe, I open the door to a pair of startled children.

The younger one nearly trips backwards, his eyes wide and bright. "Oh, a pretty lady!"

"She's too tall to be the tooth fairy," the older one says, eyeing me more

analytically.

“Maybe she’s a princess.”

Donny, the older, nods with the seriousness only a child can muster. “Are you Sleeping Beauty?”

The two are dressed in flannel pajamas that match the nightgown I’m wearing—red plaid tops and bottoms. They’re also wearing royal blue robes that make them look so much more mature than their ages of six and four.

“Sometimes I wish I was,” I say, ruffling their soft, brown hair. “No, I’m just a friend of your mommy’s.”

“Are you going to have breakfast with us?” Donny asks.

“If you’ll let me.”

He reaches out and takes my hand. “Come on, I smell bacon!”

I do too. My stomach grumbles. I can’t remember the last time that I had bacon.

I let the children lead me into the kitchen, where Eleanor and Ronald are busy whipping up the kind of breakfast I’m used to having at a restaurant. In addition to the bacon, there are eggs and muffins and pancakes. I think of all the carbs, and all the work I’ll have to put in at the gym after. Then stop caring when Eleanor comes to me and pulls me into her arms.

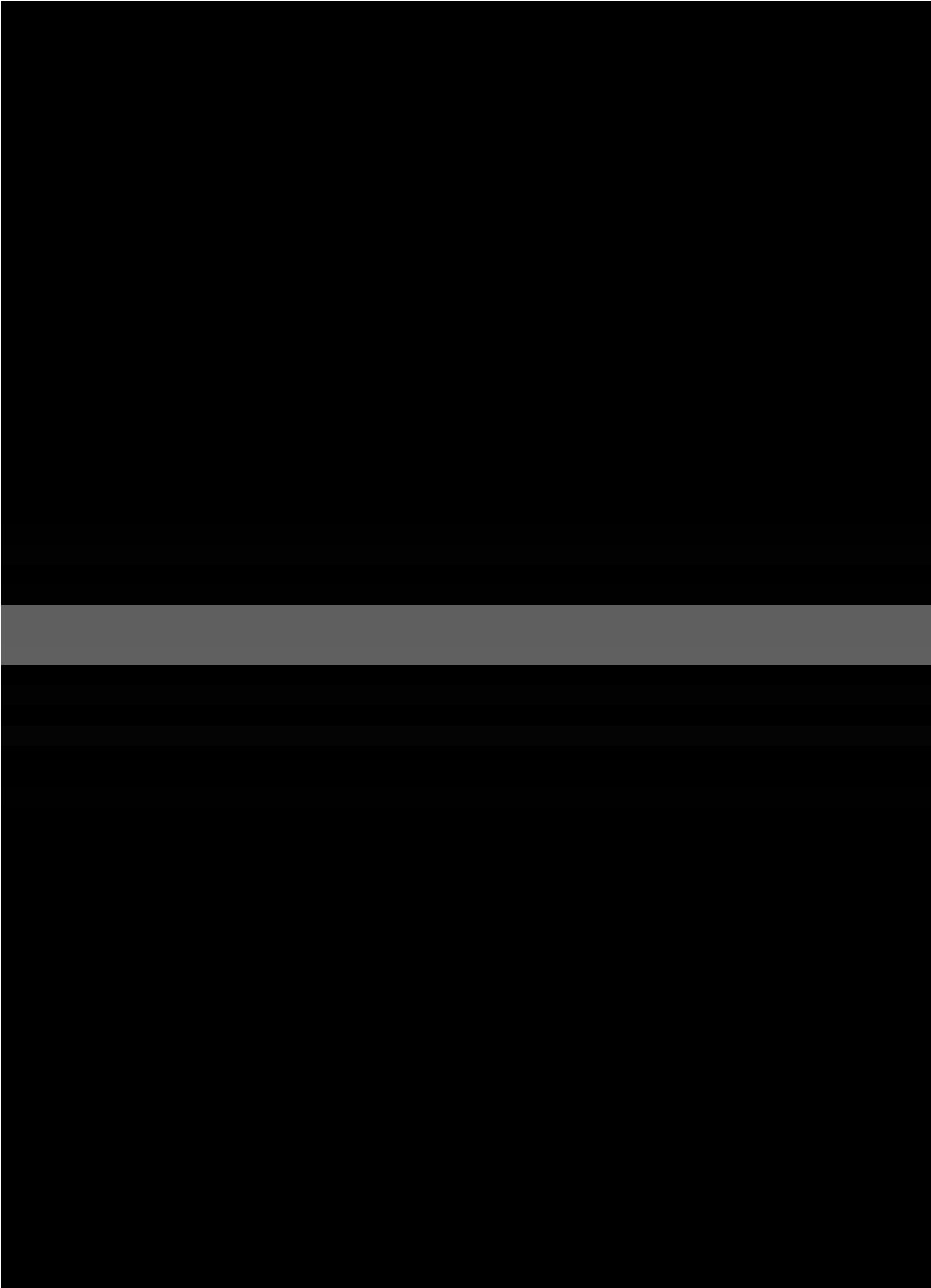
“Apologies for the children. I tried to keep them away.”

“It’s fine. It was a nice way to wake up.” I look at her husband, busy flipping pancakes on the griddle. In a flash, I remember the photo on Paul’s phone—the one from Mason as he compares notes. The one of Eleanor fucking Ronald in the ass with a strap on.

“Morning,” I say, forcing myself back into this domestic scene. Will I ever be able to look at this man the same way?

He smiles back, ignorant of my thoughts. “It’s good to see you, Heather. Hungry?”

“Starving.”



After a big breakfast and a lot of coffee, I feel rejuvenated. A long, hot shower and I feel even better. Eleanor leaves a pair of black yoga pants, a t-shirt, and a bulky sweater for me to change into.

Sitting atop, small enough that I miss it at first, is a black g-string. I chuckle, wondering if this is a glimpse of what most of Eleanor's lingerie wardrobe is. It's a funnier thing to think about than how I got here and whether my marriage was over. Still, those thoughts come, blurring my vision with tears that I refuse to let fall.

For all Joshua's faults, I love the man. He's been in my life for nine full years. He's been my constant. It's hard to imagine a future without him.

My phone buzzes. It's been hours since I walked out. I was beginning to wonder when he would contact me.

[Paul]: Hey, how's it going? I'm sorry I took advantage of you last night. Hope I didn't make your life too much of a mess. I'm sorry.

Paul, not Joshua, doing a thing that Joshua would never do—apologizing. I sigh and don't respond.

Eleanor is waiting for me in the living room. She leads me to the guest house, a detached building just a short walk through their garden back yard.

The house itself has a modern, rustic feel to it, like an upscale ski lodge. "Don't worry, the cameras are all off," she explains as she sees me looking around. "I promise."

"Cameras?" I ask.

"Oh, you didn't know? I figured Paul told you about that. This place is wired."

I glance at the loveseat on the main floor, remembering how warm the supple,

brown leather was on the backs of my thighs as I watched Jamie and Eleanor make out on the opposite sofa. “Was he recording that night?”

Fear rises through me—not so much that I was recorded without my consent, but that it would mean that I couldn’t trust Eleanor.

“No, he wasn’t.” She nibbles the tips of her fingers nervously. “Although he did watch. I’m sorry.”

“Very kinky.”

“I should have asked if it was okay—”

“Eleanor, it’s okay. But just...if you did record it—”

“We would erase it, of course.” She chews her nails. “But he didn’t.”

“Okay.”

We settle into those same couches. I look around again, wondering where the cameras are hidden. “I never told you how nice this place was.”

“Compliments to our interior designer, not me. I’m awful at those things. All I knew was that I wanted something nicer than Ron’s workshop, where he never actually did any work.”

“What? You didn’t tell the designer that you wanted a sex house?”

Eleanor laughs. “Oh, all of that came after. Happy coincidence, yeah? Now explaining to the guy installing the discreet video camera over the bed was a bit embarrassing, but I made Ron do that.” She plops down beside me, resting her head on her elbow. “So... have you talked to him yet?”

“Joshua?”

“Who else?” She’s too perceptive for that question to be anything but rhetorical.

“Not yet. He’s waiting for me to make the first move. He wants me to come groveling back.”

Eleanor snorts. “He doesn’t know you very well then.”

“That’s the trouble, he knows me too well.” It hurts me to admit this part. “This isn’t the first time I’ve walked out.”

“But this is different.”

I sigh. “I’m not so sure.”

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Dominic

I've mentioned it before, but I got pretty adventurous in college. I was on my own, away from the straight A, always-follow-the-rules high schooler I was before. I wanted to experience things. All the things.

I never told Joshua about it, though. Not to the full extent. By the time we met, I got it all out of my system. Or so I thought. I was in control. A professional woman, mature and smart and fighting to be seen as more than just a pretty blonde. I wanted Joshua to see me as more than that, too, more than anything.

Until David, I thought that he did. After... Well, I kind of missed the boredom. Missed him looking at me like his friend. It's silly, I know, and I liked that I was suddenly this vixen again, but you know how it is, it's a hard thing to balance—those two things.

Anyway, after David, he just looked at me differently. Like he was trying to unlock me, and worse, there were secrets that I had that I wasn't keen on letting out.

We ran into one of those secrets about six months after the David incident. His name was Dominic.

If Joshua embodied the grownup version of me, then Dominic was like all the mistakes and adventures and immaturity of my college days. He was hilariously cliché for a white girl like me, the quintessential bad boy—a big, black guy with tattoos and a body that was hewn from sinew and muscle more than any time spent in the gym. He drank straight from the bottle, smoked weed and cigarettes in equal amounts, and fucked like no one I'd ever been with before. And yes, he had a giant, black cock.

Joshua and I were having brunch in the city when he spotted us, sitting down in

the free chair without being invited. “Heather? Mother fuck, it is you.”

I didn’t recognize him at first. The Dominic I knew from college shaved his head and had a thin strap of facial hair that ran along his square jaw. This man’s beard was more grown out, flecked with gray, and enough hair had grown in to hint at a receding hairline. But it was him. I recognized it in his eyes, dark brown and piercing.

“Dominic?”

He stroked his beard. “It’s the gray, right? I should probably shave it off.”

“You look distinguished.” I almost giggled, feeling the rush of that other me resurface. I’d been thinking of her more and more since my mistake with David. “Dominic, meet my husband, Joshua.”

“Hey, man,” Dominic said, offering his hand.

“Nice to meet you.” Joshua’s voice was cold enough that I was surprised I couldn’t see his breath.

“You, too. The princess and I go way back.”

Heat crawled up my neck. “Princess.” The nickname wasn’t lost on Joshua. I could see him mouthing it, working it out.

“What are you doing here?”

“Same’s you. Eating.” He pointed at a table across the restaurant, where a pretty brunette sat with three unruly boys. One of those boys threw a strawberry at his older brother, who turned and punched his brother in the arm.

Dominic had kids? I looked at him, amazed.

“Well, looks like I gotta go. It was nice seeing you, Heather. Maybe I’ll see you around.”

He still looked good in his tight, ripped jeans and hoodie sweatshirt. Same old Dominic, only not at all. When he slid into the booth with his family, they swarmed him. He laughed, immediately dispelling the brotherly brawl. The

brunette leaned over and kissed him warmly before wagging her finger at him for leaving them momentarily.

I wondered if she had any idea that her husband used to make me beg him to fuck my ass.

“So that’s the kind of guy you dated, huh,” Joshua said. The statement snapped me back to the present. It was disorienting. Like waking in the middle of the night, caught between dream and reality. I wasn’t that girl anymore, but for a second I was.

“You’re surprised that I dated a black guy?”

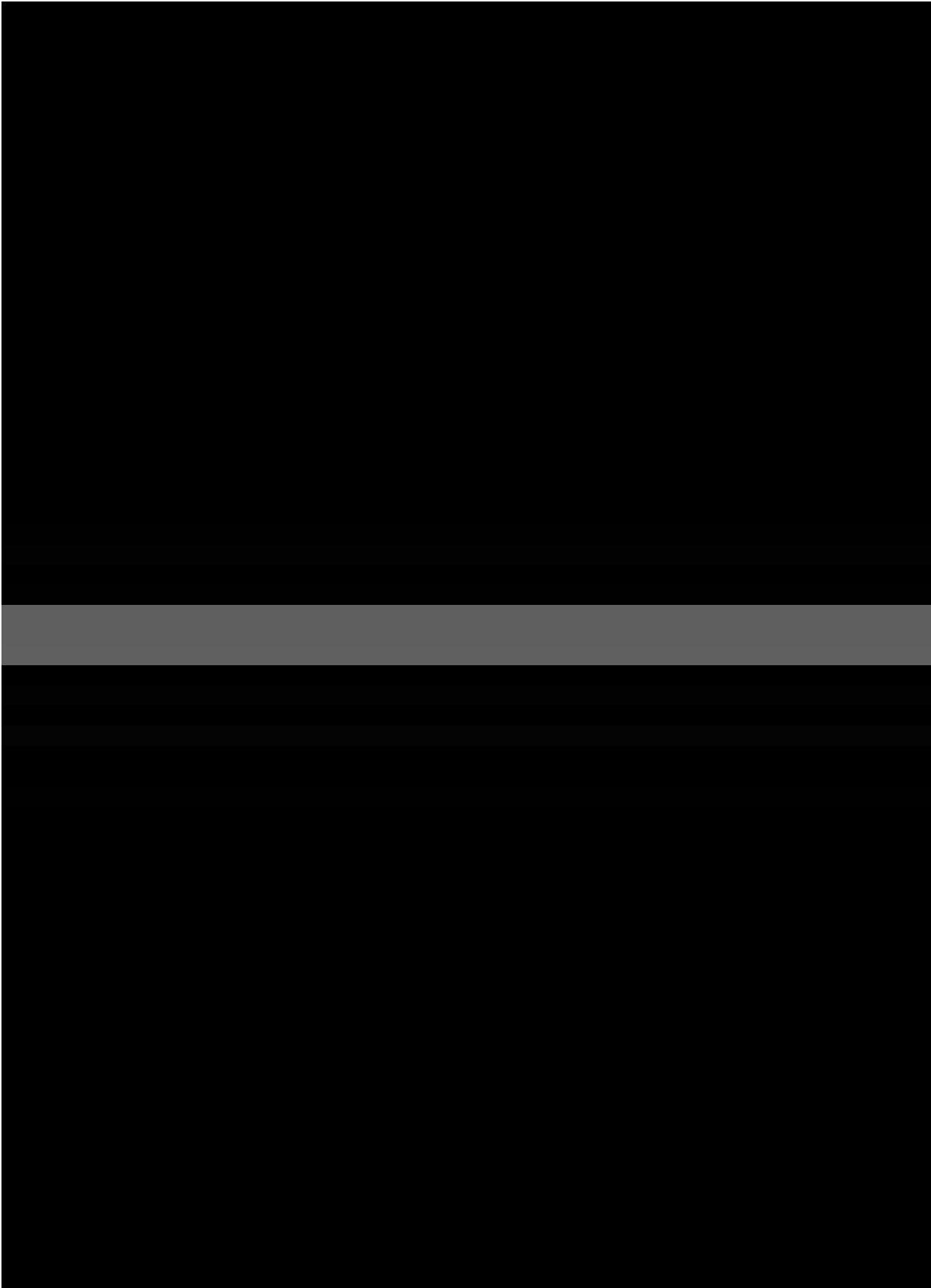
“I didn’t say that.” But he was definitely thinking it. “He has tattoos on his knuckles.”

“Not just his knuckles,” I said before I could stop myself. That wasn’t me, and I flushed brighter, laughing nervously.

Joshua was looking at me with the same manic expression he had when we’d talked about David. I wanted to look away, but didn’t.

“What?” I asked instead.

He stared at me, amusement all over his face. “Nothing,” he said, but I knew what he was thinking—How cliché.



Joshua brought it up later that night, as I was changing into my sleeping clothes. I was topless, pulling my cami top on with my back to him when he said, “Princess, huh?”

I looked at him over my shoulder. His eyes were glued to my small, tiara tattoo that peeked out of my low slung pajama bottoms.

“You got that for him?”

“I got it for myself.” But yes. “But I guess you could say he encouraged me.”

Joshua was lounging on the bed, a couple pillows tucked up under him. His Kindle sat in his lap, forgotten. “Tell me about it.”

I finished pulling on my top and joined him on the bed. His face was a mask, but I was close enough to see the way his chest rose and fell, more rapidly than the calm he was projecting.

“About my tattoo? I got it on my 20th birthday. I thought it was cute.”

Joshua turned to face me, reaching out to run his hand down my side. He watched his fingers skim into my waist before climbing back up along my hip. “Was that before or after he started calling you his princess?” He looked back up at me as he finished the question.

“He never called me his princess,” I said coyly. “Do you really want to hear this? We’ve never talked about our exes.”

“I do.”

He did. I could see it in his eyes—right along with a healthy amount of jealousy. “The more jealous I feel, the more turned on I get.” His words. Time to test that theory.

“I knew Dom was trouble the moment I saw him. I was just nineteen. He was twenty-two. We met at a house party off campus.” I met Joshua’s eyes, watching him closely. “Within thirty minutes, we were fucking in the bedrooms in the back of the house.”

I saw myself change in the eyes of my husband. That was the moment, more than anything, when his hotwife fantasy found oxygen and he stopped seeing the sweet, smart me.

He ran his hand back up my body, his thumb stroking across my breast. My nipple came alive beneath his touch. "Tell me more."

"What do you want to know?"

He looked like a kid who'd just been handed keys to his father's Corvette.

"How long did you date him?"

"We didn't really date. Mostly, we just got together and fucked." I watched him, tested him. This got him going. His hand tightened on my breast, his fingers pinching my erect nipple. "But we did that on again, off again for close to a year. With a few later blips. I lost track of him after graduating."

"Damn, Heather."

I scooted closer, crushing my chest into his hand. I felt him erect against my knee. "What? You didn't think I was innocent before I met you, did you?"

"No."

"But part of you did," I challenged. I pulled him close, our foreheads kissing, eyes locked. "Part of you thought I was your princess, pure and innocent and all yours."

It was like he was looking through me or something. It was disconcerting. I'd cultivated this more innocent persona because that's how I wanted him to see me, but maybe I was just fooling myself.

"Dom called you his princess," Joshua said. "But there was nothing pure and innocent about that, was there?"

Joshua awoke. I could see it in his eyes and feel it in his cock. He kissed me hard as we began to pull at our clothes. I wanted to feel his skin against mine. He wanted to remind me of who he was married to.

“He fucked me from behind right after I got the tattoo.” I couldn’t help myself from taunting Joshua more. “I didn’t want to. I was scared it would hurt, but Dominic didn’t care.”

Joshua flipped me onto my stomach, pulling on my hips. He was picturing that other man fucking me. So was I.

“He tore the bandage off as he drove home. Said he wanted to watch his princess scream.”

Joshua rubbed my girl spot as he started fucking me. Dom used to spank. Joshua didn’t.

“He called me a bad little princess. Said that princesses like me should be punished.” Joshua’s grip tightened on my ass. “Are you going to punish your bad, little princess, Joshua?”

He spanked me. It was the first time he’d ever spanked me, and I nearly came. I didn’t remember how good that could feel, how turned on the pain brought. It was so physical. So raw. I pushed back on him. I wanted to feel his cock drill straight through me as I screamed, “Yes! Yes!” with each thrust, with each spank.

“What else did you do with him, baby?”

“Oh, Joshua,” I moaned. I just wanted to lose myself in this moment. He wanted to keep pushing. “What didn’t I do with him?”

Joshua thickened inside me. “Did he spank you?”

“Mmm, he did.”

His palm landed with a loud slap on my cheek. I could feel the questions in his desperation. I felt all the dirty, naughty things that he often wondered about while I lay at his side, asleep. All the things he never dared to ask.

“Did you have anal sex with him?”

“Oh, yes. He took that cherry.”

“Fuck,” he barked. He was close. “What else did you... did you give up for him?”

“Two guys at once. I never—” I groaned as the intensity of my husband met the ferocity of my time with Dominic. “Never fucked two guys at once, but when... ngh... but when Dom’s best friend visited from Rochester, I figured why not?”

“Fuck, Heather, that’s so... ngh... so fucking...”

“Yes,” I said. “So much fucking.”

A whole night of fucking. It was one of the most intense moments of my life. I still remember this crazy, out-of-control feeling of being on my back as I blew Dom and his friend fucked me.

What I didn’t tell Joshua then was how mixed that memory was. As spicy and exciting and adventurous as it was, in hindsight it was also not something I was proud of. I was young and stupid and reckless. With Dom, I would have done anything, and he knew it. Luckily, he was a decent enough guy that he didn’t take advantage. I can’t say all the guys I’d been with since were quite so honorable.

But like I said, I left that part out for Joshua. He didn’t want to hear about my struggles—just my indiscretions.

“That turn you on, baby? Thinking about your beautiful wife getting used by two guys?”

Joshua gasped.

“You like thinking about me gagging on a big cock as another hammers my pussy?” I couldn’t believe the words that spewed from my mouth. I was no stranger to dirty talk, but Joshua was. At least to mine. “How about how they woke me in the morning to fuck me one last time before his friend had to leave. That... get you... off?”

That did it. Joshua drove forward, so hard that it pushed my face into the pillow. He came as I fought for oxygen. It didn’t help that I was screaming, too, as an orgasm tore through me. I didn’t love who I was back then, but that didn’t make it any less erotic.

In the afterglow, we snuggled beneath the sheets, laying side by side, staring at one another. “Did that really happen?”

“You still don’t believe me?”

“It’s just...” Joshua couldn’t seem to find the words, which is a rare thing for him. “It’s hard to imagine you with a guy like that is all.”

“Because he was black?”

“Well, now you’re making me sound racist. No, more like... all the tattoos. And he had his nose pierced between his nostrils in his... what’s that called—”

“Septum.”

“Yes, that. He looked like a little... I don’t know... It’s hard to stand a guy like him next to someone like you. You’ve always been so put together. You’re smart, funny, sexy as hell, but, like... cleaned up. The kind of girl who always wears matching underwear.”

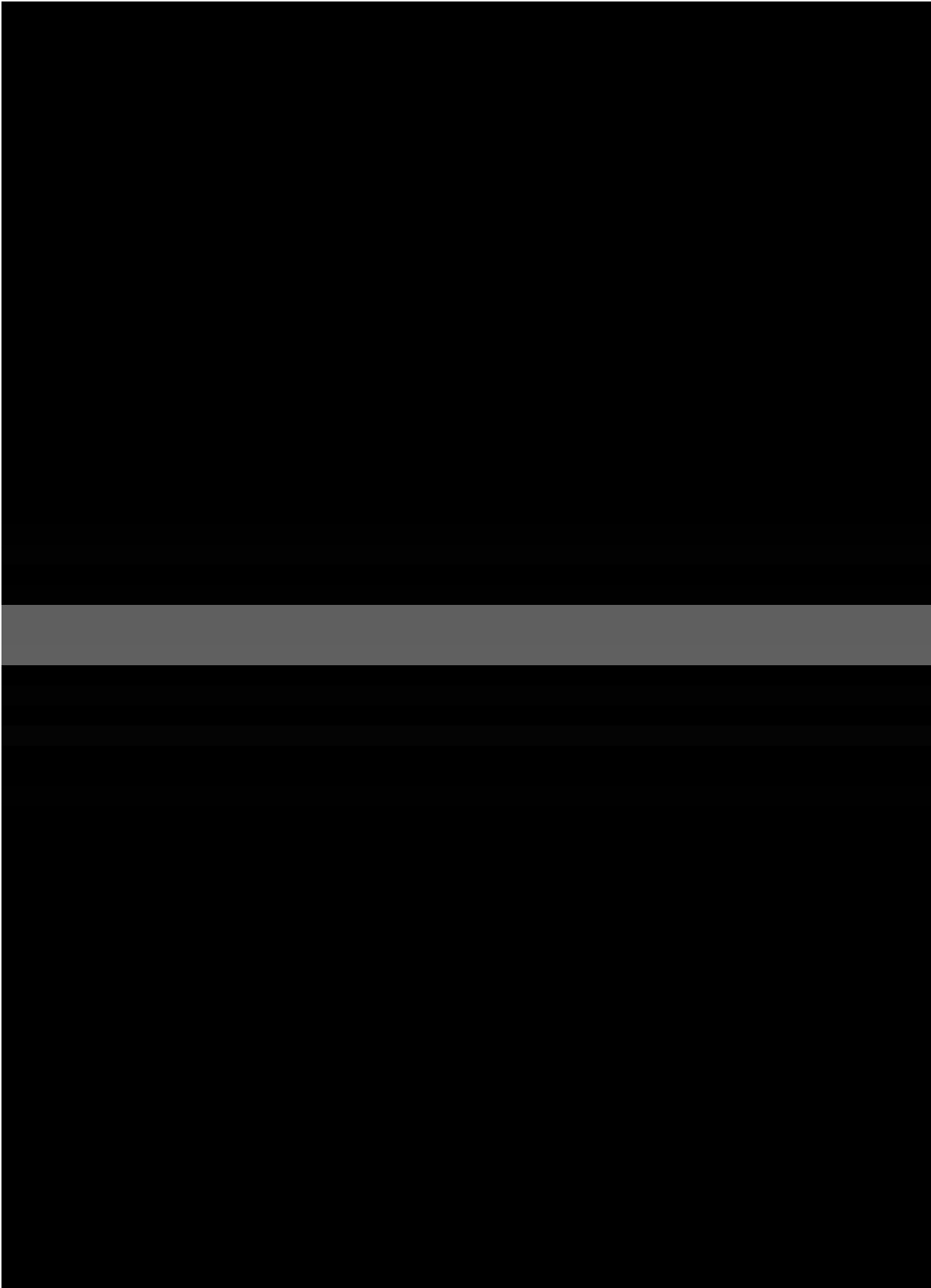
“And Dominic isn’t?”

“Not really, no.”

“You should give him some more credit. There’s always more beneath the surface, honey.”

Joshua took it as a tease, rather than a rebuttal. He smiled and stroked my cheek. “Apparently a lot more.”

I debated telling him everything—telling him about Shane, my biggest mistake. I didn’t. I still haven’t. Dominic was enough to start the obsession.



About a month later, I found out that Joshua was reading my emails and texts. That he'd hacked my Facebook account just to read through my messages. There was nothing there to read, nothing incriminating.

He told me he wanted to see if I'd been secretly exchanging messages with Dominic. That I'd actually try to have an affair with my old boyfriend. I didn't know what I was more pissed about, that I'd break up Dominic's happy family like that, or that he thought I'd have an affair at all.

"But you said yourself how you kept going back to him."

"I was twenty years old, Joshua. I did a lot of stupid shit when I was twenty."

"What else?"

"No, we're not going there. You just fucking broke my trust here."

"How's that, Heather? I thought we had nothing to hide."

I rolled my eyes. This man was infuriating sometimes. "And did you find anything I'm hiding?"

"No, exactly. You made my point," he said. The logic didn't hold, but logic didn't always matter in Joshua's arguments. He could win on sheer charisma. "You had nothing to hide. No foul, so no foul in looking."

"You don't really believe that, do you?"

"I do, Heather. I do."

I grabbed my keys. Headed for the door.

"Where are you going?"

"Why don't you check my messages. Maybe you'll find out."

So I walked out on him, and maybe I should have stayed gone. But I didn't. I already had a trip planned out west for a week, so we took that time apart. He didn't try to contact me, just like now, and stubbornly, I refused to contact him.

So I told myself.

But out there, all alone on the West Coast, I took stock of everything. I put myself in his shoes. In fact, I had been in his shoes once, just after learning that he and his ex were swingers. I'd looked Melody up, done some cyber-stalking.

I was surprised to find that she was married to Garrett now, the man she'd had an affair with. She had two kids with white-blond hair like her own. They looked happy together, one smiling, beautiful family, living out in Ohio. Joshua wasn't her Facebook friend and he didn't follow her on Instagram, both of which came with a mild relief.

I'll confess that I did briefly consider sending her a friend request, just to learn more. I didn't, and it never even crossed my mind to break into his account to check his emails or messages. That was so past the line of decency that it's still shocking that he did it without thinking he'd done anything wrong.

I forgave him in the end. That's the kind of guy I'd married, and he didn't do it for any malicious reasons. He was feeding a fantasy that demanded more and more fuel. I could see that, even then. He still loved me, and I still loved him. So I went back to him.

But not before checking into a West Coast spa for three days and getting pampered. I even flirted a little with the hot, young, male attendants. It was fun, and I made sure to tell Joshua all about it when I got home.

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Skyler and Scott

He never did apologize about Dom and all the manipulation. We dealt with it the way we deal with everything—we mostly ignored it. In hindsight, it was absolutely the wrong thing to do. But the two of us... we're pretty codependent. Joshua wanted to keep believing that anything was possible, and I guess I didn't want to let him down.

Nothing happened for about a year. We got deep into our work. Joshua brought up the hotwife thing a few times, but only in the bedroom, and that was it. We didn't talk about it before or after. It was just some harmless foreplay.

Things were good. We were having sex more, which was nice. It was like the year after we first met. It was good. And if things had continued on like that indefinitely, I would have been fine. I was picking up more clients at work. Joshua made partner. I turned thirty and things really felt good. And then we went to New Orleans did Joshua's fortieth, and ran into Skyler and Scott.

Skyler and Scott were two of Joshua's friends from his first marriage. They had actually come to our wedding, too, although I hadn't seen them since.

We ran into them by total chance at a small, hole-in-the-wall Sazerac bar in the French Quarter after a romantic birthday dinner. All these years later, though, I can't help but wonder if Joshua set it up.

Skyler and Scott didn't just know my husband from back in the day, but they were one of the other couples that used to swing with Joshua and Melody.

I noticed them first. Dressed in a short, tight black dress with her bright, white-gold locks falling in loose, springy coils, Skyler was a very attractive woman. Scott, her husband, was no slouch either—as brawny as his bold personality, with a trimmed beard and direct, confident eyes.

“What the fuck?!” Scott launched in as soon as he saw us. “Skye, you seeing this? Or have I finally had too much to drink?”

Where Scott’s gaze was open and brash, Skyler’s was more playful, like a cat to his dog. She’d even added dark flourishes to the corners of her eyes with eyeliner. If I was a bowl of milk, I could practically feel her lapping me up.

“If you see a fun evening ahead, then yes, Scott. I do.”

“Scott? Skye?” Joshua said, surprised as I was. “What are you guys doing here?”

“Was about to ask you the same thing,” Scott said, holding his arms out wide. Joshua man-hugged him, slapping backs, as Skyler floated over to me. We exchanged hugs, too, although I didn’t know her all that well.

“You smell amazing,” she said to me. “What fragrance?”

“Chance, by Chanel.”

She pulled back, but held onto my arms as she laughed. “How fitting.”

She went on to hug Joshua, and I watched them closely, curiously, before Scott stepped in and pulled me tightly. “Heather, looking even more lovely than you did on your wedding day.”

“You’re not supposed to tell a girl that, you know.”

Scott chuckled. “I don’t do a whole lot that I’m supposed to, I guess.”

I shook my head at him, glancing towards Joshua and ready to roll my eyes at his friends when my breath caught. He was kissing Skyler. Or appeared to as she stepped back. Jealousy surged through me before I could calm things down.

Scott cleared his throat for me, and at least Skyler had the sense to look bashful. “Sorry, I’m used to...” She trailed off with a look to her husband.

“I get it,” I said. Time to be the cool girl here. “You two played?”

I could almost feel the tension melt away. My jealousy lingered, but I kept it buried.

“Long time ago,” Scott said.

Skyler elbowed him. “Hey, mister, don’t make me feel so old.”

“Don’t worry, hon, you certainly don’t look it,” he said back.

I couldn’t help but agree. She looked closer to my age than Scott’s, and better than most twenty-somethings at that.

“So what are you guys doing here?” Joshua asked again. “Did you move to New Orleans?”

“No, we’re still in Chicago,” Scott said. He pulled his wife into his arms—and more importantly, away from my husband. “We’re here for a wedding. You guys?”

“Celebrating Joshua’s big birthday,” I said, stepping in.

“Well ho-ly shit.” Scott clapped Joshua on the back again. “What a wild coincidence. You settle that tab yet? If not, let me pick it up.”

Skyler detached herself from her husband to come to me as the men caught up. “I love your dress,” she said, those feline eyes hinting at more than just friendly appreciation. She reached out, touching the thin strap of my tight, red dress. “Love the color.”

“Thanks.” I got it for Joshua as part of his birthday present. It was the kind of dress I never wore anymore, but knew that he would love. The thin material clung to me, super short and low cut—the kind of dress that made even me feel self-conscious. The kind of dress that required a drink to wear without fiddling with the hem.

“Yours is gorgeous, too.”

“Thanks. Looks like the two of us are ready to party.”

I gave her an appreciative look—the same look she’d been giving me. The black dress was cinched around her neck, the straps cross-crossing her back before hugging her narrow butt. She had small, perky breasts, and her nipples poked out high and hard through the thin material. She couldn’t have been wearing a bra.

“I know I am.” As I said it with a smile, a hot thrill pulsed through me. It had been a long time since I’d flirted with another woman, and Skyler was being very receptive.

She held my eyes, but before she could speak, her husband placed a couple shots in front of the two of us. Skyler shook her head with a delighted smile, as if to say, Can you believe we’re doing this? But when Scott toasted to Joshua’s fortieth, she threw the shot back with the practice of a college coed. I followed suit, pleased that I still possessed the skill not to cough as the harsh liquor hit my throat.

Scott tipped the glass down and shook his head like a wet dog. “That burns.” He laughed. “We aren’t young anymore, are we my friend?” He winked at me. “Well, except you, sweetheart.”

Sweetheart. My hackles went up, but the alcohol slowed my sharp response enough for Joshua to step in.

“That mean you’re throwing in the towel, old man? Skyler, you’re welcome to ditch this old bag.”

She looked right at me, and again things got hot and tingly. “I’m not ready to turn in just yet.” She shimmied her shoulders. “I was promised live music and dancing.”

I turned away from Skyler and danced my back up against her. Looking over my shoulder, I said, “You heard the birthday boy. You’re invited.”

Scott raised his hand. “Could I get an invitation, too? I suddenly feel ten years younger.”

Skyler looked at me. “What do you think? Give him a second chance?”

I looked at Scott, who was doing his best to look contrite. I didn’t believe it for a second, but it was fine. Besides, he was Joshua’s old friend and I was feeling adventurous that night.

I raised my index finger at him. “Just one more chance.” I could feel that shot as it entered my bloodstream and made everything effervescent. With a smile, I added, “If you sweetheart me one more time, though, your invitation is

rescinded.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

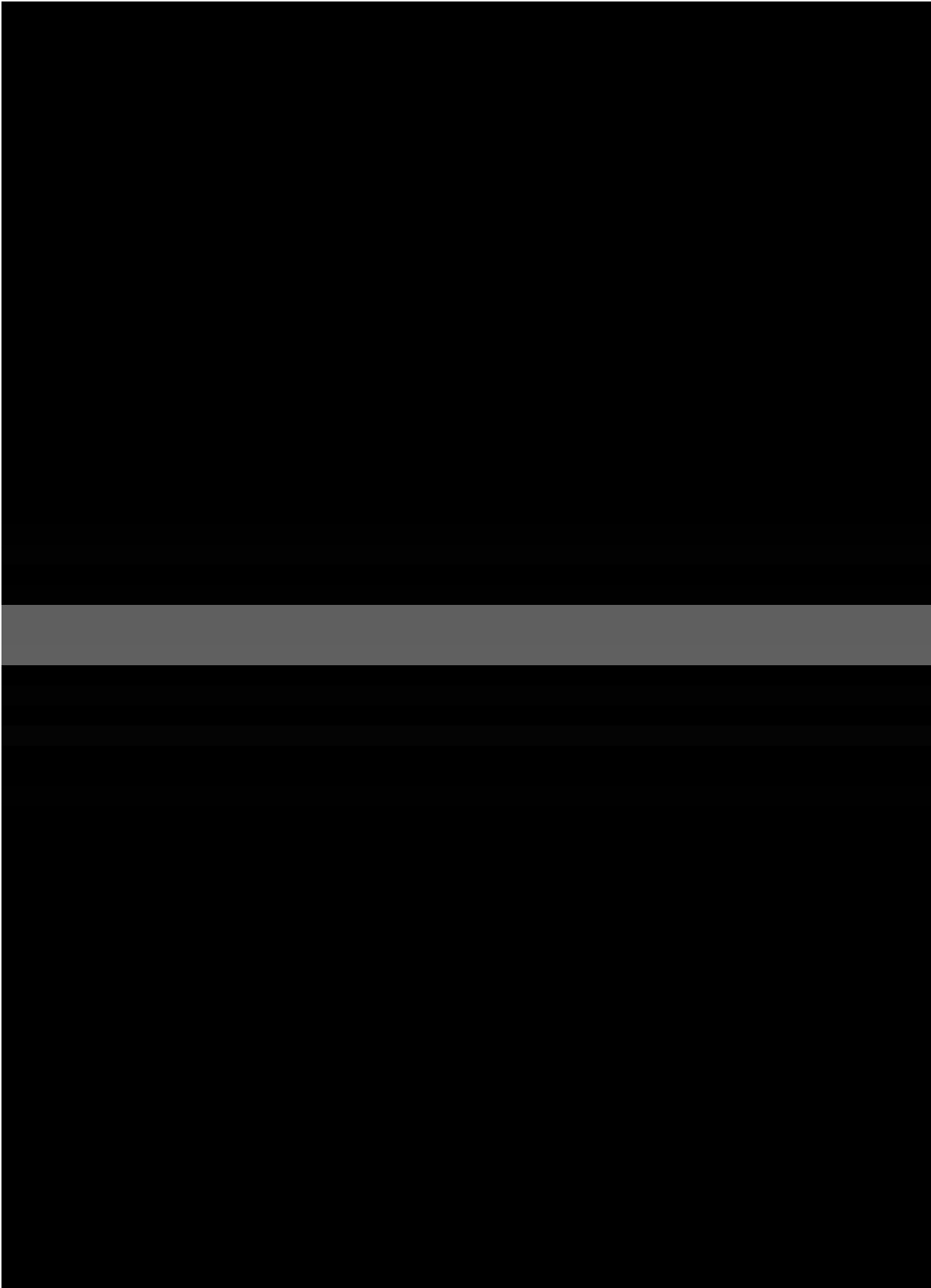
“‘Ma’am’ is now on the list, too.”

He looked at Joshua. “Any advice?”

He looked at me. “Call her princess. She loves that.”

My eyes burned into my husband’s. If I could strangle him, I would. Scott put his arm around him instead. “And you can call me ‘gullible’, but that doesn’t make me one.”

“You guys done?” Skyler asked. “Or are you going to keep trying to outwit the other like this is fucking Shakespearean times or something. Let’s go!”



Skyler was drunk. Or very, naturally gregarious. Or maybe it was just the energy of New Orleans' French Quarter on a Friday night. I felt it infuse me as well—the smell of booze and cigarettes and perfume; live jazz spilling out of bar after bar, a harmonious cacophony that took on a life of its own; street performers entertaining crowds as bicycle cabs meandered up and down the car choked streets.

“Isn’t this just fucking amazing?” Skyler shouted, taking it all in.

It was. I hadn’t felt this kind of energy in years. Since my wilder days, when I felt bold and indestructible. She looked behind us, where the guys trailed.

“They’re checking us out,” she said.

“Shocker.”

“I like you. You’re good for Joshua.” The implication there was that his first wife wasn’t.

“He’s good for me, too.”

She squeezed my arm. “You want to make his fortieth extra memorable?”

These were swingers, I had to remind myself. And I wasn’t, as tempting as it all was. Skyler was fun, and Scott was good looking, even if his personality was a bit much.

But I had Joshua to worry about, and, since the alcohol was making me introspectively honest with myself, I had myself to worry about, too. I wasn’t that woman anymore, but it would be so easy to fall back on her. All I had to do was think about my slip up with David.

“I’m not sure I’m cool with what you’re implying,” I said carefully.

“Which is?” I felt like she was toying with me, so I decided to cut to the chase.

“To swing with you guys.”

“Oh, is that what you think this is?”

“That’s how you know Joshua, right?”

“Scott went to school with Josh. We’ve been friends forever. And...” Her voice went up an octave. “...we occasionally fooled around together. But that’s not what’s going on here.”

That felt like a relief. And a disappointment, too, if I was honest with myself. Mostly a relief though. “Okay then, how were you thinking of making the night memorable?”

She stopped at a bar, that very specifically did not have live music. It was more of a lounge than a club, with people drinking brightly hued cocktails and dressed more like Skyler than me.

“Thought you wanted to dance.”

“Oh, I do. But first, we need dance partners.”

She guided me to the bar, where a couple stools at the corner were still open. Our husbands followed us in, but didn’t join us. Instead, they pushed up to the bar closer to the front and ordered drinks by themselves.

“What are they doing?” I asked.

“Watching. What’ll you drink?”

Watching. I looked around, saw the men circling. I knew what kind of bar this was. I’d spent many nights in bars like this—nights where I started alone and ended with company. Our husbands were watching as other men hit on us.

I found Joshua’s eyes down the bar, through the crowd. In the red glow of the lounge, they looked completely black beneath his tensed brow. He took a breath, his chest rising and falling like the edge of something powerful. He was into this—conflicted, as always, but definitely excited.

So was I. All that energy I’d felt walking over here, the atmosphere of this strange city, the promise of something new and wild and exciting just within reach, it infected me. My blood raced with the possibility. I smiled at my

husband one last time before turning back to Skyler.

“Drink, Heather?” Skyler had the bartender’s attention.

“Manhattan. I’ll take a Manhattan.”

“Classy,” she said. “Two Manhattans, sir.”

Before they were even made, we were approached by the first pair of guys of the night. “Evening, ladies,” the lead asked, zeroing in on me.

Skyler spoke, cutting him off before he could get any further. “You timed that on purpose?”

“Hm?” he asked, confused.

“Waited for us to order our drinks before approaching.”

“No, I was about to offer to buy you a round—”

“He timed it,” she said to me. “Tacky, tacky.”

“I—”

His friend realized this was a lost cause and stopped him. “Let’s go, man.”

Skyler broke out laughing before they could get out of the bar. “That seemed mean.”

“Please, those guys deserve it. Also, never take the first guy to approach seriously.”

I nodded. “Too eager.”

“Right. And what fun is that? One of my favorite things is the subtle eye contact across the room. The build up.”

She glanced past me, smiling at someone. I doubted it was her husband. “You guys do this often?” I asked.

“Not often, no. If you do something too much, then it’s less exciting, you

know?” Our drinks arrived. “That’s one of the real dangers of this lifestyle. What was once exciting is later taken for granted. Things get more extreme. Like drugs, I guess, you need to do harder and harder stuff to achieve the same high.”

“Makes sense.”

She picked up her drink. “Honestly, I’m a little surprised that you’re here.”

“Wasn’t this your idea?”

“Darling, haven’t you figured out yet that I’m the one always pushing the envelope?” Skyler was shameless, and I loved it. “I thought Josh would shut me down.”

I thought about David and Dom and how Joshua had reacted. “Why did you think he would? Seems like it’s a core fantasy of his.”

For the first time that night, it seemed, she hesitated. Like she’d stumbled upon something unexpected, even for her. “Did he tell you about Melody?”

“I know they split up because she had an affair.”

“Is that what he told you?”

I nodded, not liking where this was going, or how I was feeling. The buzz of the evening had turned harsh, it grew teeth.

“I suppose that’s one way to look at it.”

“How would you look at it?”

“Oh, this is so, classic Joshua.” She tossed her hair, like this was the most amusing thing in the world. “I’d say it was more of a failure-to-communicate situation.”

“What does that mean?”

“Look, I love Joshua, but let’s not kid ourselves. He’s got a way of seeing things as right and wrong—meaning he is right, and if you don’t agree, you’re probably wrong. That cocksuredness—is that a word? Whatever. You know what I mean.

Good for lawyering, sometimes bad for interpersonal shit.”

This was true. It’s also one of the things that drew me to him—not his stubbornness, but the challenge it presented, because I also had a little of that tendency myself. Led to some spectacular fights, which inevitably led to spectacular makeup sex.

“So bring it home, Skyler. How’s this relate to his first wife?”

“He says she cheated. Maybe she didn’t?”

I looked at her wryly. “Maybe?”

“Fuck, Heather, you always cut to it?”

“I don’t like riddles when I’ve been drinking. You know something. Please speak plainly.”

“I—” She stopped, her attention past me. More men had arrived. “I promise, I’ll tell you later. But these guys are too delicious to turn away.”

She was right, they were mesmerizing. Not only were they tall and handsome in a clean cut kind of way, but they were identical twins. Only way to tell them apart was that one wore a dark blue shirt and the other a white one with flowers.

I’d had threesomes before, but I had never had one with twins, and while I was now married and had left that life behind, I couldn’t help but imagine what that would be like with these two able bodied young men. Skyler was right, they were just too delicious to pass up.

Flowers came to me, his haunting blue eyes seeking me out beneath his dark, curly hair. I always loved that contrast.

“Sorry to interrupt. Looked like you two were having an intense conversation,” he said.

Blue Shirt picked up right where Flowers left off. “You also looked like you needed a refresher on your drinks.”

I couldn’t help myself. “To approach, or not approach. A classic bro dilemma.”

Neither twin seemed fazed. Flowers even seemed to play along. “I know, right? It’s a great opportunity, but it’s risky.”

“So who’s the risk-taker?” I asked.

Blue Shirt answered. “That’s not how we work. Jon and I don’t do anything we can’t agree on.”

I turned to Jon, and walked my fingers up the flower prints on his shirt. His chest felt like a granite block, and my blood began to warm. “So you two guys agreed to hit on a couple hot blondes. What a difficult consensus to come to.”

“It’s almost like they’re brothers,” Skyler said with a snicker.

Jon, looking down at me, smiled. He either liked being toyed with, or saw right through me. Joshua had also seen right through me, which lead to one of the best nights of my life.

Joshua! I almost forgot that he was here! It was hard now to seek him out, to check if he was upset.

I pulled my hand away from Jon’s chest—slowly—but felt off my game.

“I know it’s hard to believe, but Jack and I are actually brothers,” Jon said as I tried to get a handle on the situation again.

“Twins, in fact,” Jack added with a laugh.

Skyler put an arm around me. “Lucky for you, Heather and I aren’t related.”

“Why’s that lucky for us?” Jack asked.

She ran her free hand up my stomach and out along my ribs. My chest tightened. My nipples grew to hard points. She said, “Use your imagination.”

Her insinuation wasn’t directed at me, but my imagination came alive, too. I could see a night of debauchery unfold before us. Could feel it in the tingle of my nipples and the sudden heat between my thighs.

“So how about another round of Manhattans?” Jack offered eagerly.

I took the moment to glance over at Joshua. He was still there, with Scott whispering something to him. The look on my husband's face was of tangible conflict—betrayal and lust clashing under his dark brow. When he saw me looking, he gave a little nod. Whether that was to me, or to Scott, I wasn't sure. I wanted it to be for me, though.

“How about something we can take with us on our way to dancing,” I said, catching Skyler's eye. “We're in the French Quarter in NOLA. Might as well take advantage of their loose, open container laws.”

“Strawberry margarita for me,” Skyler bubbled. She hugged me from behind with a laugh.

“I'll take one, too.”

The guys ordered beers for themselves, settled the tab, and we took off as a group. Joshua and Scott sat at their spot at the bar, watching us silently as we passed. Joshua stared at me possessively, hungrily. For a moment, I thought he was going to hop up and stop us from going. He licked his lips, and I swore he started to make a move when Scott stopped him. His friend whispered something, and Joshua backed down.

Then we were outside again, drinks in hand as we joined the party in the streets. Jon was at my side, tall and handsome. “What kind of music do you want to dance to?”

Dancing was more Skyler's idea, but she was caught up in whatever Jack was saying, laughing and clinging to his arm. So I answered. “Anything that gets you going.”

“I know just the place.”

“You're not taking me to your bedroom, Jon.”

He laughed. “Not yet.”

I raised a brow at him. “You're a cocky one.”

“And you're a tease, but something tells me you're worth it.”

I held up my ring finger. “My husband thinks so.”

“I saw that.” He didn’t elaborate.

“That bother you?”

“Only if he’s here and going to kick my ass. We’re in NOLA, Heather. It’s like a more authentic Vegas. Look around you, what do you see?”

I looked. Crowds stumbled along the uneven sidewalks where buskers and peddlers and street performers commanded attention. Couples danced and kissed and smoked and drank. “I see debauchery.”

“People come here to let loose. Look at how many bachelorette groups you see. How many groups of cruising guys. They’re not looking just for dance partners.” He stopped, looked down at me. Dimples formed as he smiled. I wondered if his twin had them, too. “You’re not just looking for a dance partner, are you, Heather?”

He could have kissed me in that moment and I probably wouldn’t have stopped him. My body was humming on the same frequency as the NOLA night, fast and high and relentless. He didn’t, and my gaze slid away from him, back down the street.

Joshua and Scott were there, drinks in hand. Scott pretended to watch a street magician stuff a cigarette up his nose, but my husband couldn’t take his smoldering eyes off of me.

I half-smiled at him, tucked my hair back over my ear, and turned back to Jon. “So you and your brother ever fuck two blondes before?”

“Like at once?”

I stepped closer, tracing my fingers along the flowers of his shirt. “Like at the same time.”

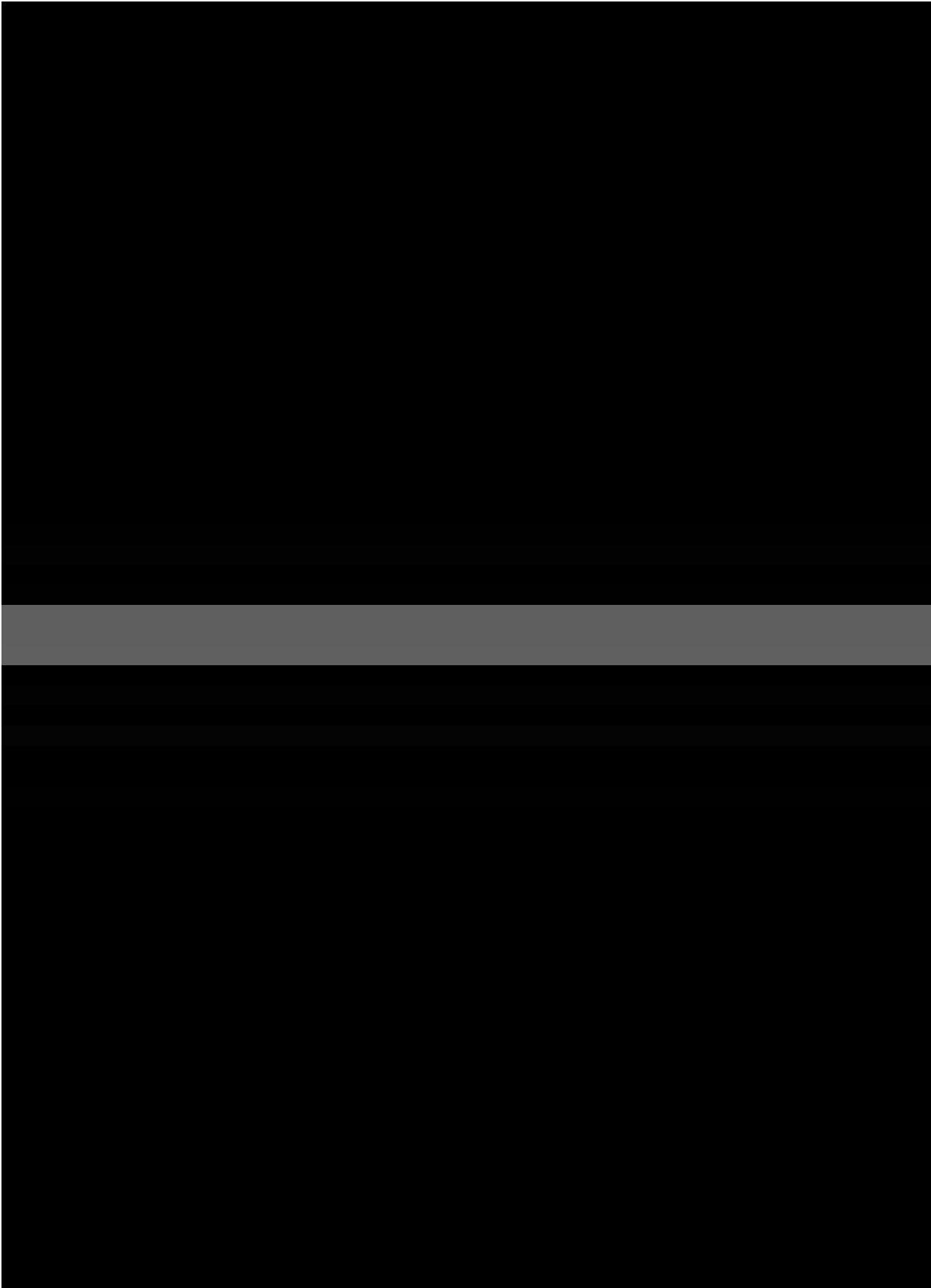
I could feel his heart racing. I made him just as nervous as he made me. It was always a good reminder that in any given situation, the one who appeared in control usually was.

“As a matter of fact, we have,” he said. “And yes, we did take turns with them.” I felt the tables beginning to turn on the game of control. “And yes, they did lose track of who was who.”

I imagined it—two identical men taking me at once, like a fever dream, their hard, toned bodies using me, fucking me, making me scream. It was a fucked up fantasy that I didn’t know I had until that moment.

Skyler cleared her throat. “Excuse me, lovebirds, but we’re going in here!” Jack pulled her before she could finish the sentence, dragging her into the club we’d stopped in front of. A swing band was playing in the back, before a huge crowd of energized dancers.

Jon looked at me, clearly wishing his brother hadn’t interrupted. I shrugged, grabbed his hand, and followed them in.



I love to dance, but ballroom dancing with a partner will always bring me back to a more innocent time. Back in high school, my dad and I took swing lessons as a way to bring us closer. It was a formative moment, not only teaching me how to jump and jive and spin, but actually tightening our bond.

As Jon, and then Jack, lead me into the swinging beat of the live band, I was transported back to that more innocent time. Only there was nothing innocent about this. All it took was a glance at Joshua, watching in the wings, to remind me of that.

Joshua's presence actually helped. I had an audience. I had a partner. I could misbehave if I wanted to, and my husband was right there, eager to watch. The guys I was dancing with were extras in this show. So I played up to that audience. Neither Jon nor Jack were very good dancers, but that let me take control of the swing. I spun into them, shimmied close, wrapped my hand around their necks as our bodies gyrated to the horns and drums and bass. This wasn't my father's swing.

At one point, Skyler slid into Jon's place before me. Unlike the guys, she knew what she was doing. More importantly, she knew how to lead, and make it sexy. We spun and grooved and entwined, drawing an audience of tongue-wagging men and jealous women. They barely registered. Skyler enraptured me, moving me and turning me. At one point, I spun into her arms, my back to her, her arm hugged across my body. My skin was damp with sweat, and her bangs clung to her forehead. Our eyes met and holy hell did I want to kiss that succulent mouth of hers. Everyone around us seemed to hold their breath. Then she spun me away and we fell back into the swinging beat.

When the band took a break, so did we. I needed water. I was handed another frozen drink instead.

"Be right back, guys," Skyler said, taking her drink in one hand and my hand in the other. Not sure where we were going, I followed as she weaved through the thick crowd, back towards the rest rooms.

Skyler let out a loud "whoo!" as she shook her hips to the piped in R&B that substituted the band. A clutch of guys clapped their hands and hooted back.

“Fuck, I love this city!” Skyler shouted. Skyler’s exuberance was as intoxicating as the cocktails we’d already consumed. I couldn’t stop smiling.

“You having fun, Heather?” she asked before pushing into one of the private bathrooms. For a jazz hall off the streets of the French Quarter, it was surprisingly clean.

“A lot of fun—”

Before I could finish that sentence, Skyler pulled me to her and kissed me. Automatically, I kissed her back, tilting my head and putting my hands on the soft swell of her hips. When she pushed her tongue into my mouth, I clutched at her dress. I wanted this. After all the teasing, I needed it. It had been so long since I’d kissed another woman, and it was just as exciting and tender as I remembered.

Skyler peeled her lips away, smiling. “I’ve wanted to do that the whole night,” she said. She giggled, breaking some of the tension I hadn’t realized I was feeling. “You’re so fucking hot.”

This close, her eyes looked even more like a cat’s—playful and unpredictable and sexy. A girl could get intimidated by a woman like this. Luckily, I wasn’t just a girl. “You’re not so bad yourself.”

Skyler’s giggle grew to a laugh as she leaned into me. I stumbled a little, realizing that I was a little more drunk than I’d thought. So was Skyler. She placed a hand on my shoulder to steady herself as she turned to the mirror. Opening her clutch purse, she pulled out her lipstick.

“God, I love this hotwife shit,” she says as she smacks her lips. “It’s the best of both worlds, you know? We get the husband and the home and all that stability, but also the freedom of being single again.”

I’d never considered it like that. Remember, until this moment, my exposure to Joshua was pretty one-sided. It was always about him. It was all about his fantasy. Skyler made a great point—I could have fun with this, too. And, I had to admit, I was having fun.

I pulled out my phone and sent Joshua a quick text.

[Me]: Enjoying the show?

Skyler, reapplying her lipstick, went on. "So I see two possibilities for the rest of the night."

"Do they look identical?"

Skyler snorted. "I've never been with twins," she mused. "But no. Well, yes, but Jon and Jack are one possibility. We could have a whole lot of fun with them."

And we could. Just the thought of it sent tingles through me. I still had some sense, though. "I don't think I'm ready to take that step just yet. You can though. I won't hold it against you."

She ignored my offer, meeting my eyes in the mirror. "So we go with option number two. We sneak out on the twins and reap the rewards for teasing our husbands all night long." The drunken giggle was back. "Those poor guys are probably ready to burst."

My phone buzzed.

[Joshua]: Even more than with David.

It was hard to remain cool. Glancing at my reflection, I was surprised to see that while I was flushed, most of that was from all the dancing.

"So is this what you guys did? Before me? With... his ex?"

Skyler watched me carefully. She wasn't so drunk that she was oblivious to my emotions. Which was good. "A few times, yeah."

"Did you ever go back with the guys you flirted with?"

“You mean me and Mel? No, whenever we were out, it was just to tease. It was all foreplay.”

I texted my husband.

[Me]: I'm so turned on right now.

To Skyler, I said, “But you have when doing this alone?”

Skyler's smile was all the answer I needed—and all she was willing to give. She dropped her lipstick into her purse and pulled something else out, a small, chrome vial, and unscrewed the cap.

My gut squirmed. I knew what this was, and suddenly the night took on a less playful tone. Without even a glance at me, Skyler tipped out a small bit of white powder into the cap. She lifted it to her right nostril and quickly inhaled, tipping her head back slightly as it went down. She glanced at her reflection, touching her nostril with her red lacquered nails.

“Bump?” she offered me.

My heart was going a hundred miles a minute. If she'd pulled a handgun from her bag, I think I would have been more calm. “No, I'm good.”

“You sure? It's good shit.”

Was I trembling? I was trying so hard not to tremble.

“I'm sure.”

Skyler shrugged and did a second bump of coke in the other nostril. I watched her, watching for that moment when her body shuddered and her lips parted just so—as the cocaine entered her blood with a pleasant kick.

It reminded me of my darker days. Days that felt like another lifetime. Joshua knew about Dominic now thanks to the chance encounter. He knew that I'd been

wild. He didn't know about Shane or those lost years after college, when I'd been making too much money and let too many superficial things get to my head. Those were years meant to be forgotten. In so many ways, I'd been attracted to Joshua because he represented a saner, more mature life. Maybe I was wrong.

My phone buzzed. Still dazed, I looked down.

[Joshua]: I need you.

I needed him, too. I felt unmoored, a strong tide pulling me into stormy seas. I needed him to pull me back. Needed him to rescue me from my darker impulses.

"I'm sorry." Skyler was right there, right in front of me, her reassuring voice fading into clarity like the signal of a distant radio. "I didn't mean to spook you. I just assumed you partied."

"Oh, that. No, I'm cool," I said in that way that made me feel decidedly uncool.

"I know you are." She kissed me again and I could almost feel the narcotic energy pouring through her and infusing our kiss. "How about a cigarette instead?" She didn't wait for me to agree. "Come on, let's sneak out the back."

There are currents that take us through our lives. Sometimes they're gentle, easy to escape and just as easy to explore. Sometimes they lead us to good places in the end—a change in career or deciding to go out on a date with that handsome guy. Sometimes they are strong, the outcome inevitable—whether it's good or bad irrelevant.

That night in New Orleans for Joshua's fortieth birthday felt like one of those moments. There was a momentum to the evening I couldn't fight that was beyond just Skyler's hand in mine, pulling me through it.

We were out back when Joshua and Scott joined us. I was smoking a cigarette for the first time in years, and the night felt bright and alive and full of possibility. I hadn't felt that way in years, when eleven o'clock was early and the

sun rise came before bedtime more times than I could count.

I don't remember going back to the apartments where we were staying, but suddenly we were there, our heels echoing off the tiled staircase as we made our way up to the renovated apartment. Nervous energy passed between us in labored breaths and giggles and a forced quiet.

Even as we entered our room, with its high ceilings and access to a wrought iron balcony overlooking the street, no one spoke. Not even Skyler, who'd been a chatterbox all night long. She stared at the king-sized bed and guided me over to it before we turned into one another's arms.

We picked up where we left off in the bar's bathroom. She scooped her hand behind my neck as I wrapped mine around her back, tracing the criss-crossing straps of her tight black dress. We tilted into one another, eyes meeting, noses brushing, lips encroaching. I could feel her warmth flutter against my mouth before she turned her head and denied me the kiss.

She looked at the men, who were loitering around the windows. Scott was busy opening them. Joshua stood, his chest rising and falling like a great cat preparing to bounce.

"Your wife is lovely, Joshua." She turned back to me, whispering into my ear, "And I can't wait to feel your tongue on my pussy."

My breath caught. It was a statement designed to tempt both all of us. Skyler's lips nuzzled up behind my ear as I continued to watch my husband. He gave a short nod. Granting the permission I craved.

Scott found the latch of the windows, throwing them open and letting in the sounds of the NOLA party down below. I turned to Skyler as the horns from down on Frenchman Street enveloped us. I was caught right in that current again, strong and growing stronger, as she finally kissed me.

The kiss earlier caught me by surprise, and was over before my brain could catch up. This one was languid, designed for show, designed to melt into.

Her soft lips parted as she pushed her tongue into my mouth, playful yet demanding. I was up to the challenge as the world swirled around us.

We undressed each other, pulling those tiny dresses over each other's heads. Like I suspected, she wasn't wearing a bra, and her perky little tits were in my mouth before her dress hit the ground.

I loved making her moan. Like I said, it had been so long since I'd fooled around with another woman, and I missed all the little details. Stuff like how long her nipples got as I flicked my tongue against them. How she gasped when I applied just enough pressure. How good it was to slide my fingers into her thong and feel how wet she was—wet because of me.

I went down on her first, as nervous as the first time I ever did it with a girl. Just as excited, too. I was practically shaking as Skyler laid back on the bed and I dragged her panties off. Her pussy was beautiful, ripe and moist, parted like a flower in bloom below the narrowest of landing strips.

I teased her. I teased her mercilessly, touching her everywhere but her clit. The way she had teased me all night long. This was payback, and it was so sweet. I eased my fingers inside of her and watched her brow tighten in a silent plea. It lasted all of a minute, I bet. Skyler wasn't the type to be teased, and ended up grinding her pelvis against my mouth.

Suddenly, it was all I could do to keep up, to breathe, to hold on. She actually wrapped her leg around the back of my neck and held me there as she humped my face. It was either make her come, or pass out trying.

I fingered her, pressing into her g-spot as I sucked on her clit like a mini-cock. She rocked above me, gasping and crying, pulling my hair. It was intense. I distinctly remember thinking how much I love women, and how I couldn't wait for her to return the favor.

We tumbled into the bed, side by side, continuing to kiss and lick and explore one another. I could feel the men watching me, and it was that, more than anything, that fueled the night for me. When Skyler lowered me onto my back and scissored her legs into mine, I glanced over at Joshua, feeling his sharp gaze.

"She's got a pretty pussy, doesn't she, babe?" Skyler asked as she pressed her mound against mine. "Feels fucking great, too."

She wasn't just saying it for the guys. The soft, wet friction of pussy-on-pussy had me moaning right along with her. But then, the guys were also there,

watching their wives tribbing each other into oblivion.

Joshua was silent and stern. Scott, ever more gregarious, had a grin that stretched from ear to ear. It was that grin and his eyes that unlocked the latent exhibitionist high in me—this man, basically a stranger, who now knew that I shaved my pussy bare and liked the way his wife rubbed her clit against mine.

He had blue eyes that I couldn't look away from, even as Skyler rutted faster and faster over me. She held my leg open, grabbing me by the ankle as she flexed her thighs. I kissed her knee, lifting myself up onto my elbows as we twisted together.

“That's it.” I pulled her closer, too, curling my hand behind her ass. “Mmm, yes, Skyler. Yes!”

Even then, I glanced over at Scott—and Joshua—through heavy lids and long lashes. They were ready to join us. I was ready for them to join us.

“Fuck me, Skyler.” I reached up, grabbing her tits. “I'm so close. Get me off!”

She slid off me and sank down between my legs. I yelped at how quick the transition was, going from all the soft, sodden rubbing to her warm mouth and slippery tongue. It was too much, too good, her touch unmistakably that of a woman's. I thrashed on the bed, arching my back and clutching at the sheets as she made me come, screaming.

When the haze cleared, Skyler was still there, still between my legs, still staring up at me with her beautiful face and flushed cheeks. Only now, Scott was behind her, his shirt off and his pants open.

He had a nice cock—stout like the man, much thicker than Joshua, if not quite as long. He ran it through the valley of Skyler's tight buttocks before teasing it against her pussy. As he thrust home, I licked my lips, wondering what that felt like.

Skyler's moans felt wonderful along my pussy, timed with each of Scott's thrusts. But I wanted more than a soft mouth and another woman's tongue. I wanted something harder. My gaze drifted up to Scott, his brawny frame hairy and slick with sweat. He held Skyler's hips in his hands, his thumbs digging into her ass, and was staring at me as he fucked his wife—staring in a way that made

me want to show off even more.

I opened my legs wider. I palmed my tits, squeezing them together as if to say, Imagine how good it would feel to slide that cock between them. I could practically see Scott make the calculation. I wanted to fuck him. I wanted to fuck him so badly. If he'd pulled out of his wife and moved to me, I would have.

Before I could go down that path any more, I looked for Joshua. My husband. The birthday boy. He was the only man still clothed, still standing by the window, arms crossed. I beckoned him over with the crook of a finger, and like all men, he came.

"Your friends are nice." My voice was throaty from all the sex.

Joshua snorted, looking down at Skyler, whose white-gold hair was plastered to her forehead, her eyes on us. She lifted her chin just enough that we could see the corners of her lips curl up. "Get that cock into her, Josh. I want to see something hard splitting it open."

I laughed, looking from Skyler to my husband. It was all moving so fast. I didn't even have a chance to wonder how we got here. I was being lifted, scooted up on the bed so that Joshua could slide in between my legs.

He was so hard, harder than usual—hard in a way that I now associated with David and Dominic and stories of my past. But he was also familiar. I knew the contours of that cock. I welcomed him as he slid into me.

Our kiss was a passionate reunion, greeting one another after I almost strayed. "Did you like watching me with her?"

"It was amazing." He kissed me again. "You looked into it."

I ran my hands over his svelte body, caressing his taut muscles. Kissing his neck, I whispered, "What can I say? You married a horny, bisexual woman, and then invited a woman who looks like that into our lives."

Skyler was beside us again, the two friends having moved up the bed. Scott was still behind her, fucking her doggy style. "You talking about me?" she asked before leaning down and kissing me again. "I was half-hoping you were just bi-curious." Another kiss. "Although no one eats pussy like that on their first try."

We made out right there, inches from Joshua, like his personal porn show. Our kisses were deep and full of tongue, and once again, I lost myself in the moment. Only this time, I had Joshua's hard shaft pumping in and out, ready to burst.

Thing with Joshua, though, was that he didn't want his cock pumping me. He wanted to watch another man do it, and the height of this wild moment had blown away his inhibitions.

Skyler crested first, tearing her lips away from me and burying her face in the sheets. Her whole body shuddered with each powerful drive of Scott's body. I wanted to feel that next. I wanted to feel that block of a man crash against my parted thighs. And Skyler was right—this is the appeal of the hotwife. We could do these things and still have all the benefits of a marriage and a husband.

“Fuck, I need a bump.” Skyler crawled out of bed and headed for the bathroom, her ass bouncing with her springy steps. She scooped up her purse along the way before disappearing from view.

Scott, always smiling, got off the bed too, watching his wife until she was gone. He didn't join her, though, his attention returning to me. He was still hard.

“You can,” Joshua whispered. It felt like it was all in the background. All my attention, every ounce of it, was on this barrel-chested man and his naked body as he crawled over to us.

When he leaned over and kissed me, time stuttered. Or maybe that's just how I remember it all these years later. Joshua came with his quiet intensity as Scott palmed my breast, his touch callused and unfamiliar and exciting because of it.

Joshua squeezed my hands one last time as he slid off of me, rolling onto his side. This was it. This was going to happen. Scott was there before me, his body rising between my splayed knees.

I glanced at Joshua at my side. He was my tether to all that was sane and real. He was there as Scott mounted me, as he leaned down and kissed me. I'll never forget that kiss—wild and unbridled in a way that two people do just before they have sex. He put a hand on my knee, pushing my legs wider. I reached down and wrapped my hand around his cock, anticipating what it would feel like to take all of that girth. It'll hurt. It'll feel so fucking good.

I pulled him close, against my pussy. I watched as the tip began to split me open. Beside me, Joshua's breath caught.

And then he was gone, and Skyler was screaming bloody murder at him, and everything was moving so fast.

She was there, eyes wild, her fury scattering us like a maelstrom. "You pig!" she screamed at her husband as she dug her nails into his chest, leaving angry streaks of pink. "I knew you just wanted to fuck this slut!"

It was Joshua who grabbed her off of his friend. It was Joshua who snapped to action, gathering the things of the squabbling couple before kicking them out. I was too stunned to do anything, still in shock over what I'd come so close to doing. I'd had another man's cock in my hand. I'd felt the tip enter me. Had I just cheated?

By the time they were gone and things had settled down, the moment had passed. Here's where some men would ask if I was okay, or make some corny joke about our shared brush with... whatever that was.

Joshua, as I've said, is a man of single-minded focus. "If that hadn't happened, you would have fucked him."

"Oh, God, I think so." Like that, the absurdity of the last half hour gave way to guilt and shame and worry. "I'm so sorry—"

"The way you stared at him—"

"I'm so sorry." I covered my face.

Joshua peeled my hands away. "Don't be."

He was there, his face as hard as ever, only now I could see the light behind it, a fire that I haven't seen burn this brightly since the night he caught me with David.

"It's what I want." With that, he pushed into me, his cock once again swollen and hard and full. "Tell me it's what you wanted, too."

I wasn't sure if I should. Honesty, I was scared. Joshua could be so

unpredictable, so prone to wild moods. But there was no disputing how hard he was. No doubt that something had him excited.

Pulling him down to me, I whispered in his ear, “I couldn’t wait to feel how thick he was.” Joshua grunted. “And I’m sooo disappointed that I didn’t.”

That triggered Joshua. He folded me in half and hammered me with his hips, his face red and his hair shaken into a wild bloom of salt and pepper.

“Even just the tip felt enormous.”

Joshua barked out his orgasm, his heat filling me, triggering my own throbbing orgasm. I arched up into him and shut my eyes, daring to imagine Scott coming inside me, filling me with all that liquid excitement.

Joshua collapsed beside me, panting hard enough that I worried about him. I rested my head on his chest, listening to his heart beat like a jack rabbit’s. He stroked my hair as we started to sober up.

“Are you okay, Joshua?”

I wished I could see his face, but was also relieved that I couldn’t. Even his short hesitation felt like a wedge between us. “Never been better.”

I turned to him. “You’d tell me if you weren’t?”

He wouldn’t, but humored me with the easy lie. I let it go.

“Welcome to your forties.”

His chuckle was genuine. “Any more days like this and I don’t think I’ll make it to 50.”

It was good to joke like that. Meant that maybe, just maybe, we’d make it there together.

■

Recharge

I pause to yawn, and I'm back in the present. I blink, surprised to see that we're not in the apartment in New Orleans, but Eleanor's sunlit guest house. "What time is it?"

"Almost noon." Eleanor rises. "Why don't we take a break. I'll fix us something to eat."

I rise with her. "Let me help."

"It's okay. You relax. You've had a hard night. I'll be right back."

"You sure?"

"Of course. Then, we can get back to the juicy details of your sexual history." Before I know it, she steps forward and kisses me softly on the lips. It lingers a moment too long to be merely friendly, and when she steps back, there's a flush in her cheeks. She doesn't apologize, though, merely smiles and heads for the door.

I stand there, the kiss buzzing on my lips. Eleanor, I must remember, is Eleanor—a woman newly awakened to the sexually-charged world. I don't know all the details of what she's done with Paul, but I know enough. She's as sexual as she is sweet.

This house with its cameras is proof of that. How kinky. They must record the sessions. I wonder if Joshua would ever do something like that. I wonder if somewhere, they have a recording of Paul...

It sends a thrill through me. I check my phone, hoping to find something from Joshua, but there's nothing there but Paul's old one: "Hey, how's it going? I'm

sorry I took advantage of you last night. Hope I didn't make your life too much of a mess. I'm sorry."

I settle back into the sofa, intending to just relax as instructed. I must have drifted off, because the next thing I know, the sun is coming in through the windows at a new angle, and my stomach grumbles as I wake.

Eleanor is adjusting a blanket over me when I open my eyes and blink away the sleep.

"Oh, sorry to wake you," she whispers.

"What time is it?"

"Four-thirty. I came back with some lunch, but you were asleep and looked so peaceful."

"Thanks. I guess I needed that."

"Feel better?"

I rub my empty stomach. "Not really."

Eleanor laughs lightly. "Want to grab some dinner?"

I think of her family, and how much I've already imposed. "I don't want to be a burden."

She shakes her head. "Don't be. They're all out, anyway. Seeing some Pixar movie."

"Oh, are you missing that because of me?"

"It's fine. I'm not crazy about those things, anyway, and it's good for Ronald to get some time with the kids. Let me order some food. We can keep talking whenever you'd like."

She's wearing a little sundress... "Should I change?" I ask, looking at my yoga pants and knit top.

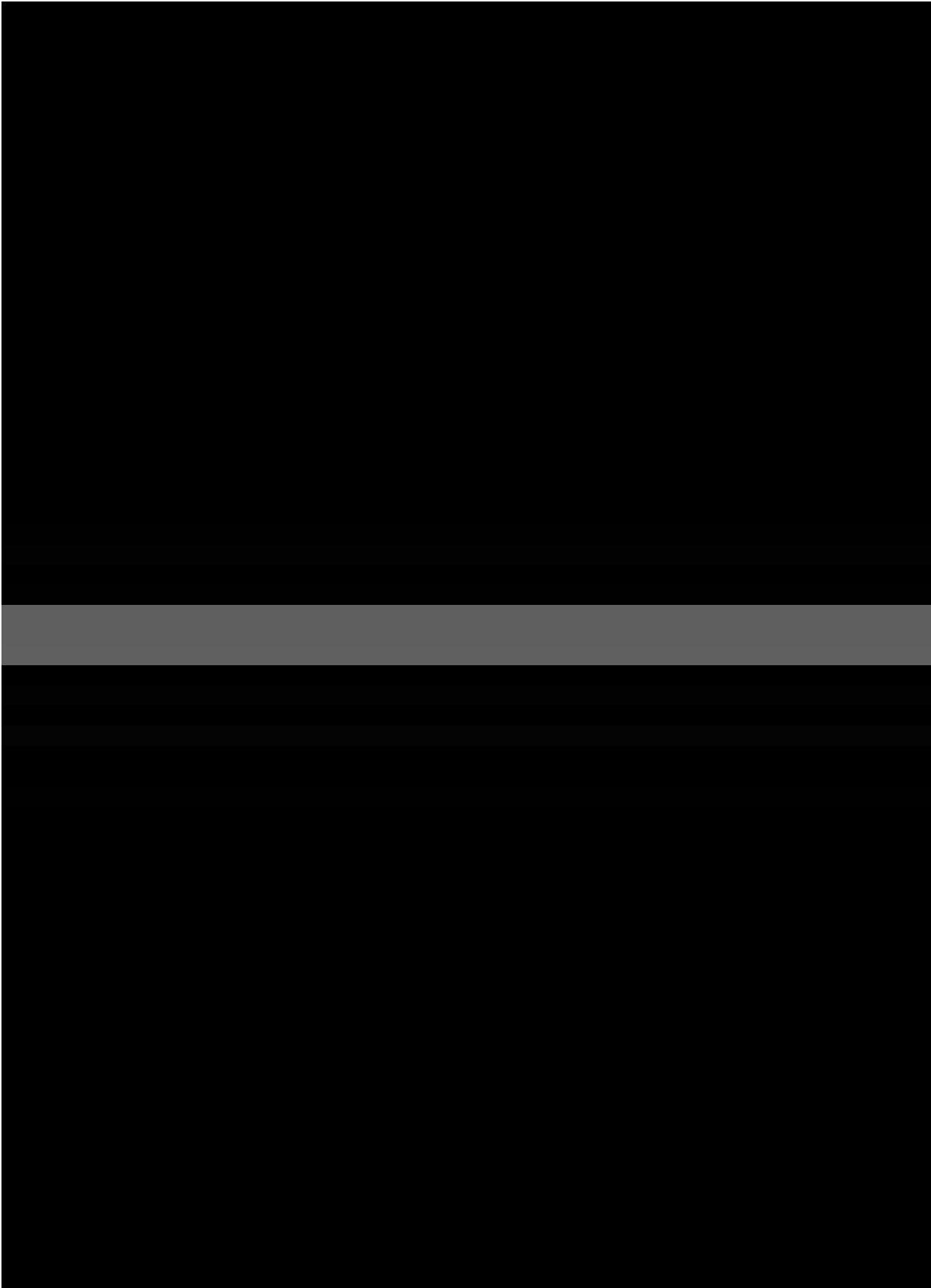
"No, don't be silly."

She pats my leg before getting up to retrieve some menus from the kitchenette. As she rattles off the names of take-out places, I think about how nice it is to have someone like her.

“Thank you, Eleanor.”

She pauses, seeing the emotion in my face, and smiles at me. “It’s going to be okay, Heather.” She holds up the menu for a local pizza place. It’s funny in its incongruity—this high society English woman holding a crumpled menu with a closeup of a slice of pizza being pulled off the pie. “What do you like on your pizzas?”

I laugh.



We return to the sofas after the order is placed, the two of us facing one another, feet curled up like we're having a slumber party. All that's missing are our jammies.

"Ready to talk some more? Or should I get the wine?"

I shake my head. "No more wine, please. I've already had way too much."

"You watch what you drink, and I get the feeling it's not because you're counting calories."

I chuckle. "Well, that's part of it."

"Part of something else."

"I've made mistakes in the past when too much alcohol is introduced."

"Like last night? With Paul?"

"Like that. But..." I feel color climb my neck. "That was honestly pretty tame compared to my past."

She nods thoughtfully. Before Joshua? And worry that you'll become that woman again?"

"Not quite." She doesn't try to read my mind. She gives me room to think, and I'm grateful for the space. "I'm not ashamed of who I was or what I did in my early twenties." I pause. "Well, not ashamed of most of it. It was a phase—a really fun phase—but...a phase."

Eleanor looks thoughtful and, if I'm not mistaken, envious. I note it and quickly forget.

"Thing is, I like sex. A lot. Joshua's hotwife fantasy and all that's lead to—even the bad stuff—has reminded me how much I like it. Not in the I'm-worried-that-I'll-lose-control-and-become-a-whore kind of way. Just...kind of like giving up cigarettes and smelling one again after years.

“After New Orleans, I thought a lot about what Skyler had said—I got to feel like I was single again, with all the uncertainty and potential, without actually being single. Skyler was batshit crazy, but that resonated. I had a partner in my singleness. Joshua and I, we were co-conspirators in this wild thing. The years after New Orleans were all about exploring. For the first time since he’d introduced it—”

“You let yourself have fun.”

I nod. “Yeah. I was always so worried about Joshua. He can get so jealous, and he’s got so much baggage with his ex. But yeah, I guess New Orleans normalized things. By the time Paul entered our lives, I started wondering if maybe I could do it with a guy like him. Not actually with Paul, mind you, but a guy like him.”

“Why not him? He’s actually a great guy underneath all that rampant testosterone.”

“For sure. But he was also a client, which definitely complicated things.” I glance up at Eleanor, realizing that here was a woman who had an affair with him regardless of their controversial, social dynamics.

She laughs it off. “Don’t worry, I understand what you’re saying. It’s definitely complicated.”

“So I was there on the cusp. I mean, so close. I had a profile on DeBauch. We were meeting up with potential guys together. If Joshua was just a little more patient...” The anger rose through me again. “He had to go and force it. He couldn’t give me any more space. I wanted to go out and cross that line with Joshua. All he wanted was for me to do it. Period. At all costs. And that’s why I stormed out last night.”

We sit there quietly. I am a maelstrom again, lost and not sure what comes next. Eleanor reaches out along the back of the sofa, closing her hand over mine. “It’s going to be okay, Heather.”

I force a smile, even as tears well up. The worst thing, the thing I don’t confess—that I can’t confess—is how amazing an experience it was with Paul. How, despite all the anxiety and anger I’m feeling, above all of it is this sense of exhilaration. I know that it’s a fairytale, but I have this guilty feeling that it’ll all

be okay with Paul. Not with my husband.

The doorbell rings before I can wrangle my thoughts. Our pizza is here. Eleanor hops up. “Stay right there and hold that thought.”

I do. Or try to. I stand, looking around this place as I begin to ponder the enormity of what comes next. How long will I be here? Will I need to go get my things from our house? Will Eleanor be okay if I bring my dog, Spock, here, because there is no way in hell Joshua would take care of him.

I’m standing by the time Eleanor returns with a box of wonderfully—and unhealthy—smelling pizza. I can feel tears welling up in my eyes. “Thank you, Eleanor. I’m not sure what I would have done without you.”

“You would have been fine.”

I force a laugh. “You say it with such certainty.”

“Because I’m certain. I’ve watched you. You’re capable and strong. Inspiring, really.”

“I’m not perfect.”

“No one is. We’re all complicated. It’s what makes us interesting.” She lifts the pizza box. “Perfect people are boring, anyway.”

“Well, I’m definitely not boring then.” I laugh. “But that’s not exactly what I’m talking about. I just... I’ve just never had a friend like... like you.”

“Come on, let’s go eat this thing out on the patio.” The Mary Poppins in her is back as she tuts and ushers me out to the patio. I follow, led along by the smell of the pizza and the promise of comfort.

Like the rest of her home, the flagstone patio is professionally designed. I uncover the furniture, upending the shallow pools left from last night’s rain as Eleanor turns on the string lights overhead. She moves behind the bar, where she set the pizza down, and starts to brew some coffee.

I open the pizza. When was the last time was that I had something so greasy? I don’t care. I pull a piece off and bite into it, my mouth watering. Eleanor laughs.

She says, “You know what? It’s nice to have someone to talk to about all of this.”

“Thanks for that.”

Eleanor pulls a piece of pizza off for herself. “I’m actually talking about myself. This lifestyle isn’t exactly something I can chat about with the PTA moms, you know?”

I realize that with all my opening up, I haven’t asked her about her own life, her own problems. “How’s that going? You and Ronald seem good.”

“We are. He’s a sweet man. I’m lucky to have him.”

“No...friction?”

Eleanor smiles. “Only the good kind. He’s really into it. And it’s fun to tease him, you know?”

“Yeah. The teasing is my favorite part.”

“Guys are so easy. All it takes is a ‘misplaced’ statement or a casual comment about another man and they get all turned on and jealous. It’s delicious.”

“Ronald gets jealous?”

“Of course. I think that it’s part of what makes it so exciting for him.”

“Seems like an exhausting fantasy to have, honestly.”

“It’s an addiction.”

“I guess so. Are we enablers?”

Eleanor pauses. “I’ve never thought about it like that. I don’t think I am. I’m having fun. He’s having fun. What’s the harm?”

The harm is when everything gets out of balance. The danger is what happened last night.

Eleanor begins to say something, then holds back. I see her working up her nerve

to ask me something. At this point, I'm an open book to her. "Go ahead, Elie." Paul's cutesy name for her comes easily. She doesn't seem to mind it. "What's on your mind?"

"So that time in your early twenties..." My stomach quivers, not expecting her to go there. "You say you don't miss it?"

"No, I think I said that it was a phase that I outgrew. I don't smoke cigarettes anymore, but that doesn't mean I don't miss it."

"Why does that make you blush?"

It's only then that I realize just how hot my face is. The summer evening air suddenly feels so hot. "You have the term in England, sex, drugs, and rock-and-roll?"

"I've heard it before." It's then that I see the hunger in her face. She leans in. "Drugs?"

I feel so ashamed. I think of Eleanor's family, her kids, her happy home. I think of her position on the board at Dawning and how established she is in her life. I want to lie to her, but I don't. "Yeah. It was pretty prevalent in the circle I ran in."

"Like... marijuana?"

"Yeah, for sure. But also harder stuff. Ecstasy, meth, acid. But my drug of choice was definitely cocaine." Saying it is like unburdening myself of my past, something that I thought I was at peace with until the shame hit me.

Eleanor's eyes flare, her mouth parts, but she's not put off. She licks her lips, like she's hungry for more. I give her more.

"I partied a lot, mostly during the time after college. I hitched onto this PR consultancy firm—one of the big players. I traveled all the time. Had more money than a young girl knew what to do with. Made me reckless."

She wants to know how reckless. She wants examples, and for the first time, I'm ready to give some.

“I fucked my boss. That became a regular thing. Every time we traveled together, we got adjoining rooms, but I spent all the time in his bed.” Eleanor is quiet, but she’s breathing hard enough that her shoulders are rising and falling. “I fucked my clients—not to win any contracts or anything, but just because they were hot and I was high and looking for a good time.”

Eleanor is riveted. I worry that I’m glamorizing my past. “It wasn’t all good, Elle. I lost my best friend because of it. I seduced her into a threesome with a guy I was seeing at the time. She’d never been with another woman before.”

I can almost hear Eleanor’s gulp. “Not a bad first.”

“She never spoke to me again.”

Eleanor casts her eyes down, and I hate that I shamed her. “I’m sorry.”

“But that wasn’t the worst. Even that wasn’t enough to snap me out of that phase of my life.”

She licks her lips. “What was?”

I chew on my lower lip. I never told anyone about Shane. I didn’t think I ever would. Even now, I can feel the temptation to make something up and keep this one buried.

“So there was this guy...”

-

Shane

I met Shane at a bar in San Diego while I was out there for a conference. I was looking for someone to play with on that first night, and he was exactly what I was looking for. Attractive in this Italian American/Goodfellas way, there was always an air of danger around him. Of menace. I knew before he even came over that he was bad news.

He actually thought that I was a hooker that first time. We did the usual banter thing in the bar. I put out all my signals and the next thing we knew, we were in my room and my tiny dress was on the floor.

He fucked the way he looked—aggressively, dominantly. It was an amazing night, one of the best fucks of my young life. And when he went to leave, he pulled out his wallet and started to count off hundred dollar bills.

I was so shocked. I didn't know what to say at first. I was embarrassed for both of us, you know? I think I said something like, "I'm not a prostitute," or something.

Shane just chuckled and set some hundred dollar bills onto the nightstand anyway. "You could be."

I should have been insulted. Instead, it turned me on. I looked at the stack of bills, then at Shane, and said, "Looks like you paid for at least another hour. Come back to bed."

He didn't leave until the next morning.

Like me, Shane was on the road more than he was home, but his travel was flexible enough that we were able to meet throughout the country and it was always an amazing time. I felt like giddy every time I flew somewhere that I

knew Shane would be. It wasn't love, for sure, but it was something. The man was exciting. He pushed my boundaries in exciting and terrifying ways.

I actually slept with my first prostitute along with him. She was a stripper at this club he took me to in Atlanta. "Candy." She was a brunette with blonde streaks through her hair and fake, yet tasteful, tits. She was gorgeous. I can still remember her eyes, large and sultry.

"You're so pretty," I remember telling her as she danced for Shane.

"Aw, thanks." When she smiled, those eyes lit up even more.

Looking right at me, he told the stripper, "Dance for her."

When she started to move into my lap, Shane said, "In the back room."

So I went into my first ever strip club back room and got the experience of my young life. Apparently the rules were more relaxed when it came to female patrons, and before the second song was even over, Candy was licking my pussy as she fingered herself.

"You want to play with her some more?" Shane asked as our half-hour wrapped up.

She watched me as she slipped back into her g-string and tiny skirt. "I'd love to," I said.

"What do you say, Candy? Want to make a little extra money?"

"A little? No. But if you're willing to part with more, I'm sure we could work something out." The way she said it, without hesitation, without the awkwardness that I was feeling, stuck with me long after we left Atlanta.

"How does a grand sound?"

We could both see her face light up at the figure, although she tried to play it cool. Shane, naturally, didn't let her.

"But for that much, my expectations are pretty fucking high. You understand?"

There were dollar signs in her eyes when she agreed.

We went back to our hotel room, where Shane made the two of us perform for him as he watched. Once he was good and hard—and I'd made her come—he fucked her ass as I continued to eat her out. I'd only ever had anal sex with Dominic, and he was so large that we only tried it once. With Shane, he didn't even ask, and I didn't attempt to deny. He just looked at me and said, "Now it's your turn," and I was there.

That was my problem with Shane—I could never resist. Worse, he knew that I couldn't.

We had this on-again-off-again relationship for over a year. Each time we got together, things were electric. I started picking clients and arranging meetings just so I could see him again, knowing that we'd have a wild time. We went down to Cabo San Lucas and partied hard. We went to Ibiza and partied harder.

On one trip to Sacramento, where I grew up, Shane met up with me. This is when I slept with my high school best friend. We seduced her together. She'd never been with another woman, had a threesome, or snorted cocaine. We gave her those three firsts. It was hot and we all had a great night, but it was devastating to our friendship afterwards. It was around this time that I started to think of Shane as a problem. Not that I stopped seeing him.

The first time Shane pimped me out to a business partner, like every other crazy thing we did together, was so very wrong, and because it was so wrong, it was intoxicating. That's basically the story of my relationship with Shane. He pushed me to do things I never thought I would, and every time I was with him felt ripe with this thrilling possibility.

I met up with Shane at the tail end of one of his business trips in Miami. I was sunning on the beach—topless but on my stomach—when Shane finished up his meeting and came out to join me. With him was Luis, this Cuban businessman who was really hot.

"Heather, this is Luis."

I shaded my eyes and looked up at him, fully aware that he was trying to catch a glimpse of my tits as I rose like that. "Nice to meet you, Luis. You a friend of Shane's?"

“Luis doesn’t speak English.” In fluent Spanish, Shane turned to the other man and said something. Luis replied in Spanish, and Shane translated. “He says it’s very nice to meet you. And actually, we just met today. Luis works for an import/export business.”

“I see. So he’s here for business.” I didn’t look away from the Cuban, whose dark eyes were delightfully hungry.

Shane said something in Spanish, then laughed at whatever Luis said back. “He says that right now, he’s here for pleasure.”

I pushed up onto my elbows, enough that I knew both men could see my nipples. “Looks like that makes two of us. Mind tying up my top?”

It was a question for Shane, but he redirected it to Luis, who squatted down beside me and retied my string bikini across my back, his hands touching me more than was necessary. I closed my eyes and rested my cheek on my hands. “Tell him that he’s got nice hands.”

Shane translated. Luis spoke again.

“He says you have nice skin, and...” Shane listened. “...and he loves your hair... He says that he loves blondes.”

“Not many blondes in Cuba?”

Shane squatted down beside me, grinning at this exchange. “He wants to know if you’re a natural blonde. Are you a natural blonde, Heather?”

I blushed at the attention between these two men. I’d had a plenty of threesomes with two guys before, but Shane and I hadn’t gone there yet. I had a feeling that was about to change.

“I am.”

Luis spoke. Shane chuckled. “He wants to know if you’re shaved.”

“Wow, that’s forward.” I looked right at the other man. “I’m always shaved.”

“Luis here would very much like to see that.” He looked at the Cuban. “In fact,

he says he'll pay you a grand if you go back to his room, right now."

"What?"

Shane laughed. "I know, right?" The two men had a rapid exchange in Spanish, and for one small moment, I thought that Shane was actually standing up for me. I should have known better. "Okay, he says he'll go to two grand, and he'll throw in some blow."

"Shane..."

"Go on, Heather. You know you want to. Look at him. You find him attractive, right?" Like I said, Shane had this way with me. "Go and be my little coke whore. Do it."

It all should have grossed me out being treated like a commodity like that. Maybe I would have felt differently if Luis was old and overweight and unattractive. He wasn't, though, and before I knew that I'd made up my mind, I was rising, taking Luis in my hand, and leading him off the beach.

I looked back at Shane, who just grinned at me. He loved corrupting, more than anything else. "Have fun, princess. And think about all that money you'll be making."

The money. Yeah, I did think about that. All night long. As I was sucking Luis's cock. As I pushed him down between my legs to feast on my shaved snatch. As I rode him, my fingers clutching his dark chest hair. When he pulled out at the end and came all over my tits, all I could think about was that I was doing this for money. I actually blew him back to hardness just to fuck him again because I was not yet satiated.

That wasn't the last time that Shane pimped me out, although it was the most intense because it was my first—most intense, that is, until my last experience. This is the one that ended things between us. This is the one that's hardest to talk about.

We were in Las Vegas, of all places. Our first time there together, and I knew that Shane would really push things in the spirit of that city. I wasn't wrong. He got me this leopard-print dress, strapless and so short it practically showed off my ass cheeks. I never would have worn something like that by choice. I even

told him that it made me feel like a hooker.

“Like you’ve objected to that before,” he said as I cut up lines of pre-party coke on the hotel suite’s coffee table.

“So we’re doing that again?” I snorted a hit, rubbing my nostrils to make sure I got all the residue off. “What are you, some kind of cuck?”

Shane grabbed me by the hair and yanked my head back. “No.”

The coke surged through me, infusing me with confidence. “You like dressing me up for other men.”

“I like making you do it.” He released my hair. “Take off your panties.”

It was like I knew he’d order me to do that, and the clairvoyance made me giggle. “But this dress is so short—”

“Take them off.”

I slipped my thong off, leaving me with absolutely nothing beneath the leopard-print titty dress. He slipped his hand beneath the hem, rubbing my clit. I gasped.

“You like selling your body for me.” He pushed two fingers into me.

“Nghh!”

“You like being my whore.” His thumb went into my anus, and my body swooned over the coffee table. “Don’t you?”

“Yes.” I grinded my teeth.

“You like fucking the men I bring you.”

“I do.” Every one of them was a man I’d fuck without being paid to fuck, but the money always added an extra level of transgression.

“You’re hot, thinking about it now, aren’t you?”

His fingers felt so good, working my ass and pussy. He added his other hand, fingertips tickling my clitoris until I was bucking back against his touch.

“We’re in Vegas, baby. So many wild possibilities. You ready to cross some more lines?”

“Uhhh, fuuckk...” I pressed my cheek to the glass coffee table top as I sought my orgasm. Reaching back, I found his cock hard. I wanted that.

“Yeah, you are. We’re gonna have some fun tonight.”

He knew I was on the cusp of release. A couple more strokes was all it would take. And then his touch was gone, leaving me gasping and splayed out on the table.

“No—”

“No time for that, Heather. Time to get downstairs and find that fun.”

We went down to one of the casino lounges—this swanky place with a bar that glowed and refreshingly no video poker screens. We settled into a booth in the corner with a good view of the whole place and ordered a couple cocktails.

“See anyone you like?” Shane asked, scanning the place.

“The blonde at the bar is pretty hot.”

“Probably also working it. Better watch out for her. She may think you’re trespassing on her turf.”

“I mean, I kind of am.” This was a bad idea. I almost said it, but kept the thought to myself. “Okay, what about the guy at the high top.”

“With the MGD? He couldn’t afford you.”

“I think that’s a compliment?”

“You’re high class, Heather. Don’t forget it.”

I could hear the sarcasm. Somehow, he made even the nicest things sound backhanded.

The blonde approached my MGD guy a moment later. Shane snickered as we watched. The two flirted. She whispered something that made him tense up. He

was wearing a ring, something I only noticed once he started rubbing it self-consciously. The blonde tried something again, and reluctantly he nodded. The two left the bar a few minutes later.

“Cheap whore. She’ll be back within the hour.” Shane was so biting.

“She’s just earning a living. It’s a job for her.”

He looked at me like I’d just delivered a joke that he didn’t quite understand. I saw judgement there, and worried that it was directed at me, not her. Looking back, I hate how weak I was with him.

“Who else. Try harder. I need you to get more ambitious, Heather. We’re in fucking Vegas. Live a little.”

Just then, they walked in. Three black guys clapping each other on the back and grinning as they came in from the casino floor. Maybe it was the booze and the coke. Most likely it was Shane’s encouragement. As I watched those three guys stroll in, I couldn’t help but think about being on my knees between all three. It had been a while since I’d been with a black man, and I’d never done three at once.

Shane saw who’d caught my attention and smiled broadly. “Now you’re getting into the spirit.”

“No, I couldn’t—”

“Please. We both know that you could. And you definitely want to.”

“Shane—”

“Ten grand. That’s what you charge for a gangbang.”

Gangbang. The raunchy word stole my breath. It was like he’d reached beneath my skirt and flicked my clit.

“Now go. Do your thing and bring me back all that money.”

“They won’t go for it.”

“But you’re gonna try.”

I drained my cocktail, pulled the hem of my tiny dress down, and sashayed over to the three men, who’d settled in at the bar.

“Evening, gentlemen. Buy me a drink?”

They were so tall, looming over me even in heels. It made that image of being on my knees all the more real. I tamped my nervousness down even as my stomach did flips, meeting the middle guy’s eyes with a confident stare of expectation.

He chuckled. “You look like a tequila girl. You a tequila girl, blondie?”

“I can be whatever kind of girl you want me to be. Is tequila what you’re in the mood for tonight?”

The men shared a grin. “Baby, we’re always in a tequila mood. What’s your name?”

“Heather.”

“Nice to meet you, Heather. I’m Anton.” Anton, who had a deliciously shaved head, broad shoulders, and a clipped goatee. “This is Joey,” the tallest of the three. “And Rashaad,” who had a stocky, weight-lifter’s build. “And we just won a fuckload of money at the blackjack tables.”

“Congratulations. Maybe champagne’s called for.”

“Or you could be our celebration,” Anton said. “Rash, order us a round of tequila shots.”

“That could be arranged,” I said, stepping close to Anton and walking my fingers along the buttons of his shirt. “If you’re willing to part with some of those winnings.”

He chuckled, seemingly unfazed by my offer. “You talking to just me? Because we were all winners here tonight.”

I looked from Anton to Rashaad and Joey, my chest tightening with anticipation. Meeting Anton eye-to-eye, I said, “No, not just you.”

He laughed at that. “Damn, babe. When in Vegas, right?”

I smiled, twirling my blond hair between my fingers. “When in Vegas.”

“How much?”

“Ten and you all get me. All night long.” Saying it aloud sounded so ridiculous. I made good money consulting, but ten thousand dollars was still a crazy amount of money to spend on a whim, for just one night. I prepared to be laughed at.

Instead, he reached out and touched my cheek. “For that much money, we’re not going to be taking turns. You follow?”

My whole body felt dipped in fire. “I follow.”

The shots were handed out, and Anton made the toast. “To fucking winning in Vegas.”

The tequila helped calm my nerves as we exited the bar and headed for the elevators. I wished I had more coke, although I was buzzing hard enough that I didn’t need it to feel good. I glanced back at Shane, still sitting in the booth.

“So why are you guys in Vegas?” I asked as we piled into the elevator. Mercifully, no one joined us.

“Joey’s getting married,” Anton said.

“Congratulations.” I turn to the tallest of the men, slipping my hands around his arm. It feels like the trunk of a small tree. “She’s a lucky girl.”

“She is.” He had a quiet smile that I found more attractive than Anton’s brashness—although that had its place, too.

“Although tonight, I think that I’m going to be the lucky girl.”

The elevator stopped. We spilled out into the hall, me still on Joey’s arm with Anton and Rashaad leading the way. Their suite was a mirror of the one Shane and I were in. It was all one large room, with a circle of couches around a wall-mounted television, and a couple beds on the opposite side of the room.

I couldn't help it. I asked, "Which one of you boys shares a bed?"

"Whoever won the least sleeps on the couch," Rashaad said, shoving Anton playfully.

"I was up on you until that last hand, motherfucker."

"No one made you double down with a stack of 5 K."

Anton looked at me and shrugged. "Easy come, easy go."

I licked my lips, my adrenaline spiking. "About the money..."

"Of course, business before pleasure." Anton nodded his chin towards Rashaad. "Big winner, pay her."

It was clear who the alpha of this group of alpha men were. With my arm still linked with Joey, I turned to Rashaad and kissed him. His lips were full and his tongue demanding as he pushed it into my mouth.

Joey moved behind me, running his hands along my waist and out onto my hips. Lower, he caught the edge of my high-riding dress and pulled it up.

"Damn, she's not wearing panties," he whispered, almost to himself.

Anton broke the kiss and grinned. "Little slut."

"Isn't that what you want?" I reached down, crossing my arms as I grabbed the bottom of my dress and pulled it up over my head, leaving me naked other than my heels. "You boys ready for this?"

Anton palmed my breast as I turned my head and kissed Joey. My hands explored, groping them, discovering that both possessed cocks that lived up to the myth of the black man.

I dropped to my knees as Rashaad joined us, money in hand. I didn't bother counting it. Just seeing it sent a surge of excitement through me. I unzipped each of them, fishing their thick, dark cocks out and sucking them one by one as I jerked the others off.

They stripped, a circle of towering man-flesh over me, around me, as I knelt in their shadows. My pussy throbbed. My body hummed. I forgot about the money and the situation, forgot about who I was outside of this room, outside of this circle of men. I was their plaything and like a bowl of fucking ice cream I savored every guilty moment of it.

They used my mouth, my face, my throat. They drove their cocks deep until I nearly gagged, my gasps and moans coming out like frothy gurgles that I knew they loved.

We moved to the bed, where I rolled a condom on Joey, the groom-to-be, and straddled him. “You’re so big,” I groaned as I lowered onto his monster. He was. Biggest I’d been with, before or since.

At first, they took turns with me on the bed. Rashaad, with a cock as thick as his barreled chest, took me missionary, emptying his come into his condom. Anton was last, fucking me doggy-style as he spanked my ass.

“She’s got a nice booty for a skinny, white girl, don’t she?” he said, slapping it harder.

The others agreed.

“You like getting fucked in the ass, Heather?”

He felt so good. So full. I gripped the bedsheets and held on as he drove his powerful hips against me, over and over. I mumbled something into the sheets.

“What’s that? I didn’t catch it?”

“Yes.”

“You like it?”

Thinking of any of these guys taking me back there was scary, but that also made it thrilling. “Oh, yeah.” I gasped. “I love—” I moaned. “—love anal.”

“Fuck yeah, you do.”

He pulled out of my pussy, bracing for what came next as he slid his cock along

that sensitive bridge between pussy and ass. “Spread those cheeks for me, baby,” he ordered.

With my face down on the bed, I reached behind me, grabbed my ass cheeks, and pulled them apart as Anton placed his thick cock head against my anus. I relaxed my body and calmed my breath, just as Shane trained me to do. We’d been practicing ever since Atlanta. He made me get a butt plug. We’d used anal beads. He took my ass at least once every time we got together.

None of that prepared me for the fullness of Anton’s black cock as it entered my ass.

“Fuck!” I barked, the pain almost as intense as the pleasure. “Ohhhh—FUCK!”

“Damn, babe, you’re tight back here.” He didn’t stop. He kept pushing and the pressure inside my ass kept building and building. “Take that BBC, you whore. We all know you want it.”

It felt like my eyes were trying to roll back into my skull. I knew I was moaning, but I felt deaf to it. To all of it. I entered the liminal state between profound pleasure and pain, and it was there that the orgasms started to roll.

“Fuck, guys, she’s really into it,” I think Anton announced just as he began to really fuck my ass. He grabbed my elbows, pulling my arms until I was strung out like a bow before him, and gave it to me hard.

Anton lifted me off the bed like I weighed nothing, pulling me back into his lap. His cock remained lodged deep in my ass as we rearranged. I squatted over him, planting my feet on the bed and opening my thighs. Anton held my hips in place above him so he could drive himself again and again into me. It was an impressive display of core strength that some detached part of me registered. The rest was screaming for more.

“Fuck my ass. Give me that cock, baby. Harder!”

Anton laughed with delight, obliging me. Rashaad was suddenly at my side, his girthy member in hand, feeding it into my mouth. I swallowed him whole, right into the back of my throat, my moans and cries turning to a wet, muffled cacking.

I pulled back, gasping for breath. “Where’s that other cock? I need something in my hand.” Joey was standing by the side of the bed, watching the action and stroking himself. “Let me help you with that.”

I grabbed their cocks in both hands, moving back and forth, taking turns choking on them as Anton continued to ream my asshole. But we all knew that wasn’t the main event. We all knew where this was leading.

Rashaad was the first to reach down to finger fuck my empty pussy. “Damn, babe, you’re so wet.”

“Wet enough,” I said, staring up at him.

He got it, his face splitting in two as he mounted me. I reclined back onto Anton, never taking my eyes off of Rashaad as he fisted his cock and brought it to bear on my sex. I’d never done this, despite all my wild adventures in the bedroom. I’d never been DP’ed, and it scared me.

“Do it.” Brow low, eyes cutting up, I must have looked maniacal. “Fill both my holes.”

I have never felt so much pressure in my life. I’d never felt so stuffed, so full. Even when Shane fucked me with an anal plug in, it wasn’t even close to the real thing. Anton was huge. Rashaad was even thicker. I felt stretched, my world coming apart. I felt—

“So fucking good! Uh, God. Uhhh, ohmy—GOD!”

The two men didn’t waste time. Once I was acclimated to the two dicks, they started pounding in unison. Anton held my hips as he fucked my ass, and Rashaad bore the full power of his body-builder frame down on my sodden pussy. It was bliss. But it wasn’t complete.

“Give me...that last...cock.”

“Listen to this ho!”

Joy stepped up, cock in hand, long and dark and huge as I wrapped my mouth around it. I licked the sensitive spot just beneath the crown as I stared up at him. “What are you waiting for, stud?”

Joey, most reserved of the three, didn't need further provoking. With a thrust, he was in my throat, choking me with his beautiful, black flesh.

"Air tight, baby!" Anton barked with delight.

All I could manage was a gagged, wet moan, but yes. This was what I wanted. This is what it meant to care about nothing but pleasure. This was me being so consumed by lust that nothing else mattered.

The night didn't end there. After I nearly passed out from the chain of orgasms those guys gave me, we switched it up.

I busted out my own stash of coke just to keep the night going, and because of that, most of it was a blur. They rotated, taking turns in my ass and pussy and mouth. I do remember being held physically up in the air by Rashaad, his fat cock lodged in my asshole, as Joey fucked me and Anton stood on the bed so I could blow him.

I awoke the next morning naked and cradled between Joey and Rashaad. My mouth tasted like come and the spermicide of the condoms. My head rang, and the light pouring in through the open blinds was searing. I disentangled myself from the two snoring men and crawled out of bed. My body ached—partially from all the sex, partially from a cocaine hangover.

There, on the credenza near the door, sat all my cash. All ten thousand dollars of it. Anton walked out of the bathroom just as I was set to leave, wearing a bathrobe and a cock-sure smile.

"Leaving so soon? Stay. There's more of that if you have time."

Maybe it was the fact that I was back in my leopard-print dress, and he in his robe. Maybe the sluttiness of the dress was much worse in the light of morning. Maybe I was finally coming to my senses. I'd never felt like such a whore until that moment. Worse, a part of me was actually tempted.

"Thanks for the offer, but I've got plans."

He gave me his card. Anton Jones of MMT Holdings. "In case those plans fall through."

I threw the card away as I waited for the elevator to arrive. Chills ran through me. I was shaking by the time I got back to our room, where Shane was actually sleeping soundly. I'm not sure what I expected. Remember that at this time, I didn't know about hotwives or reclamation or any of that. I just wanted to be loved.

"Oh, hey. You're back," Shane said groggily. "Have fun?"

"I need you." I slipped into his bed, running my hands over his warm body. "I need you, Shane."

He turned to me, looked me once over, taking in my tangled hair and smeared mascara, and said, "Not until you take a shower, babe. You're filthy."

I wish I could tell you that that's how it ended. That I walked out on that callous asshole when all I wanted was to be held. I didn't, although it was certainly the beginning of a very rapid end.

Before we'd even left Vegas, I discovered the truth about Anton and MMT Holdings. He was a potential client of Shane's, and Shane had actually given him the ten grand to pay for me.

"You set me up?!"

"Please, don't act like you weren't into it. Anton told me how much you liked getting stuffed." He was so smug. "I know he offered you more to stay. That was all him, not me."

"Gee, thanks. Now I feel so much better."

"Don't be like this, Heather."

"Like what? I think I feel entitled to be pissed off when someone uses me like
—"

He wasn't hearing what I was saying. He never heard it. "Like a princess? You're not her. You're a whore, Heather, whether you're actually getting paid for it or not. And like a good whore, you like it. You want it. And you'll keep doing it."

And that's when I walked out. I cut Shane from my life cold turkey, leaving the partying and the sex behind. My father got sick a couple months later, and I quit my job to help him manage Smith & Kingsley.

That helped me stay clean. I joined a rehab group. I started seeing a therapist. With everything falling down around me, I got in order the one thing that I had control over—myself.

But Shane lingered—or at least what he symbolized lingered. When I met Joshua, he was like the anti-Shane. Or so thought at the time anyway. We had a conventional relationship. He courted me. I didn't sleep with him right away. We went on dates and got to know one another. I threw myself into it because I needed to move on. I needed to bury my past.

That's one of the reasons the hotwife thing freaked me out so much. It was too much like what Shane pushed me into doing. I mean, the going out to bars and flirting with men as he watched felt too similar to Joshua being my pimp, and I vowed never to be another man's whore.

Of course, time does all kinds of things. The woman I am now isn't the one I was when I first met Joshua, who wasn't the same party girl in her early twenties. David and Dominic and Scott and Skyler had all happened to us, and we'd come out the other end, seemingly in a better place than ever.

I started enjoying our games together. It was exciting, walking into a strange place like I was single, knowing it was turning Joshua on. Maybe I could do this, you know? Maybe we could do this.

That's the state of mind I was in when I first met Paul. That's who I was when I became "Manhattan."

-

Becoming Manhattan

“I’ll just call you... Manhattan.”

Thinking back on my first encounter with Paul is so funny. My first impression of him still makes me laugh. He was like some kind of caricature of a single man. There he was, trying to pick up this girl using these really corny lines, when she leaves, he turns right to me without missing a beat.

“Do I look like a Manhattan?”

“At least you’re not drinking a Gimlet.”

I wouldn’t have entertained him if not for Joshua, who sent me a one line text as I was flirting: Him. That night was special, Joshua’s 43rd birthday and three years since Scott and Skyler. I figured I could put up with this guy for my husband’s birthday.

Turned out, Paul was fun. Despite the lines with the bimbo before me, he stepped it up. Our banter was quick and playful. He actually got me to laugh with him, not just at him. When I left him there, I knew that I’d be imagining Paul and his dark, good looks later that night.

I had booked a room at the Marriott, so it was a short ride up the elevators before the real fun began. Still, I made sure to torture my poor husband on that short ride.

“You enjoy that?”

He scooped me into his arms, his hand skimming along my back. “He wanted you so much.”

I held up a napkin that had Paul's number scribbled on it. "We could find out just how much he wanted me."

The doors opened before Joshua fully processed it, and I stepped off, sashaying my hips. "Kind of reminds me of David," I mused. "Only taller."

I pulled out my phone as we neared our room, leaning my back to one side of the door as Joshua fumbled with the key card. "What do you think? Maybe we can catch him before he finds someone else?"

Joshua eyed me darkly before throwing open the hotel room door. It slapped loudly against the closet. I laughed, brushing past him and into the room.

"You wouldn't..."

It was the perfect segue into my real birthday gift for the man who had everything. I unlocked my phone and launched DeBauch.

"Maybe not yet, but this might get me closer." I handed him my phone.

Joshua had mentioned the app a few months ago—a platform to connect married people looking for some illicit fun. In Joshua's world, it had become the go to place for couples looking for a hotwife experience. I'd gone on there and set up a profile for myself, although so far it only consisted of an obscured profile pic of my face and the letter H as a name.

It took Joshua about half a second to pick up on what I'd just handed him. His head snapped up, eyes wide. "You...you did this?"

I nibbled on the tip of my index finger. "Pretty naughty of me, don't you think?"

He read my profile and smiled. "Very naughty. But you don't have any pics on there."

I cocked a hip, striking a pose. "Was thinking that maybe you could help me out there."

Joshua's grin made the whole setup worth it. I probably wasn't going to actually use this service for its intended purpose, but like Paul downstairs, it was great foreplay.

He held my phone up, camera facing me. “Say, ‘cheese.’”

“Just don’t post any of my face,” I said as he began snapping photos.

“We can crop them before we post, but I’m not going to leave out such a beautiful feature.”

“Aw, thanks.”

“Now turn around and show me that ass.”

I turned, letting him take some tamer snaps of me from behind before I glanced back and began to pull up the short hem of my dress, exposing my next little surprise.

“No panties,” he said. “You were down there with no panties?”

I pulled my dress all the way off, leaving me completely naked but for my heels. “With nothing on.”

I turned, watching as he traced my nudity with his eyes. He still held my phone, still had it pointed at me, and was no doubt taking photos. I approached him, playing to the camera. We’d never taken naughty photos like this and I had to admit that it was sexy.

I lowered myself to my knees, keeping my eyes fixed on the camera, knowing he was watching me there like I was his personal porn star. “Happy birthday, baby.”

It wasn’t the most comfortable of positions, but I knew that Joshua loved the subservience—a thing I could give once a year. He was hard. So hard. Coupled with how horny I was, I wanted to eat him alive. I yanked down his pants and grabbed his cock, stroking it.

He looked just past my phone. I wondered if he’d switched to video. The thought of it was surprisingly thrilling. “I want you to think of his cock while you suck on mine.”

I did as told, wrapping my mouth around him and swirling along the ridge before tracing a lazy zigzag down the underside. Then, making a show of it, I shut my eyes and pretended to really think about doing this for another man.

It wasn't just pretend. After all those years, it was easy to dive into the fantasy. Easy to imagine that I was on my knees before the brash and too-cocky-for-his-own-good Paul while my husband watched.

"Oh, baby," Joshua groaned. "Suck that cock."

He grabbed my hair, taking control of my head. Rocking his hips forward, he shoved more and more cock into my mouth and down into my throat. I suppressed my gag reflex, regulating my breathing as he fucked my face. In bed, Joshua was a forceful, dominant lover, but he never did this before. Never fucked me like a whore, like a plaything for his own pleasure.

I shouldn't have liked it. If we did it all the time, I wouldn't. But this was his birthday and I was prepared to be his submissive hotwife.

"Take it," he demanded. I took it, wet gurgles and chokes escaping around his shaft as it plunged again and again into my throat. "Think about him."

I was. I didn't realize it until Joshua forced me to confront it, but I was thinking about Paul—although I didn't know his name at the time. I touched myself as I did, rubbing my clit in rapid circles.

Joshua was close. I was close. We both raced against our clocks. I gave myself completely to his control, focusing on my pussy and my own pleasure as he guided my head up and down his cock.

"Fuck, baby." Joshua plunged one last time, deep, his balls brushing against my chin. He held me there, smothering me as all that thick, swollen dick began to pulsate. I controlled my breathing, taking the bursts in the back of my throat, swallowing it all and somehow, miraculously, not choking.

He was still hard when he was through, and I was still horny. I slowly sucked off of him, releasing his cock with a pop. Just as slowly, I opened my eyes, savoring the moment.

The phone was still trained on me, and behind it, Joshua stared, a man possessed. "Were you thinking about him?"

I spoke right into the camera, knowing this must be video. "Yes." I rose, my hand never leaving his cock. I was still amazed that a 43-year-old man didn't go

soft. “Know what I was thinking, specifically?”

I could feel the tension tighten around him with such a simple question. He was so easy to toy with. “What?”

“A man as cocky as that knows how to use his dick.” I squeezed Joshua’s. “Do you?”

He tossed the phone onto the pile of his clothes. Foreplay was over. Time to fuck.

We were closer to the hotel desk than the bed, so that’s where Joshua pushed me up against. Grabbing my naked ass, he lifted me, setting me onto the rickety thing. There was a madness in his eyes—the madness I associated with these pseudo-reclamations, only more so. Joshua wasn’t the kind of hotwife husband who liked to be humiliated, but there was a line I could push.

“How do you know about guys like that?” he demanded.

I opened my legs and pulled the underside of his cock along my sex. I wanted to feel him inside me so badly, but I put it off. Just a little longer. Instead, I kept rubbing him against my mound. He still wore his shirt, but I wanted to feel his skin. I snuck my free hand up under it, into the sweltering heat that had built there. I traced the muscles of his abs, fingers caressing his ribcage and his hard nipples. “I may have been picked up in a hotel bar or two by a guy like that, once upon a time.”

“You were a slut.”

“Isn’t that what you want?” It wasn’t a real question. It was what he wanted. Still is. To drive this point home, I rubbed the crown of his cock along my clit, using that ridge to get us both off. “Ten years ago, I would have snuck away with him into the bathroom and let him fuck me against the—SINK!”

Joshua entered me with a forceful thrust. I felt his balls. Felt his mouth mash and kiss me possessively.

“Is that what you wanted me to do tonight?” I asked. “Should I have accepted his offer?”

Of course Paul hadn't offer that, but my husband didn't know, and it drove him crazy. He fucked me hard, fueled by his conflict and his passion. I wrapped my arm around his neck, my legs around his torso, squeezing him into me. The desk wobbled beneath us, groaning with each hard thrust.

"He was so hot." I urged him on, digging my nails into the back of his neck, clawing my fingers through his hair. "I have a thing for tall guys, did you know that?"

"Ngh," Joshua groaned.

"With broad shoulders."

He pumped faster. The desk creaked.

"And nice, big cocks."

"Oh, Heather!" Joshua rammed home hard, his cock going off inside of me. I was there with him—not because I was thinking about Paul and his potentially hard cock, but because of how excited it got Joshua. How into this he was. His fantasy became mine.

The desk snapped beneath us. The back leg gave out, and the whole thing came slowly crashing down. We teetered and fell together, riding the shattered desk to a softer landing than I expected. He was still buried inside me when we hit the floor.

"Think housekeeping will notice?" Joshua asked.

I could only laugh, burying my face in his neck and hugging him close. "Happy birthday, Joshua."

"So you really set up a DeBauch account?"

I reached for my phone, nestled in his discarded clothing. Navigating to my photos folder, I realized that he had taken a lot of very inappropriate photos, in addition to a long video of my blowing him. I already knew we'd watch that later that night as we got ready for the next round.

"I really did." I didn't hide what I was doing—selecting two of the tamer, fully

clothed photos he took of me and cropping out my face. “Wonder if anyone will be interested...”

Opening DeBauch, I added those two photos to my profile. By the time I was finished, Joshua was already hard again. As an afterthought, I edited my name.

“Mandy?”

I smiled to myself. “It’s what that guy downstairs thinks my name is. Who knows, maybe he’ll find it one day?”

■

Jameson

It was two or three weeks before I got the call from the Dawning Foundation. I will never forget the feeling of shock I felt, walking into the boardroom and seeing Paul standing there. It was so surreal. I wasn't even sure it was him at first. Like when you see someone completely out of context—a teacher at the grocery store, a coworker at the pool—and that he was an accountant working at a non-profit was even more bizarre. I'd pegged the guy I met as more of a bartender type than a square, numbers man.

Other than the shock, all I could think about was getting home and telling Joshua about the coincidence. We'd had some fun on DeBauch—I even posted a photo of myself from New Orleans in the red dress. But this was going to blow him away.

“You'll never guess who my new client is.”

“I've been following this Hamilton Fund scandal thing. Dawning, right? You told me.”

Joshua was already in bed when I got home, propped up on the pillows, reading glasses on and a book in hand. I knew he was watching me as I peeled the white blazer off and hung it in the closet.

“Yes, the client is the Dawning Foundation.” I unsnapped the white suit pants and wiggled out of them, feeling Joshua's eyes on my thong-clad ass. “But it's the guy that I'll be working with that you'll find more interesting.”

“Why's that?”

I slowly unbuttoned my black blouse, studying him out of the corner of my eyes. He's riveted—and not just on my butt. “Remember that guy we ran into at the

Marriott on your birthday?”

“Of course.”

I slipped out of my blouse, hanging it as I posed. My bra was the same nude lace as my thong, and while I knew Joshua would prefer me wearing white or black, there’s no way I was going to do that beneath a white suit.

“Turns out his name’s not Bruce,” I said, sharing a smile. We’d nicknamed him Bruce, as in Bruce Wayne, because of his broad shouldered, dark hero look. “It’s Paul. Paul Sharpe.”

“Did he recognize you?”

I turned to the bed, sauntering forward. When I unsnapped my bra, Joshua barely looked at my breasts. That’s how into this fantasy he was. “He did.”

Joshua licked his lips. “And?”

I wasn’t sure what he wanted there. I crawled onto the bed, right up to him. “And it appears I’ll be working for him.” I straddled him, leaning over him as though to kiss. I stopped, pulled back, and smiled. “Just the two of us. Long hours. And I think...” I bit my lower lip. “I think he’s going to need a lot of help.”

“Oh, Heather...” Joshua groaned.

I felt his erection against my pussy as I pressed down. “Does that excite you?”

Joshua seemed to shake off the haze of the fantasy. He found me above him, looking at me darkly. He started to say something, but whatever it was faltered. It wasn’t often that he was at a loss for words.

I helped him out. “Did he seem interested in me? Of course he did. A woman can always tell.”

I scooted back down his legs, pulling the sheets away to uncover his thick cock. I rubbed him through his boxer-briefs, watching him watch me.

“Is that why you came home so late?”

The truth was “no.” In fact, I believe Paul was meeting up with you that night, Eleanor. But I didn’t tell Joshua that. I didn’t tell him anything. Just dropped my head into his lap, yanked his boxers down, and wrapped my mouth around his cock.

He was so hard, his breathing so ragged. He fought back his orgasm as I did my best to tease him. Lapping down his shaft and over his balls, I looked up at Joshua and smiled. “I was going to pass this account to June, but maybe I’ll keep it for myself.” I swirled my tongue around the swollen crown of his manhood. “Think I should do that?”

“Yes.” It was like Joshua had to force the word out.

“Could be dangerous.” I bobbed down over him. “I’d be working even more late nights.”

“Oh, fuck.”

Joshua lost it. He flooded my mouth with an ardor that caught me by surprise—and I was expecting it. I swallowed as best I could, but when I started to choke, I had to pull away. I caught a splash of come across my neck and another on my tits before I could redirect it up his chest. He smelled like bleach, messy and warm. I kept pumping, stroking it into my fingers as I climbed back up into his lap.

“By the time we were done tonight, everyone else was gone.” I pulled my thong to one side and rubbed his softening cock along the smooth lips of my pussy. “It was just me and Paul, all alone in the dark... empty... office...”

He stiffened enough that I could sink onto him. We sighed together. I leaned in, kissing him, smearing the come on my tits against his chest.

“All alone in the boardroom, it would have been so easy to walk over to him...”

Joshua looked up at me, his face dark. He was suddenly so very hard.

“To sit him on the edge of that long board table...”

“Heather...”

“And sink down to my knees.”

“Oh, fuck, baby...”

“All through that meeting, it’s all I could think about.” Not true at all, but Joshua didn’t need to know that. For Joshua, it was gasoline on the flames.

He grabbed my ass, squeezing my cheeks hard as he pulled me into him, dragging me up and down his cock. When that became too much, he rolled us, taking charge. Pulling out long enough to tear my panties off, he rammed down again. I wrapped my legs around his waist, loving that feeling of my ass leaving the bed with each thrust, of making him work for it.

His eyes were shut. He was thinking about me on my knees, blowing another man in an empty boardroom. I ran my nails up his back, spurring him on.

“You know...” My gut quivered as I considered my next tease. “You know I never threw away his phone number...”

“No...”

“What if I told you that... that today wasn’t the first time I saw him since your birthday?”

That set him off. He grabbed my hands, pinning them above me as he lifted into a plank. His face was half twisted in a snarl.

“That idea excite you?”

“Heather, stop.” But he didn’t stop. He went wilder. Fucked harder. He squeezed our laced fingers until my joints hurt.

“That maybe I’ve been fooling around with him this whole time?”

“Heather!”

“That maybe, when he needed a crisis PR company, it wasn’t a coincidence that he called me.”

It landed like a blow. He didn’t want that. He didn’t want his fantasy to actually

be real. Yet his libido betrayed him. His cock throbbed and exploded deep inside of me.

I was right there with him. I was in the fantasy. I was thinking about Paul, a client, in ways I shouldn't have—how good he looked in a suit, how broad his shoulders were, the size of his hands...

“Uhh!” I cried out, clawing Joshua's back as I welcomed his come. He pulled back, his back hunched like a rabid dog. His stare was untamed, his eyes darting over my face like he was assessing a new acquisition.

“You didn't—”

“No.”

“You won't.”

Of course I wouldn't, but I didn't like the tone. Like all things with Joshua, he made this about him, not us. At the time, I didn't understand the depths of that proclivity, but it still rubbed me in the wrong way.

I kept my mouth shut, though. I didn't want to have this conversation. I didn't want to deal with the tension of the damned fantasy. It had been a long day, and now that we'd had our fun, I just wanted to go to sleep. So instead of doing the healthy thing and talking it over, I reached past him and turned off the light.

*

I actually ran into Paul the next morning before we were even in the office. I get coffee at this local shop a block from my office, and he was there, looking... well, looking good. I'll admit it. He's the kind of guy who looks really good in a suit without a tie, and it looked even better with that scruffy, unshaven look.

Maybe it was the unusual way we'd first met, or maybe it was that I just had the roleplay from the night before on my mind, but Paul seemed different from other guys I knew. The banter was still flirty and playful, but I felt this... I don't know... Like an instant connection.

He must have, too, because on the way out, coffees in hand, when I asked him how he slept last night, he said, “I had sex with a woman as her husband

watched.”

It was not the answer I was expecting, but I was coming to learn that’s the kind of guy Paul is. It was refreshing, especially after so many years having to read between the lines with Joshua.

Paul even invited me to ask him questions. It’s weird, in hindsight, thinking that the woman we were talking about was you, Elle. At the time, it was just fascinating hearing about another “hotwife” actually doing it. Other than Skyler, who I wasn’t about to reach out to, I’d never met any others. I had no one I could talk to about this.

When he turned it back on me, though, and asked about my life, I opened up. It was easy. Since he knew about the game Joshua and I played, I could actually say some of the things I wanted to tell my husband.

Like how I didn’t think Joshua could actually handle it. How his jealousy and possessiveness would drive a wedge between us, as it had with his first wife. It’s funny, when Paul said something about being surprised that I’d settle for a man like Joshua, it touched a nerve.

“You don’t think a woman like me wants to be possessed?” Joshua’s possessive attitude from last night was still raw.

But maybe, with Joshua, I did want to be his. For all his faults, he was different than the men I was with before. I wasn’t interchangeable. I wasn’t a casual encounter. I was his prize, and treasured. Some enlightened, powerful female role model I am, huh?

Anyway, after that began an unusual friendship between me and Paul. He was surprising in so many ways—not at all the man I’d pegged him as when I watched him try to pick up that bimbo. He was hard working, organized, and a surprisingly empathetic person. At least when it came to the staff and the mission of the Dawning Foundation. Women, that was another matter, but no one’s perfect.

I started to look forward to our banter. When it was a day that I knew I’d see him, I got up with more of a pep, ready to trade barbs—and maybe learn a little bit more about whatever crazy thing he got up to.

Joshua picked up on it, of course, and rather than try and play it down, I decided to feed his fantasy a little. In the mornings, I made sure he caught a glimpse of me dressing, checking my ass out in the mirror in a tight pantsuit, for example. Or fastening the garters of my stockings before rolling a short skirt over them.

“Dawning?” he’d ask.

“Yeah. Going over the PR plan for the potential brand change.” I’d kiss him chastly on the corner of his mouth. “I may be late.”

It wasn’t the first time I’d used his fantasy to tease him, but this felt really fun. Really refreshing.

Maybe it was such close proximity to the real deal, but we also started playing around more with that DeBauch account I’d set up. Browsing mostly, sometimes hitting the Heart button on guys I thought were cute. I mostly did it to get a rise out of Joshua but it was thrilling for me, too—like window-shopping at a store that sold men. All types of sexy, available men. Most were easy to write off, of course. They’d introduce themselves by sharing pictures of their dicks, then asking to get some naked photos of me.

Paul, though, he was what really got me going. I lied to myself for the longest time. Then there was that night at Starlight Lounge when we were all celebrating the new board. Drinks were flowing. Spirits were high. I let my guard down and kissed Paul.

It was amazing. It was terrifying. Joshua saw it, too, which I think was a blessing in disguise. He was furious and turned on and right there to really reclaim me. This time, there was no Skyler to go ballistic or Joshua to barge in. I stopped it myself. I went back to my husband. I shouldn’t have done it at all, but I did and it didn’t go further. It was dumb, but we could recover.

Then Paul fucking discovered my DeBauch account, messaging me with the silly name I’d given him from the bar—Jameson. I think that in a way, DeBauch gave us the space to carry on whatever thing had started at Starlight. “Jameson” and “Mandy” were our excuse to be ourselves.

Joshua saw the exchanges—because the deal was that he got to see all my messages in DeBauch. After that, Paul and I entered this new phase of our relationship. We were like BFFs, only with this overriding sexual tension that

both of us did our best to ignore.

I even went out with him when he was meeting up with a DeBauch couple, which was pretty wild. I told Joshua the semi-truth—that I was meeting up with Jameson for drinks. That night, I was as amped up as my husband was. The ironic thing was that while he thought I was just making it up and teasing him, I really was out with ‘Jameson’ and when we were in bed together, I really was thinking about what Paul was definitely doing to that blond hotwife he left the bar with.

After that, you know most of the story. Paul and I used DeBauch’s messaging system to set up a date in full view of Joshua. The week leading up to that “date” was so fun. I teased poor Joshua mercilessly. I went dress shopping, sending Joshua photos of various outfits from the changing room.

It was actually Paul who decided what dress to wear, though, telling me through a DeBauch message to wear the red, New Orleans dress from my profile. It made things even more intense that I chose to go with another man’s preference, and that particular dress was so loaded with significance.

Day of, Joshua came home early to help me get ready. Obviously it was all a setup, and I wasn’t just meeting up with Paul, but also with you, but there was still this energy between us. This was the first time we’d ever pre-arranged a date, and it felt like a big step—real or not.

“You sure this is a good idea?” I asked.

“It’s a good idea,” Joshua said. With confidence. Like he really meant it. But here’s the thing with Joshua—he’s a lawyer, better at bullshitting than I could ever be, and I’m in PR. I’ve heard him tell bold faced lies to people and make even me wonder if they were true.

I strolled over to my purse, feeling his eyes on my ass, clad in a pair of snug yoga pants. I had a test. “You’re sure, you’re sure?”

“I’m—” He froze, mid-sentence, as I pulled out the box of condoms I’d picked up at the drugstore on the way home.

“Sure?” I asked, raising a brow.

He wasn't sweating, but looked like a man about to. Suddenly, this was more real than it had been before. I'd read about using condoms as a prop, and it had its intended effect. Joshua was forced to confront the fact that another man may have sex with me. Cruelly, I was happy to get past the abstract, because I'd been living with this reality for a while. He needed to catch up.

"When did you get those?" The hunger was still there, but his jealousy had taken over. This was the other side of the coin for Joshua, the backswing of the pendulum. He got jealous. He got paranoid. It's why I knew I could never fulfill this fantasy. Not really.

"Oh, I've had them for a while." I said it playfully, heading for the shower. I set the box on the dresser and glanced over my shoulder. "Why don't you count how many are missing?"

Of course, the box was unopened, but I heard him scurry to it and check as I turned the shower on.

"You're evil," he said with a laugh behind me. The tease had the unintended effect of softening the edge that the condoms had introduced.

"I hope those are big enough for Jameson." I stripped out of my clothes. "I was so nervous, buying them. Like a teenager or something." They were XLs. I was sure Joshua took note of that.

He was behind me, discarding his suit as he approached. "Don't worry, you're all woman to me."

He filled his hands with my tits, pressing his cock against my ass as he kissed my neck. He squeezed, like he was trying to convince himself that I was his. I let him. This was the way he usually got when his fantasy was in play.

"Think Jameson will feel the same way?" I teased.

"No way he wouldn't."

We stepped into the shower together, our hands all over one another. I love shower sex. It's one of those things I always forget about until I do it, then wonder why we don't do it all the time. You can be as dirty and messy as you want, and the spray cleans it all away.

“Maybe I won’t need the condoms tonight,” I said. Dropping to my knees, I looked up at Joshua. His chest was rising and falling so fast I wondered if he’d pass out. “Maybe, since this is just a first date, I’ll just suck his cock.”

It was such a loaded question. I knew my husband well. “Condoms”, “suck his cock”, even “date” were all trigger words for him. He was so hard, thick enough that it was a challenge to wrap my fingers around it as I stroked in time with my bobs. I paced myself, watching him watch me as he imagined me doing this for another man.

I closed my eyes to reinforce his fantasy, and suddenly I was imagining doing this with another man. With... with Paul. I’d read his reviews. Read how women gushed over how good he was in bed, and how big his cock was, and how he did things to them that none of their husbands could.

I didn’t realize that I was playing with myself until my own orgasm hit me. Flushed with equal parts embarrassment and excitement, I finished Joshua off easily, pulling back and jerking his shaft off as I looked up at him. My throat was raw, making my next words husky and effective. “But seriously, I doubt either of us will stop at just a blowjob.”

My words ripped his orgasm from his body. I kept jacking him off as I directed his come over my chest like the whore he wanted me to be.

I leaned back into the spray, letting it cleanse me. Still, I felt dirty. Felt ashamed. I’d been thinking of Paul. I’d let it take control, and that was definitely not okay.

I rose, serious now, pressing my wet and warm body against him. Usually, after he comes, the insecure side of him rears up. Not this time, though. Those sharp eyes were still locked on me, still enthralled by the upcoming date. I reached behind him, picked up my razor and the can of shaving cream.

I kissed him playfully before backing up into the corner, lifting a foot onto the soap tray, and spraying shaving cream over my mound. Joshua struggled with his emotions as he watched me shave any stubble away, a darkness gathering deep inside him.

I glanced at my husband. “Check it for me?”

He didn’t drop down to his knees like I’d expected. Instead, he stepped close,

running his fingers across my peach-soft lips as his mouth bore down on me hard. I met him, kiss for kiss, passion for passion, as he pressed two fingers deep inside. I found his cock, stirring once again. Stroking it, I could already feel him spread me, already feel his length run along my denuded clitoris.

Then he stopped, stepped away. Tearing his lips from mine. “Don’t wear panties,” he said.

I studied him. He was back in that zone, lost in the grip of his fantasy. I sauntered up to him, gave his cock a tug, and whispered, “Good, because I wasn’t planning to.”

■

Last night

“You weren’t wearing panties that night? In that dress?” Eleanor sits back. “So naughty, Heather.”

“I know. I felt so exposed.”

“I remember that night. I remember being so frustrated when you guys didn’t get it on.”

“And what? Leave my husband for a guy like Paul?”

“Sure, why not?”

It’s the first time I’ve let myself really consider a question like that. We’re not talking about some quick fuck. We’re not talking about fulfilling a hotwife fantasy. We’re talking about something more long-term—something permanent.

“I’m not sure the thing I need is another man with an oversized ego.” I anticipate her next question. “And yes, Paul has an oversized ego. He’s on DeBauch as a bull.”

“You know what? You do a fantastic job trying to make everyone around you one-dimensional. We are more complicated than that.”

Things feel so heavy, and I want to lighten them up. “I know you are.”

She’s not having it. “And so is Paul. Heather, you don’t need to keep denying it. Not here. Not with me.”

She’s right. I do a damn good job putting up walls. It’s been my strength since I was young. “That night, while we were dancing... Fine, yes, for a moment there,

I could see this whole future with Paul. A big What-If. And it was nice. But I also remember having a moment like that with Joshua. It reminded me how little in our lives go the way we plan, and that's okay. It's how we react and deal with all those things that matter."

"And if you're not happy? You're what, supposed to just react in a positive way?"

"Did I say I wasn't happy?" It's as much a question to me as it was for Eleanor, and I don't give it much thought before moving on. "When I got home, things were great. Joshua may have been conflicted and more than a little skeptical, but he was definitely turned on by the thought of me with other men. He wanted to watch me flirt, and I wanted him to watch me."

"You were feeling this need to reconnect."

"I guess. So you know what came next. You set up the thing with Jamie. That was fun. I was nervous, but in a familiar way this time. I had my husband watching while I flirted and that felt more normal. No Paul. No guilt. It was a performance, and felt like one.

"I texted Joshua naughty things. At one point, I accidentally sent one of those things to Paul—at least I think it was accidental. Could have been my subconscious working against me. Either way, it threw me off my game. When Jamie asked if I wanted to get out of there, I just went with it. When we were at his car and he kissed me... I just kissed him back.

"I knew Joshua was watching. This was David all over again, only without the wild setup and without me being actually unfaithful. It felt good. Great. Like a controlled version of my earlier life—the fun without the recklessness. I guess it's how it's supposed to be?"

"You're always trying to be in—"

"Control. Yeah, I know. Well, things almost got out of hand that night, if you remember."

"Oh, I remember."

The way Eleanor stares at me sends a quake through me. "When I got home, it

was late, but Joshua was still awake. He'd been drinking, I could tell, and his mood was darker than my last fake date with 'Jameson.' He saw the kiss. He saw us drive away. He made all kinds of assumptions. I helped nurture those assumptions."

"What did you tell him?"

"Nothing. Instead, I handed him my purse, which was open. While I hadn't mussed my hair or smudged away my lipstick, I'd done something else very naughty. Joshua discovered it as I reached the stairs. I'd opened the box of condoms and thrown a couple away."

"Very devious."

"Joshua was prone to moods. I knew this, so I probably knew that I shouldn't be teasing him this way. But he also asked for it. This fantasy of his, it was relentless. If he got a little burned in the process, that was as much on him as it was on me.

"In the bedroom, I stripped out of my dress, out of my bra and panties. He was against me, cupping my breasts roughly from behind, kissing my neck. The mania that always seized him was there, intensified by the alcohol and a night of sitting alone with the image of me driving away in Jamie's car.

"He kept asking me if I fucked him, and I kept stringing him along. Not answering him directly, you know? It got him so worked up. He threw me onto the bed, kissing me so hard that my gums hurt the next day. I think I bit his lower lip until I tasted blood. I know I tore open his shirt, just to get my hands on his chest."

This time, as I tell my story, I'm not so lost in the memory that I don't see my audience sitting on the opposite bend of the patio sectional. Eleanor watches me intently as I talk about sex and lust and reclamation. She bites her lip, her fingers flirting with the high hem of her short dress. It's thrilling. My heart beats faster as I press on.

"He was so hard, and it was only as he entered me that I realized just how wet I was. Just how excited this evening got me. The whole evening was a thrill. Watching you with Jamie had me so ready to get fucked myself, and Joshua was there to fuck."

“I loved that you watched us,” she says.

It feels like an invitation to something naughty. I ignore it, pressing on.

“Joshua came twice that night, in rapid succession. I remember that. Remember being impressed with this 42-year-old’s stamina. He didn’t last long the first time, and all it took was a bit of teasing to get him up for round two.”

Eleanor fans herself. She stands, and for a moment, I wonder whether she’s approaching me. Whether things are about to get wilder between us. I stare up at her, noticing just how sexy she is in her little, floral-printed sundress. My pussy quivers.

“Okay, now I’m opening that bottle of wine,” she says instead. “Please continue. Tell me all about round two.”

I blush and laugh nervously. “Maybe after some of that wine.”

“Fair enough.” Eleanor’s laugh is delightful, putting me at ease. “Ready to talk about last night?”

Last night. I could close my eyes and still feel Paul on me. I could still see him lying in bed, a thick arm draped behind his head as I walked into his bathroom to take a shower, and the smile that I couldn’t shake.

Deep breath. You can do this.

“I went out with this guy... Thomas. He was charming until he wasn’t, and then he was a true nightmare. As you know, Paul was there with me.”

“Because Joshua said that he couldn’t make it.”

“Right. The initial plan was for Joshua to come watch. Then he ‘couldn’t make it.’ He said he had a meeting in Richmond that turned out to be a lie. Just before that, though, I’d been texting with Paul about him vetting guys. I guess Joshua figured he’d take a chance. He knew that I’d gone out on one of Paul’s dates before...”

Seems over-the-top, now that I’m saying it all out loud, but it also makes sense. This is how Joshua gets when he’s set on an idea. It’s what makes him such a

good lawyer. He's intense. Focused. He gets what he wants.

"I should have known that Joshua was playing me, as much as he was playing the situation. He knew that I couldn't resist something like this. He knew that I was developing...something with Paul. For Joshua, that was enough to make him do this reckless thing."

"Don't beat yourself up about it, Heather. This isn't your fault."

"Not all of it, but some of it is." My shoulders slump. I wish I had a cigarette. "You know what, though? It was fun teasing Paul—both that night, and all the time leading up to it. Despite what you think, I know that there's more 'Mandy' and 'Jameson' in our relationship than we'd ever admit out loud. Having Paul there, listening to Thomas flirt with me, really drove that home. I could practically see the jealousy build up inside of Paul."

"I know the feeling."

"But it felt like we were in it together. Like even though I was out with Thomas, he was just the entertainment to the real date. It was like when I'd go out with Joshua, only without all the—"

"Baggage?"

"I was going to say complication, but sure, that works, too." I let her refill my wine, which was already empty. "Anyway, the date turned sour. The guy wouldn't take a hint. I ended up having to lay him out on the floor by the bathrooms."

After David and the boathouse incident, I vowed never to be that vulnerable. I took self-defense classes, trained in aikido and judo until I was confident I could drop even the biggest man coming on to me.

"He... he assaulted you?"

"I didn't let him get that far."

"Jesus."

"I was amped up after that, though, and I'd had a few drinks. When I looked up,

there was Paul, standing there with concern all over his face. Joshua never looked at me like that. He got jealous, yes. Hungry for me, all the time lately. But that kind of empathy... It's not in Joshua's nature."

I didn't think it was in Paul's, either. Not when we first met, anyway, and not for a long time after. It surprised me, and it surprised me even more how much I craved it.

"We went back to his place. I'm a big girl. I knew what was going on. I can blame the booze and the adrenaline and the strange trajectory of the night. I was shaking, but not because of any of that. As he took a seat beside me and handed me a shot glass of tequila, I was shaking because of him."

"To one scary chick,' he toasted. It made me laugh, but all I could do was look at his soft eyes and the way his mouth moved as he spoke. I think he apologized for not being my knight in shining armor. I don't know. My heart was going crazy, throbbing in my ears. I put a hand on his knee. We said some words, but we both knew where this was going."

Even now, recalling it, my heart races. My hands are clammy. My skin tingles.

"Paul wasn't going to make a move, despite every opportunity that I gave him. I swear, if I hadn't kissed him, he would have let me walk out of there."

"So you kissed him?"

"I did." And I'd do it again.

"And?"

"I wanted more. So much more. I got into his lap. He unzipped my dress as we kissed. I unbuttoned his shirt. I wanted to feel him. I wanted to squeeze those muscles. I've never felt that way—that physical attraction that's almost... I don't know. Profound? His smooth, tanned chest, sculpted and hard yet shockingly soft. I wanted to sink my teeth into him." My laugh feels desperate. "Listen to me. Like some fawning girl."

I look over at Eleanor. She doesn't agree immediately. She sees something else, something that makes my face color. I press on.

“We went to the bedroom. I asked him to take me to his bedroom. He touched me... all over.” I rub my knees together. Things are getting hot again. “We strip. Get on the bed. He climbs over me as I wrap my hand around his cock. I remember looking up at him, and nothing’s awkward. None of it felt wrong, you know, despite everything about it being wrong. I remember smiling and reaching up and kissing him as I pulled him close. And when he entered me...”

When he entered me, it just felt right. Like that was exactly where I needed to be and what I needed to feel.

I’m there again, wrapping my stocking-clad legs around his thick body, pulling him down into me. “Don’t hold back. You won’t break me.” But damn did I want him to try.

“It was too good, Eleanor.”

“I know.”

She does. More than anyone else, she knows exactly what I’m talking about. He knew how to touch me. He said all the right things to get me off.

“You’ve been bad, haven’t you?”

“I’ve been having naughty thoughts about other men.”

“How naughty?”

“Thinking about strange men fucking you?”

“Yes.”

At some point last night, fucking turned to making love and I felt like he’d crawled under my skin, and me under his. I didn’t want it to stop. We moved from the bed to the shower then back to the bed. “We’ve always had a competitive relationship, the two of us. Sex with him last night was no different. We pushed each other in all of the best ways. But...”

But it wasn’t just about the sex and my arousal. That’s not what made that moment so truly profound then, and so guilt-inducing now. I hesitate. I don’t want to admit this part. Eleanor helps.

“But it was exactly what your husband was afraid of.”

“I never knew it could be like that,” I said. “I’ve been with so many men, but never like that.”

“Paul’s special,” she agrees.

“I fell asleep in his arms, and when I woke up, I freaked out. The adrenaline had passed. The alcohol had burned off. Even still, it felt too good to be there, to let my eyes adjust to the dark and see Paul that way. It wasn’t right. None of it was right. I got a cab and got out of there, feeling like the woman I thought that I’d left behind—a slut who jumped from bed to bed. I gave up that life for Joshua —”

“And Joshua has spent most of your marriage trying to get you to be that woman again,” Eleanor interjects. “He pushes you and pushes you, and as soon as you acquiesce, he goes mad.”

She’s not wrong. “Because of what happened with Melody.”

“Or maybe Melody just had enough of that pattern, too. Maybe she found someone... stable for her in her life.”

I sit there silently, my lips pursed. None of this is anything I haven’t thought before, but it sounds so much more real coming from someone else.

“Look, I know this is hard, but what Joshua’s doing to you... it’s abuse.”

“It’s not. It’s jealousy, which is a part of this hotwife fantasy—”

Eleanor is already shaking her head before I can finish the sentence. “Sure, jealousy can be part of it. But this isn’t just jealousy. This is something else. Something pathological. He’s manipulated other men to sleep with you on more than one occasion. Without your consent! Once, I could maybe overlook it. Maybe. This is now a pattern.”

I want to clap my hands over my ears and shut it all out. I’ve known this for a long time. Deep down, I’ve really, really known. But I hate to admit this weakness, this blindness. “I always thought I was stronger than this.” The tears come, and when they do, Elie is there, cradling me in her arms. “I’m such a

stupid, stupid, fucking girl.”

“Shhh, shhh... Don’t go there, Heather. You’re not stupid. You’re strong. You’re one of the most capable women I know—”

“You see? That’s the problem. I’m not perfect. I have flaws. I make mistakes—huge mistakes, sometimes.” I take a big, deep, cleansing breath. It feels good. Feels like progress. “Paul was a mistake.”

“First of all, I never said that you were perfect. And second of all, I refuse to believe that you actually think that Paul was a mistake.”

I look down, but don’t argue.

“You need to stop doing this, Heather. You need to stop trying to control it all. It’s okay to show emotion. It’s okay to be vulnerable. It’s okay to want things that maybe, perhaps, you shouldn’t want.”

“People don’t want to see the real me. They don’t want to see the flaws.” I feel the sneer. It’s biting enough that even Eleanor leans back. “They want to see some fantasy. It’s always been this way, from the boys in highschool that I ignored to the ones in college that I didn’t. My husband can’t seem to fucking see past his fantasy of me being some slut for him.”

“I see past it.” I look at her, and she looks at me, and I feel the same, deep connection that I felt last night with Paul. All of a sudden, I want to reach out and kiss her when she adds, “Paul sees past it, too.”

I sigh. Here we are again, yet another full circle. I feel caught in a labyrinth, and I keep returning again and again to this same agonizing spot. This time, though, Eleanor is here to guide me out.

“You need to stop trying to convince yourself of something you don’t believe.”

She’s right. But I still don’t know where that leaves me. “I—”

“I’m sorry to interrupt...” From just inside the guest house, Ronald Heller stands, wringing his hands.

“What is it, Ronald?” Eleanor asks.

“Ahh... someone’s at the front door for Heather.”

I snap my head around to look at Eleanor. “You told him?”

Eleanor looks sheepish. “Don’t be mad, but I may have let it slip. He was... concerned.”

It’s not betrayal that spreads thick and uncomfortably warm through me. Maybe I’m getting used to that out-of-control feeling after living with Joshua for so many years. Maybe I’m just really into the idea of Paul being concerned about me. Did Joshua ever feel that way anymore? Had he ever?

Ron clears his throat again. “Actually. Umm... I’m sorry—”

“Stop right there, Ron,” Eleanor snaps. She doesn’t raise her voice, but her command over this man is absolute. “Please let him into the guest house, dear.”

“But—”

She doesn’t even say anything to cut him short this time. Just a look is all that it takes and he shuts his mouth, nods, and leaves.

“I love that you came to me, and you should stay here for as long you like. There’s a lot more to you than I ever dreamed of, Heather. But there’s one thing that hasn’t changed. You’re a fighter, and you confront things head on.”

I hear her admiration. It helps strengthen my own resolve.

“Time to move on to the next chapter of your life, and we both know what that should be.” She hugs me, kisses me softly on the mouth, and steps aside.

She’s right. I ran, but I also know that I cannot run forever. Last night, for a brief moment, was magical. It can be that way again. Why am I denying it? Joshua gave me an out by betraying my trust. He wants to turn me into something I don’t want to be. With Paul, I can be free to be me.

I look inside, where I see the silhouette of a man enter, looking around to take in his surroundings. Butterflies flutter inside me. That dizzy, feverish feeling doesn’t go away. My scalp prickles as I take a deep breath and walk into the room on wobbly knees. You confront things head on, I remind myself. It’s

almost comical.

A smile arrives at last to my lips. I don't know what the next moment bodes, but that's okay. That's fine. Paul and I can figure this out together.

He stands by the spiral staircase, his back to me and his hand on the wrought iron, looking up at the loft.

My stomach drops. My heart rate spikes. This is not who I am expecting. It's not with whom I am mentally prepared to deal.

You confront things head on.

“Hello, Joshua.”

-

Head On

Joshua turns. I'm not sure what to expect. Last night, when I left I was feeling the extreme edges of the emotional spectrum. Today, the blood has cooled and the rage simmers. I've explored our past and see this man for what he is—abusive, single-minded, and tenacious about it.

But he also came here. He cares enough to still make the effort. I see the man that I fell in love with. The man that I stood and exchanged vows with.

That doesn't mean he's getting off so easily.

Slap!

My palm across the clean lines of his cheek feels good, if not satisfying enough.

"It's good to see you, too."

"You are an asshole!" I shove him. "You... you fucking asshole."

He grimaces. I expect him to tell me that I'm wrong, that I'm mistaken, that I'm not seeing it the way I should be. I expect to be lawyered. Instead, he just says, "I'm sorry."

And I'm shocked.

"You... what?"

Joshua snorts, but it feels like it's more at him than at me. When he smiles, he really is charming. "I'm sorry."

I just stare at him.

“This is the part where you say something like how you forgive me.”

It is. This is the cycle. The ebb and the flow of our lives. This is me coming home from the California spas. It’s Joshua cooling off and deciding that maybe, this time, he can handle it. It’s what we always do. It’s making this marriage work despite all the odds and all the insanity.

“Why are you here, Joshua? Did Eleanor call you and put you up to this? Did her husband?”

He looks so sincere, shaking his head. “No. They didn’t. Is it so crazy to think that I came on my own? That I’m here to fight for us?”

A tear trickles down my cheek. Eleanor’s advice whispers in my mind: You can show emotion. It’s okay to be vulnerable.

He’s flawed, just like I am flawed. I’m just as responsible for what happened with Paul as he is. No one is innocent here.

He rubs the tear away with his thumb. “I’m sorry, Heather. I made a mistake. We’ve all made mistakes.”

“Oh, Joshua.” More tears turn my vision to a soggy smear. It would be so much easier to accept this, to take his hand and go with him.

But it’s time to stop this cycle. Time to confront this head on.

“No.” I surprise myself with how sure I am in that statement. “And I can’t forgive you.” Feels better with each statement. “I won’t.”

“Heather.” His hand tenses on my face. I step backwards. “Heather, how can I make this right?”

“This isn’t just about you. It’s not just about me. This isn’t working, Joshua. Surely you see that.”

I will him to see past his own world view. This isn’t good for either of us. I’m not what he needs, and he’s definitely bad for me. His face hardens. I watch him transform into his ugliest of forms. “You can’t be fucking serious.”

I just blink.

“Is this about that cocky son of a bitch? You think... what? That you’re in love with Paul Sharpe? That you’re going to go and have some beautiful fucking life with a man who calls himself a ‘bull’ on an app called ‘DeBauch’?”

He’s baiting me. I don’t take it. “It’s not about him—”

“Maybe you’re right. Maybe you two deserve each other. Wait’ll he finds out what a true whore you are.”

“But I never told you—”

“And why didn’t you, Heather? Why didn’t you tell me that about Shane and the things you did for him. The guys you fucked for him for money.”

I never told him about Shane or my past. I should have, but I was too scared. Too frightened. Too worried that I would lose this man that I thought I was in love with.

“Yeah, I had you investigated. Had to know what I was getting before I put a ring on you. I knew about Dominic, too. Any other fun skeletons you’d like to —”

“You need to leave.”

Joshua barks an incredulous laugh. “It’s fine, Heather. I knew what you were before we got hitched, and I get it. You’re not even my first wife to cheat. Happens all the time. Most of the partner’s wives have slept around. Believe me, I’ve got plenty of juicy evidence on them—

“I’m not like them. This isn’t like that—”

“Oh no? Seems like it is where I’m standing. I always knew you were a whore for a big cock. I never thought you were so stupid—”

Slap!

This time, the strike isn’t cathartic. There’s a rage behind it. My hand stings. Joshua staggers. “What the fuck—”

“Get the fuck out!”

He takes a step forward. I tense. Am I really going to have to defend myself against my own husband? I shift, my judo instincts kicking in when Eleanor clears her throat by the French doors. Behind her stands her husband.

“Please leave the premises, Mr. Smith.” Eleanor lifts her phone. “Or do I need to call the authorities?”

He looks from Eleanor and Ronald to me like we’re so beneath him. He turns his head and spits. “Fine. Whatever. Your fucking life.”

He starts to walk away, but pauses just before he rounds the bend. Turning back to me, he says, “And just when the Dawning Foundation thought it got past its last scandal. Wonder what the press’ll make of this...”

When he’s gone, I nearly collapse. Eleanor is there, collecting me in her arms and giving me strength. I weep as she pats my back and shushes me lovingly. “There, there.”

“I haven’t cried in, like, a decade, and this is what? Three times today?”

Eleanor is crying, too, but there’s a relief to it. I want to laugh and sob and everything in between.

“No one’s counting but you, dear.”

She releases me, but doesn’t step away. I shake out my hands, like I’m flicking away water. “I’m so... I’m so amped up.”

“Adrenaline.”

Like last night. Like when Thomas attacked me. And like last night, I feel a heat that starts deep inside of me and spreads until I’m a living flame. I want to kiss Eleanor. I want to do so much more to her.

“You need to go to him,” she says, like she can read my thoughts and see my intent. “We can reconnect in Vegas.” She winks, and I blush deeply at where my thoughts just were. She brushes my cheek. “Believe me, I have so many plans...”

As if to wipe all ambiguity off the table, she leans in and kisses me. Her lips are warm and soft, a perfect fit against my own. She smells of lilac and vanilla, and the skin beneath my fingers, where I caress her neck, feels paper thin.

Her tongue prods against my mouth. I open, letting her in, letting her slide her tongue along mine. Our noses brush. I feel her eyelashes brush against my cheeks and open my eyes. I see my smile in hers, brown and warm. She pulls back, giggling. Biting her lip cutely.

“Loads more of that. Only later. For now? Go to him.”

I’m smiling. I can’t stop smiling. Incredibly, I feel like I may start crying again. I nod and turn to leave before I do. I’ve already been told twice. I don’t need to be told again.

■

Paul

Options

“It’s gonna be tight, man. Like that girls night out times a thousand.” Mason polishes off his pint and sets it loudly onto the bar. He’s looking at me like he can’t believe I’m actually turning this down.

“You sure this is what she wants?”

“Mrs. Heller is fucking planning it all, man. She’s a natural born slut, that one.”

“And she’s my boss. I’ve told you, I’m out.”

He stares at me flatly, pursing his lips until they form a straight line. “I know you’ve been giving it to her. I was there at the gala, lest you forget.”

I can’t resist this opening. “I do remember rescuing her from some predator type.”

“Good thing, too. Once she went black—“

“Really?”

Mason has a good laugh and shares it generously. “So what about that blonde piece? Maybe Vegas is your opportunity.”

I try to hide my wince, but Mason’s an observant one.

“Ah, you got shot down? Sorry, bro, happens to us all.” He chuckles. “Well, not to me, but I’ve heard it happens to some of us.”

“It’s cool.” Although it really isn’t cool. What happened last night was transcendent. What I feel now is crushing. Yesterday I had a friend. Last night I had a lover. Now, I don’t think I have either. “Don’t think she’s cut out for the lifestyle her husband wants.”

“Or maybe you’re not the right guy.”

That cuts deep. This time, I laugh it off without him seeing. “Who knows?”

He claps me on the back. “You’ll bounce back. There’s a smokin’ brunette who’s been eye fucking you all night.”

I glance towards the other side of the bar, where a woman with the most amazing eyes sits. There’s something European about her look—short-cut bangs and cheekbones that border on the exotic. She looks fun.

I look right at her as I answer Mason. “Don’t worry, I noticed.”

He chuckles and stands. When he claps me on the back, his hand is like a vice. “You should reconsider Elie’s thing. It’s going to be over-the-top. You’re not going to want to miss this.”

“I’ll think about it.”

“Do that. I’ll send you the place and time. Just let me know if I should add you to the list.”

He leaves, and I wonder why I’m so resistant to this. Everyone involved is a consenting adult looking for a good time, Elie’s always been a good time, and this is something I know she wants.

“Order her another glass of whatever she’s having,” I say, keeping my eyes trained on the brunette.

“Coming right up, Paul,” a familiar voice responds. I turn to look, and the bartender who’d been serving Mason and I has been replaced by Nadia, from the other night. Beautiful, Indian-American Nadia with her silky hair and curvy body. She wears tight leather pants tonight and a top to show off her tits.

“Hey, there.”

“Hey yourself.” She pours a glass of white wine for the woman. “Where’s your blond friend?”

I shrug. “I’m not her keeper.”

Nadia frowns, but goes to deliver the drink. She’s put me off my game. I look back at the brunette as she receives my gift. She nods a thank you, holding it up to toast me from one corner of the bar to the other. I lift my whiskey and return it.

Nadia stays on that end, chatting with the woman. The two share a laugh as they keep looking at me. I let them gossip. Nadia’s not going to cockblock me. She’s not the type. Best case scenario, I leave with both of them. Having the two brunettes on their knees, sharing my dick between them could be just the thing I need to make me forget about...

I sigh and drink my drink. I need to stop sulking like a little bitch. This is not who I am. I’ve never let another woman do this to me, so why start now?

My phone rumbles. Speak of the devil.

[Manhattan:] Are you home?

It’s like Heather just reached into my chest and grabbed my beating heart in her warm hand. It rips something out of me—breath, color, energy.

[Me]: Not at home.

[Manhattan]: Ah. Okay.

I read the disappointment in that text. I’m not sure what her game is, but she’s

assumed that I'm out with someone else.

[Me]: Just killing time at Callahan's.

It feels apologetic. It feels off-brand from Paul the Bull. However she reads it, she doesn't respond right away, and the next thing I know, the brunette is approaching me.

"Thank you for the drink." Her accent is distinctly Scandinavian, in perfect harmony with her beauty. Her lashes curl up and away, reminding me of a cat. "I'm Sanna."

"I'm Paul."

She takes a seat at my side, and I'm immediately drawn to her legs, encased in tight, black jeans.

"You looked lonely over there, Sanna."

"And yet you didn't come join me."

"I didn't want to impose. Maybe you like being lonely."

The banter helps take my mind off Heather. Off last night. Off what could have been. It reminds me how much I enjoy this game—meeting new women, flirting with them, seducing them, and taking them home.

"Sometimes I do," she says with a playful smile. "But not tonight."

"Your accent... you're from Sweden?"

Sanna laughs. "Everyone always likes the Swedes, those fucking bitches."

"Norwegian then."

"Strike two, and if you say Finland next, I'm walking out of here."

For someone so petite, she's feisty. "Danish?"

"Congratulations."

"What do I win?"

"An opportunity to buy me another drink."

Here's where I would tell her that I have plenty of drinks at my place, which is just around the corner. I could already feel the tightness of her body riding my cock. I don't even need to close my eyes to see her sweat-coated nudity cast in the dim light of my bedside lamp. Sanna knows exactly what I am thinking, too. Her smile tells me that she's game.

"Nadia. Top us up?"

A flicker of disappointment darkens Sanna's face, there and gone as quick as a thought. I wonder about myself and my hesitation. Again. Like with Mason and his invitation to Eleanor's Vegas party. I am losing my edge, and spend the next drink half flirting with Sanna and half wondering what the fuck is wrong with me.

Now I know that a normal person wouldn't even be in a bar looking for sex after last night. A normal person would be home, licking his wounds or whatever. Processing it all, I guess. I'm not a normal person, though, so fuck all that.

I finish my drink in one gulp. Time to be me again. Holding my empty glass up, I look at Sanna. "That went quick."

She smiles, amused.

"I live just around the block." This feels like riding a bike. I don't even feel that twinge of nervousness. "Want to walk me home?"

Sanna's cheeks are even more pronounced as she smiles and stands. "I'm in the hotel next door. Shorter walk."

She'll be fun tonight. I pull some cash from my wallet and set it under my empty glass. Should be enough to cover us. "Lead the way."

“Oh, I should tell you one thing,” Sanna says. She holds up her hand, where a fat, diamond ring sits. “This a problem?”

“Is it for you?”

“Not at all.”

“Then it doesn’t matter to me.”

I put a hand on her lower back, feeling her muscles dance beneath my fingertips. I feel like I’m falling—falling away from something that could have been, falling back into the life I know, the only life suited for me.

The door to Callahan’s opens just as we reach it, and in steps Manhattan. She’s out of breath, her cheeks flushed and her golden hair mussed, like she was running. Our eyes meet, and guilt crashes into me. She takes in the scene—Sanna, her furtive smiles, my hand on her back.

I begin to say something, but Manhattan—Heather—shakes her head. No, don’t stop for me.

I feel caught in the momentum of the night and of my life. No matter how hard I try, this is who I am—and I am not what Heather wants or needs.

My phone buzzes as we step out into the crisp evening air. I’ve been drinking all night, and the alcohol is finally catching up to me. I want to be reckless. I want to take my frustration out on Sanna.

[Manhattan]: Have fun. Come back to the bar when you’re done. I’ll be here.

We are in the lobby of her hotel. The whole night is ahead of us. Fun awaits, and better, Manhattan would understand. But she is no longer Manhattan, is she?

“I’m sorry, but I need to deal with a thing.”

“What?”

I don't apologize. She'll be pissed, but whatever, I won't see her in the morning. I leave, heading back to Callahan's and to the woman I should be with.

It's crowded back in the bar. The evening's clientele has picked up and the drinks are flowing. Another man has already joined Heather. He's good looking in a generic way—dark hair, five-o'clock shadow, broad shouldered. He's me, if I'm honest, and if I'm really honest, watching her flirt is exciting.

She sees me as I enter, and I see the surprise on her face. She really was prepared to wait for me as I fucked Sanna. That's a special kind of friendship. I consider paying it forward and letting her flirt with this guy. There's a spot at the bar a few people down and I think about just going there to watch. It's a more compelling idea than I would have thought.

But I don't. Not tonight. No more games. No more flirting around the edges. I walk up to her and suddenly the man at her side fades into the background. Or maybe it's just that Heather is glowing so brightly.

She smiles. "That was quick."

"Want me to give you some space?"

"It's fine. Greg here was just leaving." She dismisses the guy that quickly, and he doesn't even have the balls to be offended. Just shrugs and disappears into the crowd.

Heather is suddenly closer, suddenly right at my side, and the whole world feels much better now. Much more manageable.

"I'm sorry I ran out this morning."

"I'm sorry I took advantage of you last night—"

"No. Don't apologize for that. Don't ever apologize for last night."

That warms my heart. "It felt pretty special to me, too."

"I kind of left my husband."

"What?"

She casts her gaze away. “Just now. Yeah, I know. I still can’t believe I did it.”

“You didn’t do that for me, did you?”

She rolls her eyes. “You men want everything to be about you. No, this was my decision. You were just a small part of it.”

“You really know how to make a guy feel special.”

“Keep trying to make this about you and you’re just going to end up disappointed.”

This is the banter that I almost lost. I will never put that at risk again. “Want to talk about it?”

Heather takes a deep breath. “Yes, but not right now.”

I get that. I hold back, giving her space. She’ll come around, and when she’s ready, I’ll be there for her. “You have some place to stay?”

“Yeah. I’m staying in Eleanor’s sex suite.” I chuckle, but before I can come up with something witty, she adds, “But I was hoping to crash somewhere closer tonight.”

The way she looks at me, I see vulnerability in her for the first time. This is Heather letting her guard down. With me. I cherish this.

Still, I can’t resist a joke. “Well, Sanna, who I was just talking with, spoke highly of the hotel next door.”

Heather smirks and shakes her head. “Just take me back to your place, Paul.”

“There’s that option, too.”

■

To be Vulnerable

It was just last night that we'd gone home together, but the details of that journey are already hazy. We were both caught in the current of the moment, uncertain where it was going, only that wherever it was, we were going.

Tonight, now, holding her hand as we stroll through the city lights of this summer evening, there's more certainty—more inevitably. Enough that I feel something that I don't normally feel before a hookup. I feel anxious. The pressure to perform. To not disappoint. To live up to the myth of myself.

Yet all she has to do is look at me with those rounded cheeks and bright, blue eyes, and the anxiety melts away. This is Heather. This is Manhattan. This is where I should be.

I open the door for her, and she enters. Following, I head towards the bar when she grabs my hand and pulls me to her. Collecting me into her arms, she pulls me close, looks up at me, and smiles a smile that says, Kiss me.

Her lips on mine feel just as magical as the first time, back at Starlight Lounge, or the last time, leaving my apartment early this morning. I hold her, spin her, lift her into the room as things intensify. She sinks her nails into my shoulder blades and drives her tongue down my throat. I set her on the countertop and go for the hem of her dress. I need to see her again—see the body that will forever haunt me when she is not there.

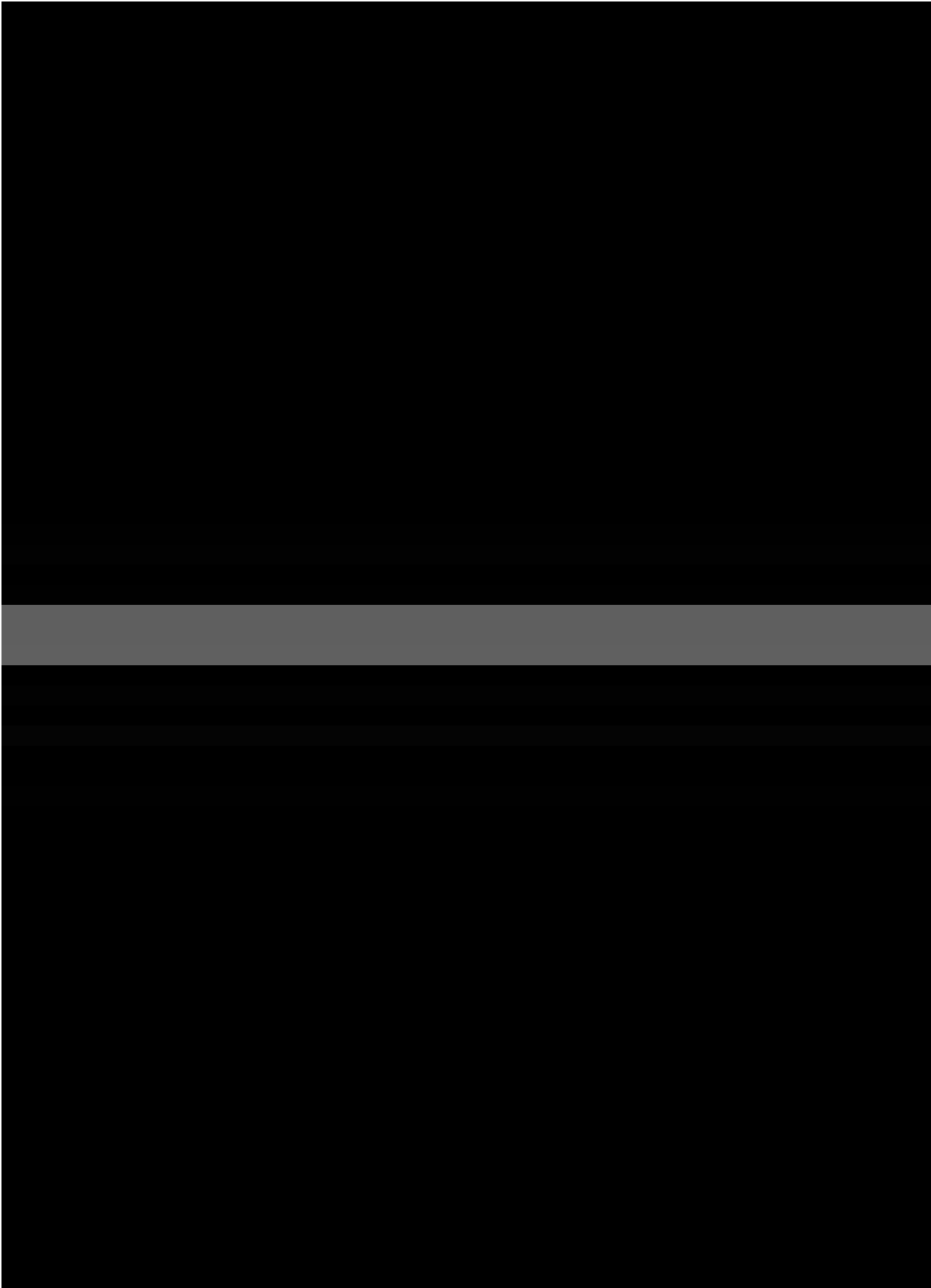
She helps me raise the dress over her head. Sitting back on the counter, her arms behind her, she cocks her head to one side. "Let's see those abs again, Paul."

"I knew you just see me as a sexy body." I pull my shirt off.

"Says the guy who's currently eye-fucking me."

She's wearing the same bra from last night—black lace and padded enough to turn her cleavage into something deep and tempting. Her panties are new, though—a black g-string that makes me think of something Eleanor would own—and she quickly pulls them off.

Her smooth mound glistens with her excitement, her clit swollen and her pussy lips beginning to part. “How about doing more than just looking.”



I cry out. His mouth feels so good on me. Like his kisses, Paul eats my pussy with confidence. In these blissful moments, as I lay back on his granite countertop and open my legs, I can give him this much—he's earned that confidence. Good lord, he's good at that.

I don't know what the future holds. I can see one with this man, but I don't know if that's what he wants. Tonight, right now, I don't care. I need his touch, and more thrillingly, he needs mine.

I grab his head, mussing his product-stiffened dark hair as I shove his face deeper into my lap. His nose crushes my clit as he thrusts his tongue into my pussy.

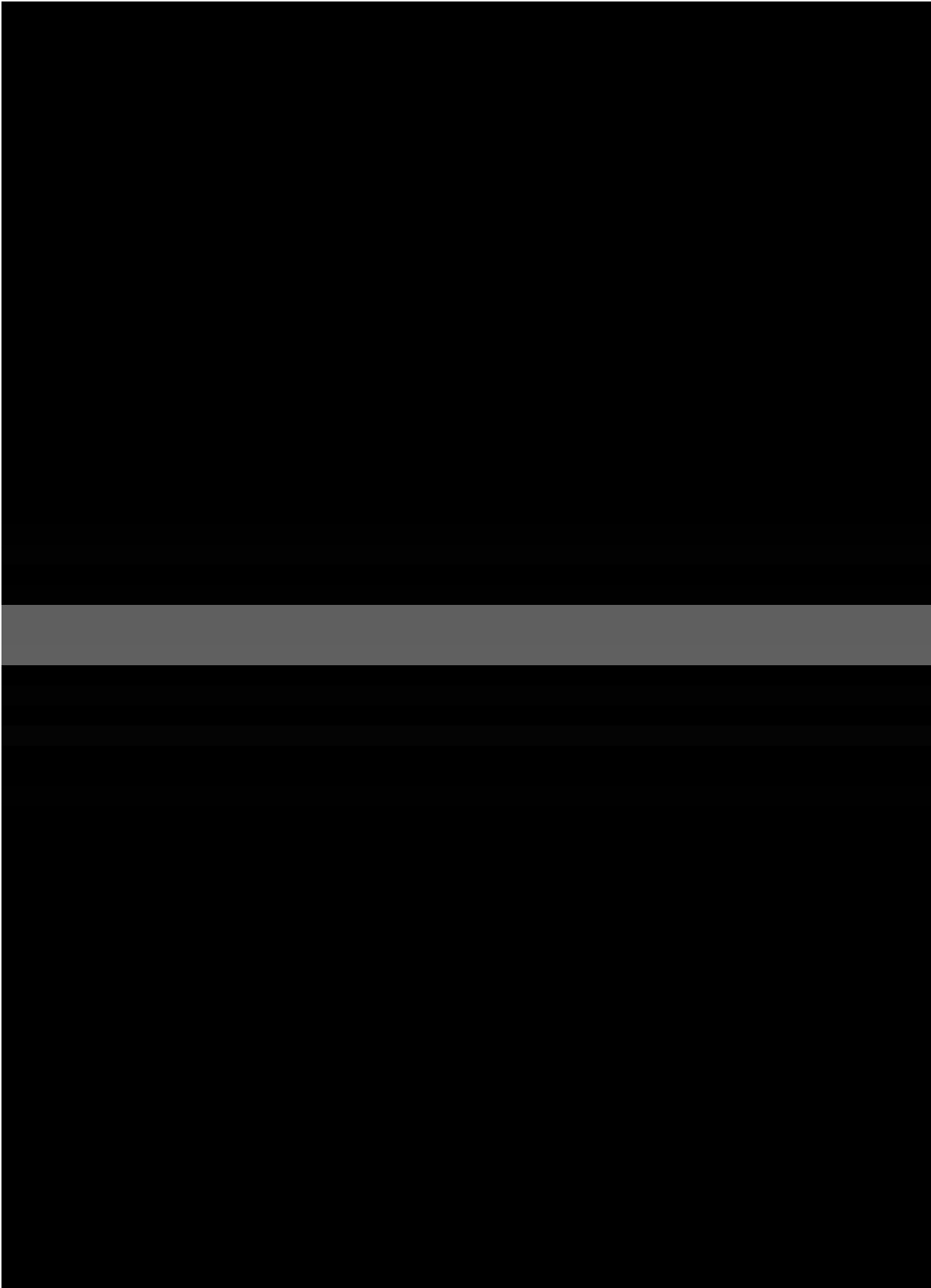
“Uh, uhhh, Paul. Eat me. Eat me!”

He steps up to the challenge, his tongue lashing my whole sex. He works his fingers into the mix, driving two deep into my cunt as his thumb teases the rim of my ass. I light up when he sinks it into my back door, a pincer attack on my sanity.

I push my bra up over my tits as I arch over the countertop, finding my nipples standing out and throbbing. I pinch and squeeze and twist, the pain mixing with the overwhelming pleasure that Paul brings with his tongue and lips and fingers.

In the fog of my orgasm, he picks me up, slinging me over his shoulder. I laugh until my abs hurt. We enter his bedroom, already tidied up after last night. His bed is made. The clothes he left on the floor tossed into the hamper.

Always ready to bring some slut back home, the cynical part of me thinks. The rest of me giggles inside. Tonight, you are that slut.



Heather can fuck. Not just that, but she likes to fuck. It's as much a sport for her as it is for me. She rides me, reverse cowgirl, her heart-shaped ass bouncing to the quick tempo of her rolling hips. The tiara tattoo dances, the looping black ink filigree almost tribal. I admit I like the girl spot tattoo, especially on a woman as classy and put together as Heather. Hell, if I was a chick, I'd probably have a tramp stamp, too.

"That's it, baby. Ride that cock." I slap her ass cheek, leaving an imprint of my hand. "You feel so...good."

"Mmm..." She plants her hands on the tops of my thighs, digs her knees into me like I'm a fucking horse, and squeezing me into a full-on gallop. I grab her hips, helping her drive harder, deeper, longer. She's not fucking me. I'm not fucking her. We do this together. We are one.

Sweat builds and breaths grow short. My balls tighten, and I hear the pitch of Heather's cries shift. She's close, too, and I want to share this moment.

"Come on, Manhattan. Let go. Let..." I'm so close. My voice is shaky. "...go!"

I can't hold out any longer. I dig my fingers into her haunches, feeling her pelvis bone. I yank her back. She squeezes down on me with everything she has—her legs, her hands on my thighs, her pussy around my cock. She presses down on me, driving my dick as deep as it can go as it swells and swells and—

"OH YES!!"

Our cries lace together, breaking down into throaty groaning and hard panting. I release everything I have, and she receives. Arching back, she's beautiful like that, her skin glistening and her hair a cascade of damp, golden locks.

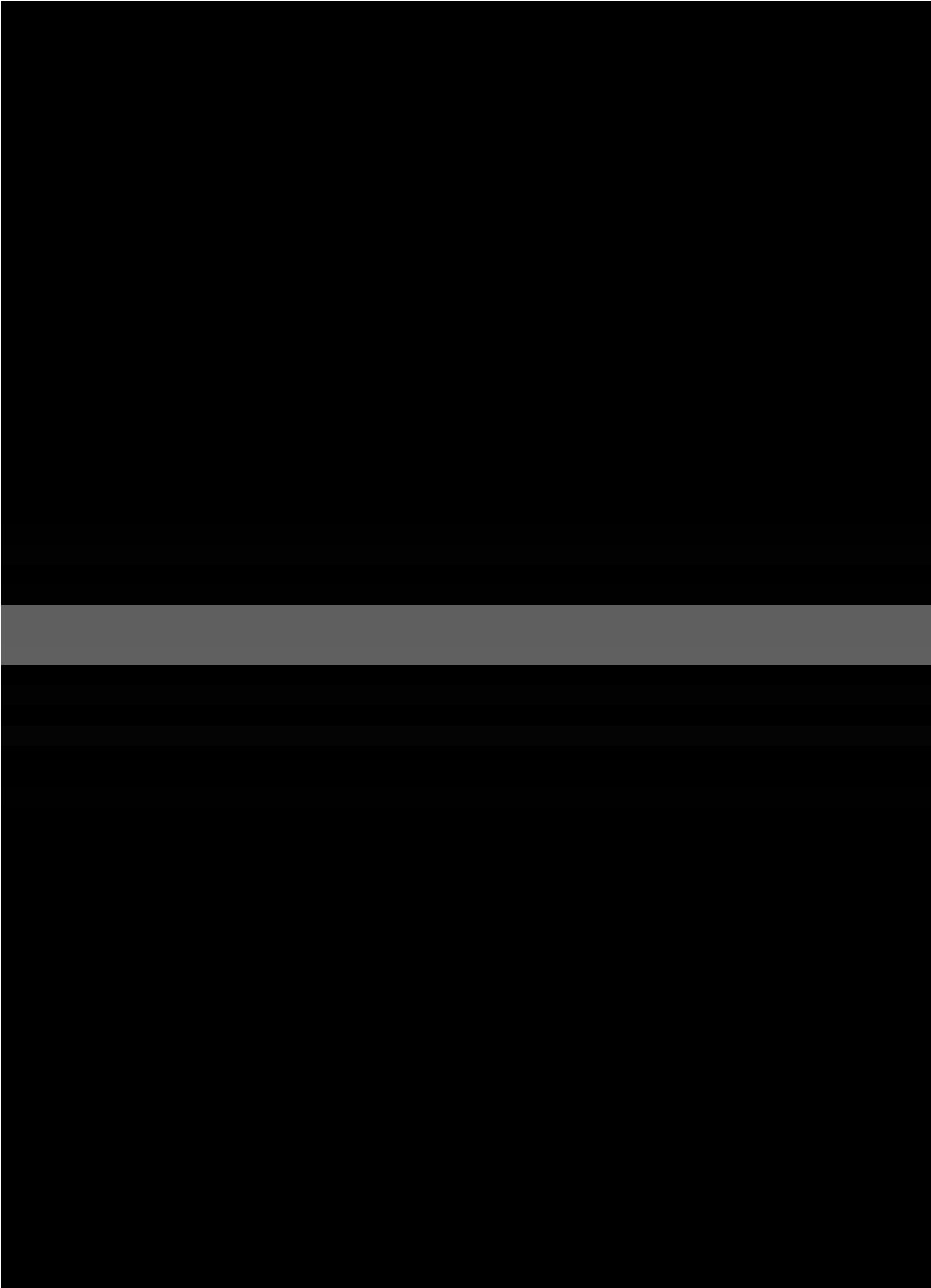
She folds forward as the climax recedes, resting her cheek on my calves as she shudders out the last throes. I flop back, closing my eyes and trying to hold on to this sense of peace.

I don't expect it to last. Just like last night, I wait for her to come to her senses, to realize who she's with, to once again leave me all alone.

It will happen. Maybe not now. Maybe not tonight. But someday. I need to keep my guard up and just enjoy what we have for as long as we have it.

She lifts up and looks over her shoulder at me, smiling as she tucks her hair over her ear. Warmth floods me.

Just enjoy it, Paul.



Lying naked and on my back with Paul's Egyptian cotton sheets kicked to the end of the bed, I stare up at the ceiling. Paul's at my side, his head propped up on an elbow as he makes circles along my rib cage, just below my bare breasts.

This is the moment when I turn to Paul and tell him all the things I just told Eleanor. Where I unburden myself from my past so we can build a future together. Where I say, I was a slut. I got off fucking men for money. I am not the woman you think I am.

It's all the things that I was too afraid to tell Joshua. Now, as I think about the future—about a future I could have with Paul—I'm afraid all over again. Is this the cycle of my life? To bounce from one unhealthy relationship to the next? I know how it happens. I'm so scared of anyone seeing past the woman I want them to see.

"What's on your mind?"

Paul looks reluctant to even ask the question. It's weird, seeing him looking... shy. I laugh before I can stop myself, and his mask is once again up.

He runs his hand up over my breast. My nipple begins to stiffen at his touch. "If you're weighing round two versus going home, I would highly recommend round two."

The banter, I realize, is his coping mechanism, just as much as it is mine. We could go on. I enjoy it. It's fun and harmless and fills the time in between all of the out-of-this-world sex. There's nothing wrong with that, and maybe that's all I need right now. It's too early to say that I'm even rebounding.

But this is Paul Sharpe. Jameson. A friend. And...

"You need to stop trying to control it all. It's okay to show emotion. It's okay to be vulnerable. It's okay to want things that maybe, perhaps, you shouldn't want."

Eleanor is right. I need to stop this cycle.

With a deep breath, I turn to Paul. I meet his eyes. I don't look away. He studies me, curious and wary. Maybe he just wants a fuck buddy. Maybe Joshua's right,

he only ever became my friend so he could get in my pants. But it's time to take a risk. Time to tell him my story.

“Paul, there are some things I need to tell you...”

The end of book four of Bull's Eye.

Acknowledgments

This one's been in the works for so long, there's no way I can thank all the people that I need to thank, so let me hit the highlights.

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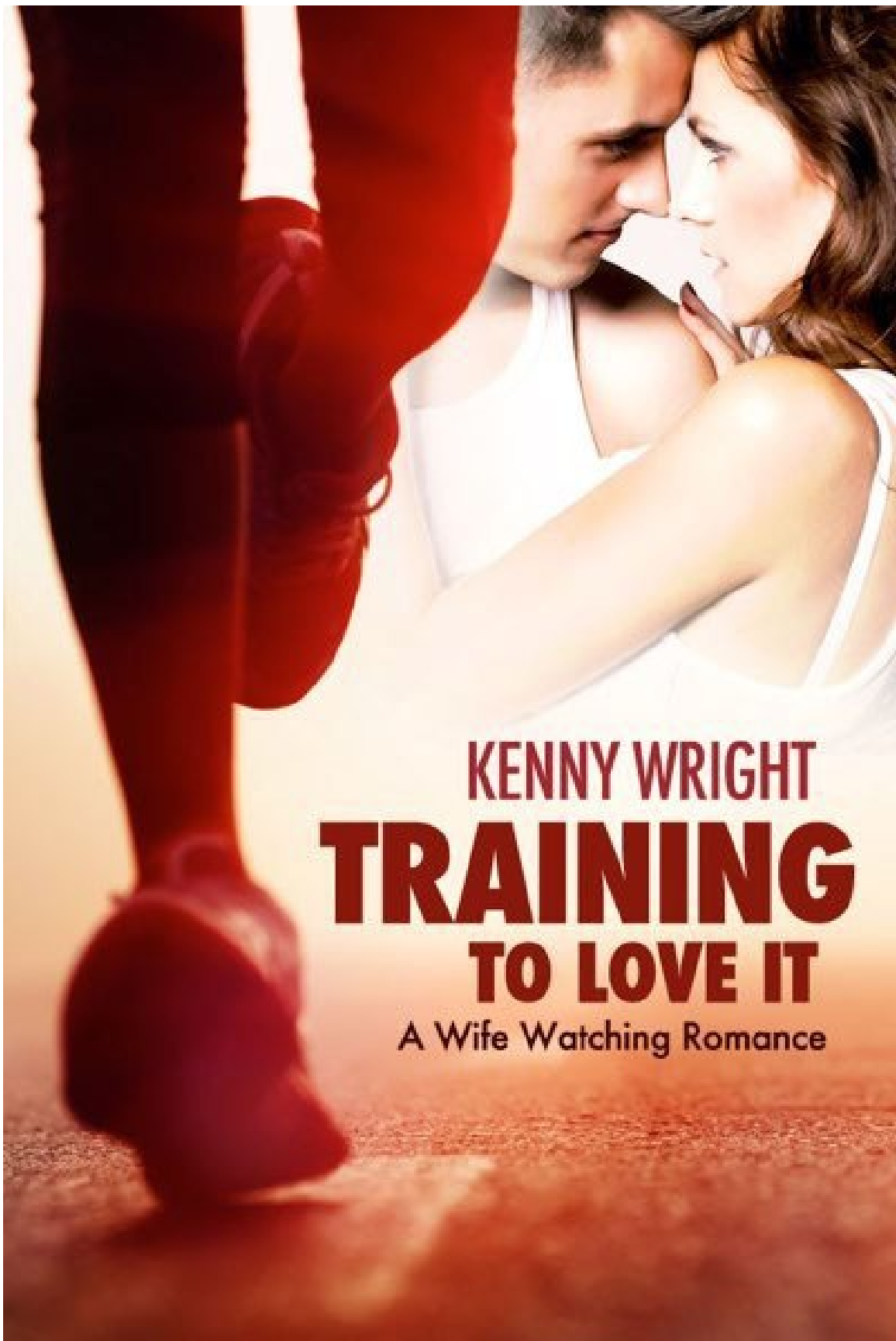
And thanks to you, reader, for not only paid to read, but took the time to read, and if there's one thing I've learned over the years, time can be a much scarcer resource than money.

Cheers!

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A Wife Watching Romance

Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

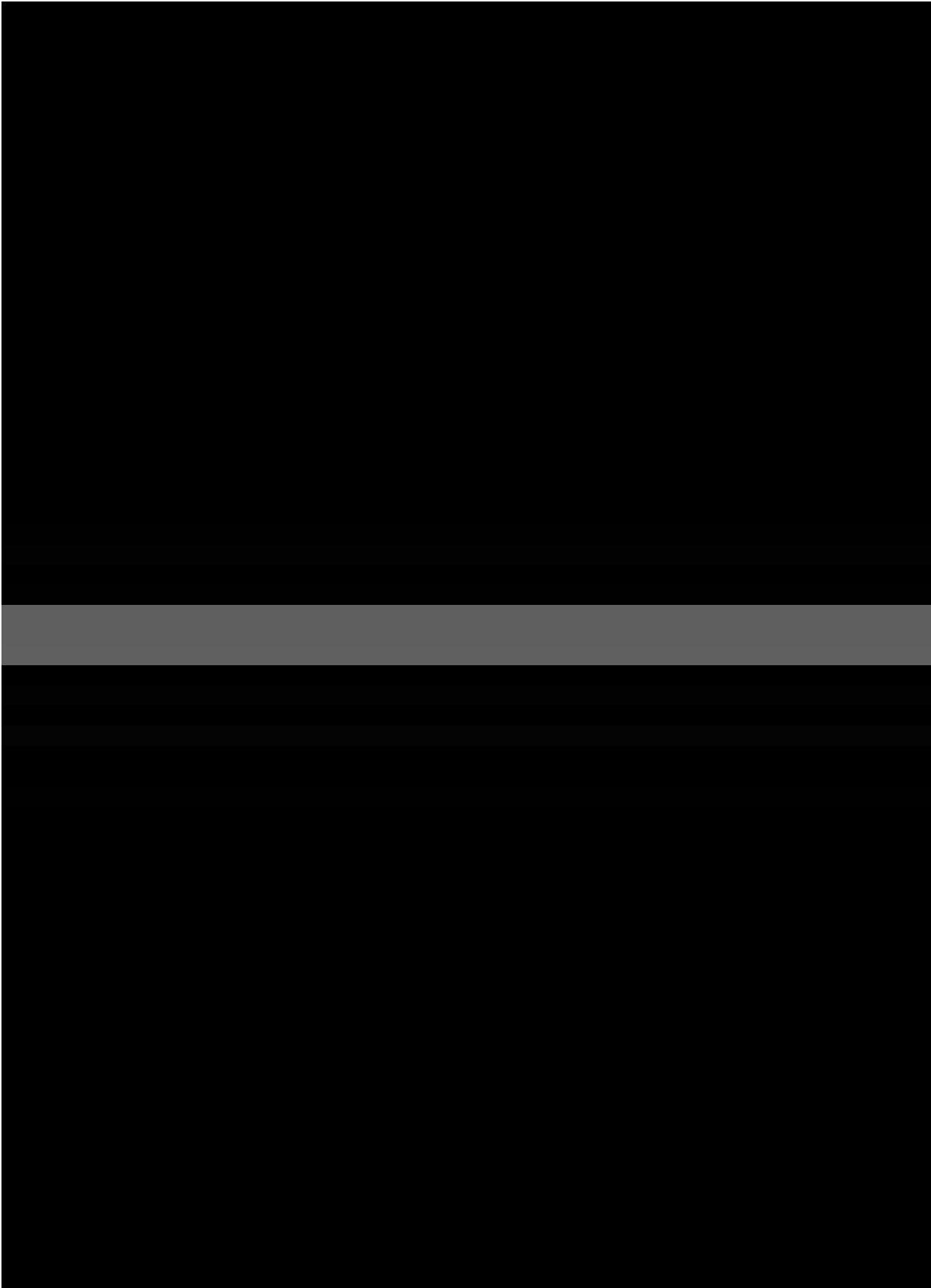
When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time he thinks of Erin with AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

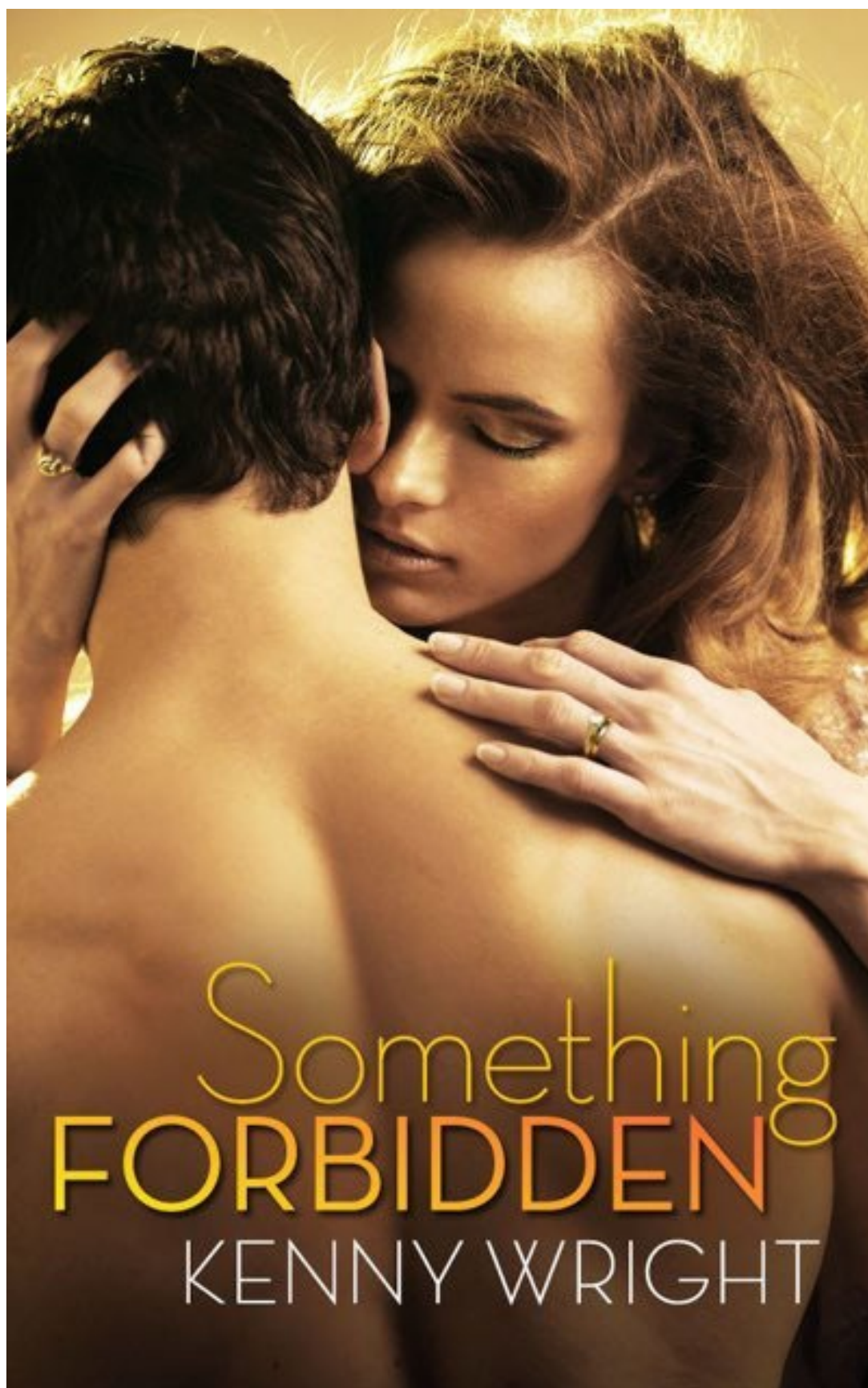
Training to Love It

Training to Love It 2

Training to Love It 3



Forbidden Series (2 books)



Something
FORBIDDEN

KENNY WRIGHT

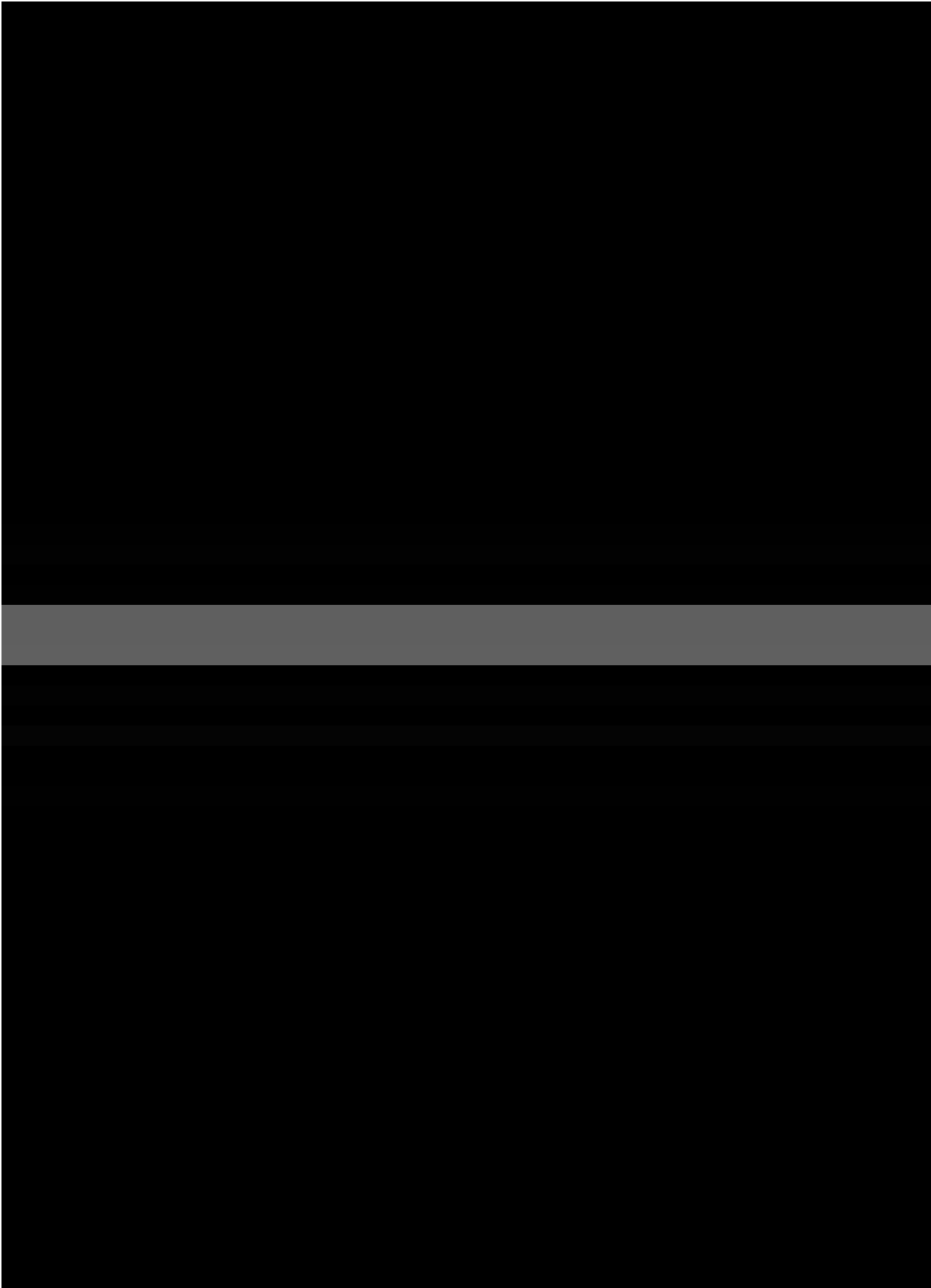
Wife-watching. Swinging. Consensual infidelity. These are not concepts that Maxwell Callahan understands, let alone fantasizes about. Max has a great life: husband, father, successful bar owner. He has no plans to shake it up.

And then he witnesses a couple play a dangerous game of pick-up in his bar: the wife gets picked up, the husband watches. A seed takes root and starts to grow. What would it be like to watch his beautiful wife, Katie, in the same situation?

Smart, successful, yet a little conservative, he never thought Katie would entertain such an idea...until she does. This suburban couple is about to take a wild ride as they turn fantasy into reality. Don't miss this marital adventure as Katie and Max try something forbidden.

[*Something Forbidden*](#)

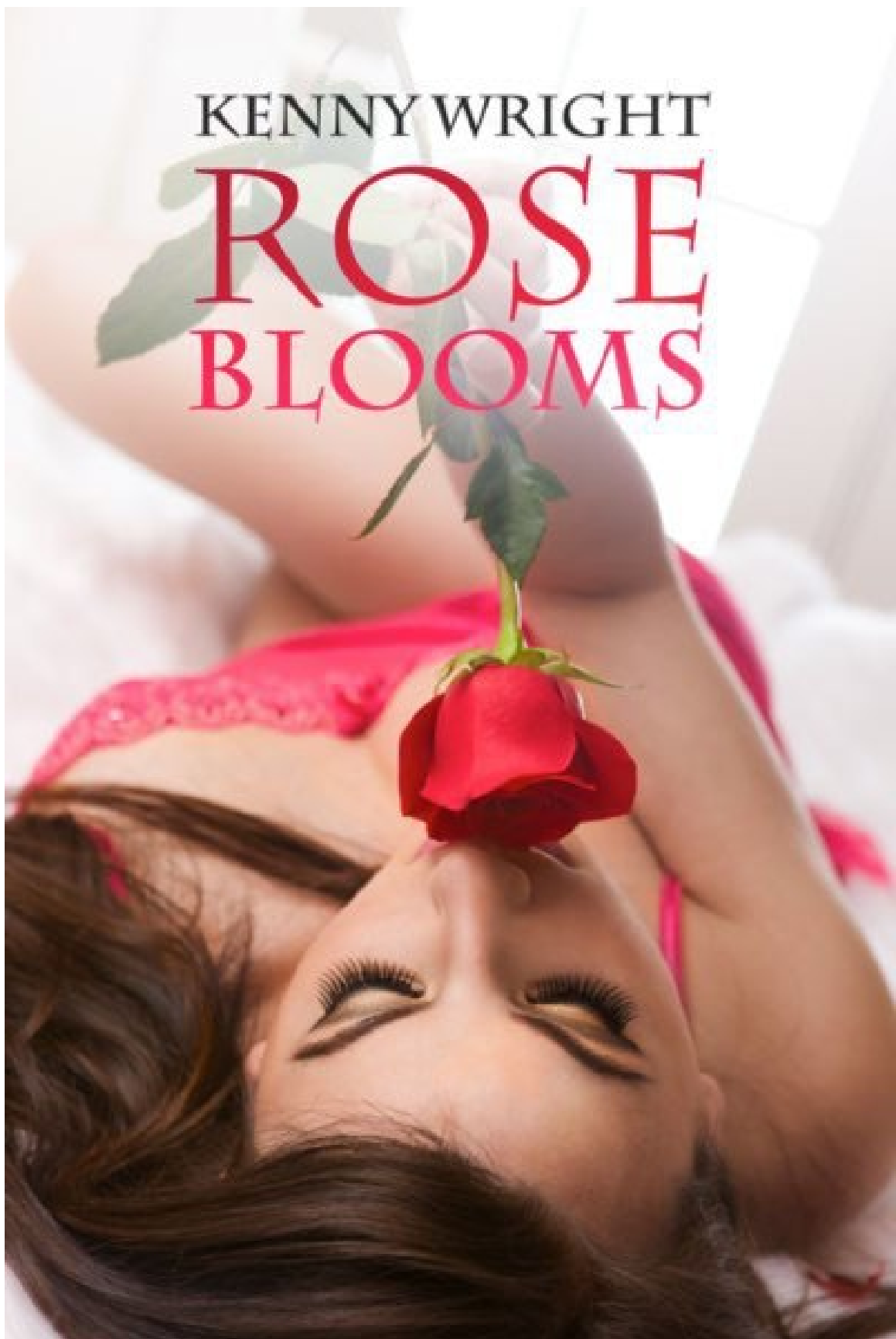
[*Nothing Forbidden*](#)



Rose Blooms

KENNY WRIGHT

ROSE
BLOOMS

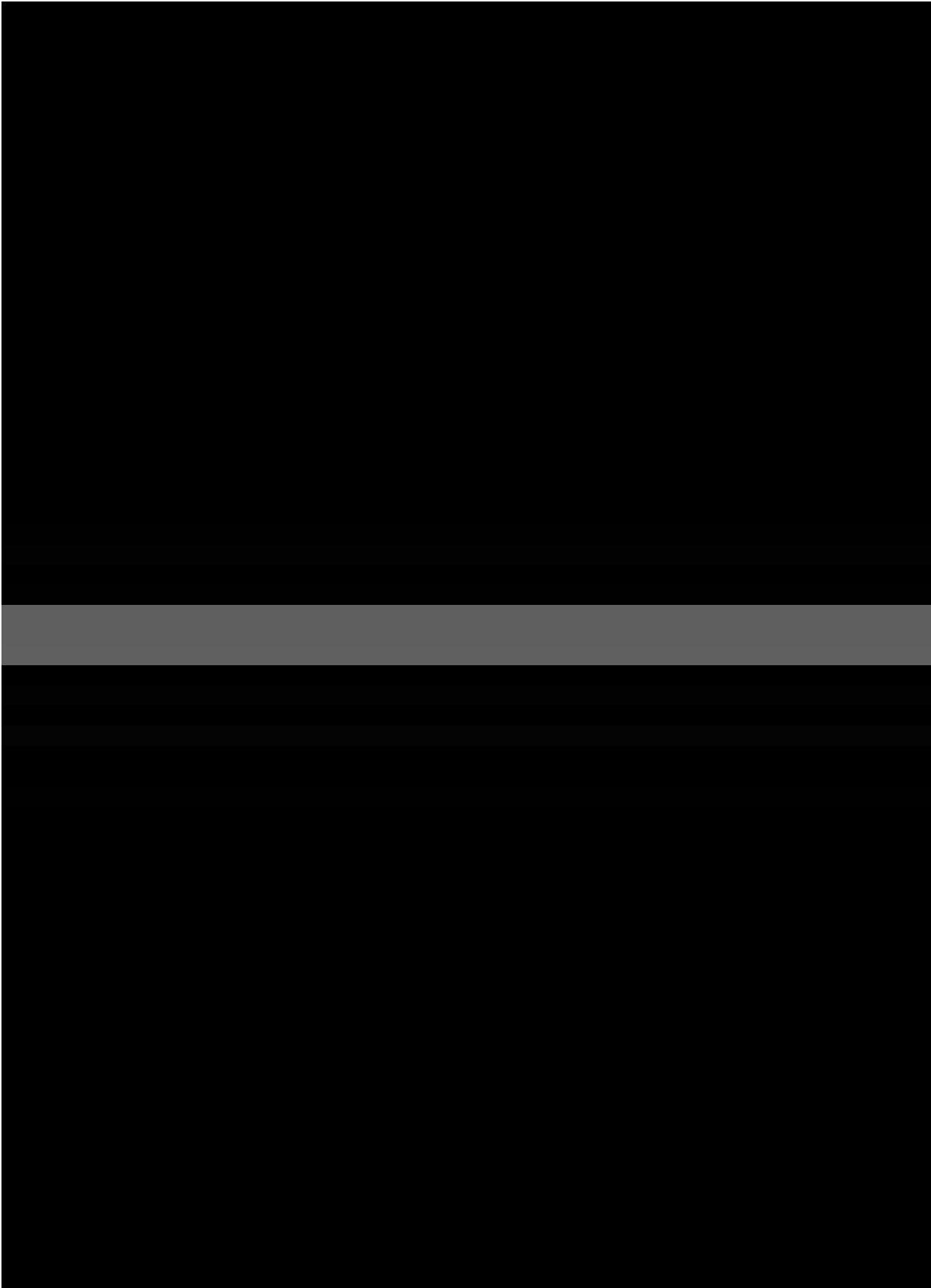


When Rose and Andy Shaw learn that their neighbors have separated, they are shocked. Jordan and Louis always seemed so...normal. Like them. Only their neighbors weren't normal. Louis has a dark fantasy, one that eventually pushes his marriage to the brink. He wants to share his wife, Jordan, beautiful and blonde, with other men.

Andy and Rose are reminded of a time early in their relationship, when their sex life was riskier and things were more exciting. When a new man enters their lives and starts to push Rose's buttons, they wonder if they are more similar to their neighbors than they want to believe.

Find out what happens when Louis's fantasy rubs off on Andy and Rose discovers that Jordan has secrets of her own. Discover how vibrant this rose blooms.

[Find Rose Blooms online](#)



Annie's Affair

A man and a woman are shown in a close embrace. The man is leaning over the woman, and they are both looking at each other. The woman is smiling and has her hand near her face. The man is looking down at her. The background is dark and out of focus.

ANNIE'S AFFAIR

A CHEATING WIFE NOVEL

KENNY WRIGHT

She cheated, and it turned him on.

Travis never thought his wife would cheat on him. Never considered it once in nineteen long years of marriage...until Rick entered their lives.

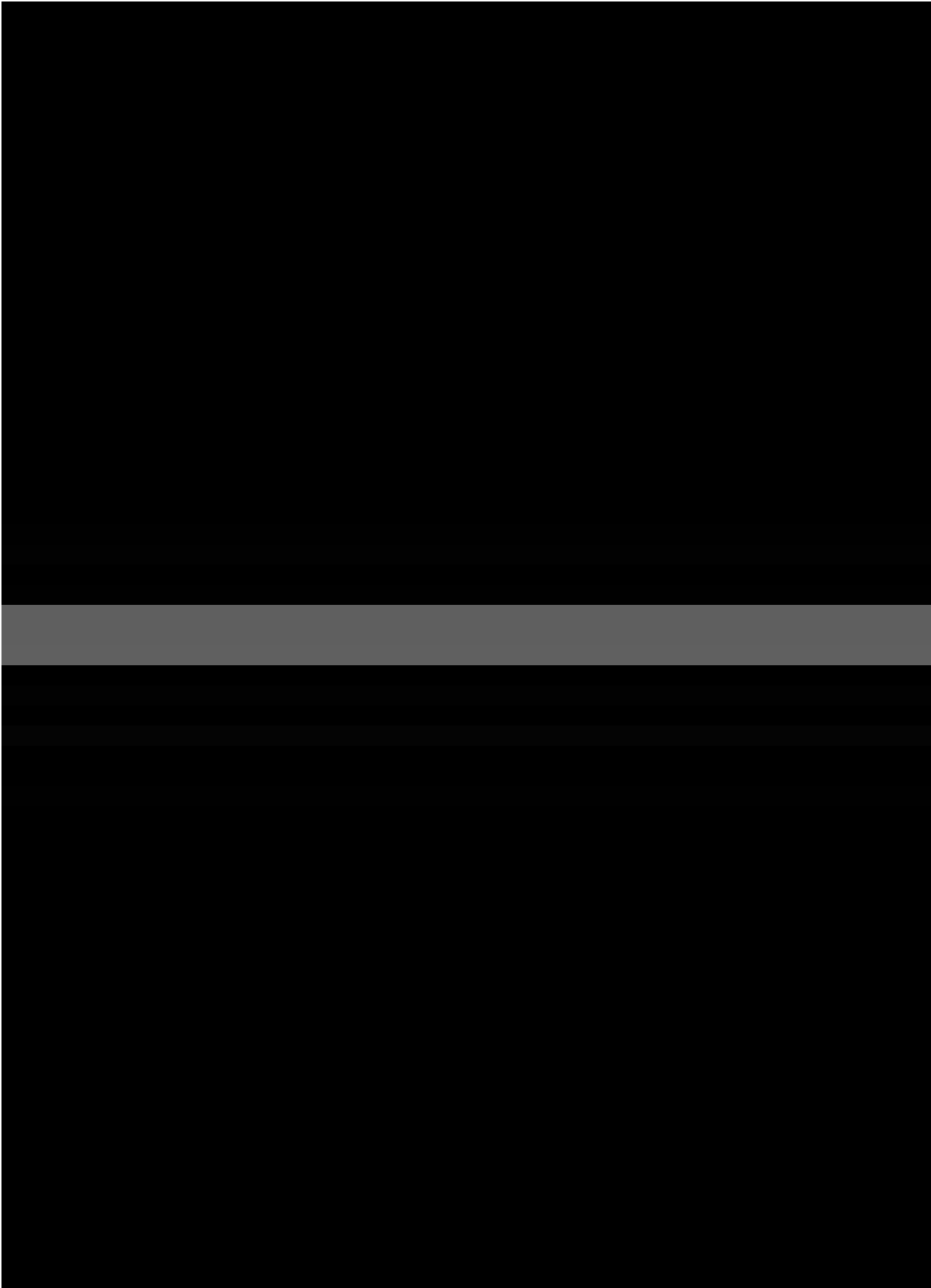
Travis never thought an affair would turn him on...until he found Annie's diary and started reading about his wife's attraction to her new, younger editor. Confident and attractive, Rick made his intentions clear. He wanted Annie, and she responded. She was tempted. She was attracted. She was conflicted.

Suddenly, Travis is able to see Annie the way Rick does—the way he used to before his perception was dulled by the long years of marriage. Annie is an attractive, smart, fun woman, with an adventurous side ready to be unleashed.

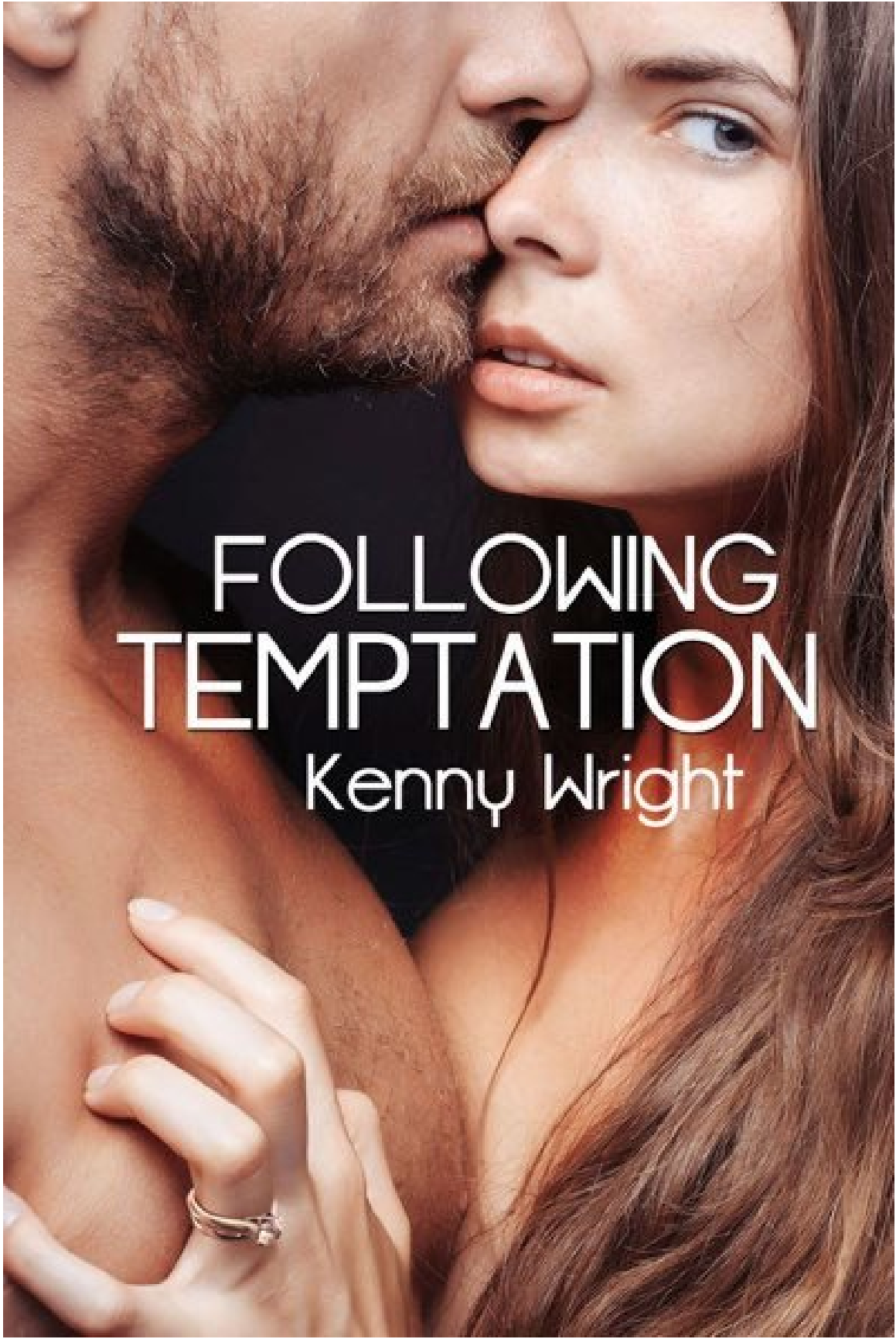
Travis never thought he'd want to watch his wife sleep with another man...until he did. And then it became his obsession.

Annie's Affair follows Travis as he witnesses his wife fall into the arms of another man, and becomes just as complicit in the betrayal as his wife.

[Find Annie's Affair online](#)



Following Temptation

A romantic close-up photograph of a man and a woman. The man, on the left, has a full brown beard and is leaning towards the woman on the right. They are about to kiss, with their lips just inches apart. The woman has long, wavy brown hair and is looking directly at the camera with a soft expression. Her hand is visible, resting on the man's chest, wearing a simple ring. The background is a plain, light color.

FOLLOWING TEMPTATION

Kenny Wright

Temptation waits just around the corner. Follow and see where it leads.

Life is good for Michael and Laura Richards, if a little stale. That is, until Michael follows his neighbor, Dane, to the house of the married Jessica, and watches Dane take full advantage of the voluptuous brunette. Michael shouldn't watch, but he can't stop himself, and the veneer of his sleepy suburb peels away to reveal its naughtiness.

Michael confesses the adventure to his wife, Laura, and the couple embarks on a journey of sexual awakening, following Dane and Jessica into a world that is as uncomfortable as it is irresistible. But there are layers within layers, and when Laura befriends Jessica and learns that not everything is as straightforward as it seems, just how far is she willing to follow her neighbor? Prepare yourself for a tale of voyeurism, naughty neighbors, sexy wives, and illicit temptation.

[Find Following Temptation online](#)

Browse all my books at kennywriter.com, hotwifebooks.com, or any major online bookstore.

About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.

